

72nd BPSC PRELIMS

प्रहार

Test Series

Test- 08

Medieval History

Solution

English



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BPSC TEST-8 (SOLUTION)

Q 1. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Palas and the Pratiharas clashed with each other for control of the area extending from **Banaras to south Bihar**, which possessed rich resources.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The Rashtrakutas clashed with the **Pratiharas**, not the Palas, for the overlordship of Malwa and Gujarat.
- **Additional related facts:**
 - ✓ The ultimate symbol of sovereignty in north India was **Kanauj**, which implied control over the upper Gangetic valley and its rich agricultural and trade resources.
 - ✓ Palas: Founded by **Gopala** around AD 750, the empire dominated eastern India. Dharmapala briefly occupied Kanauj, but after a defeat by the **Pratiharas** near **Mongyr**, his successor **Devapala** focused on expanding into **Pragjyotishpur (Assam)** and parts of **Orissa**.
 - ✓ The Pratiharas: Initially based in Bhinmal, they gained prominence under **Nagabhatta I** by resisting Arab incursions. **Bhoja** (AD 836) recovered Kanauj, making it their capital for a century, while his successor **Mahendrapala I** extended the empire into Magadha and north Bengal.
 - ✓ The Rashtrakutas: Founded by **Dantidurga** with their capital at **Malkhed (Manyakhet)**, they dominated the Deccan for almost two hundred years. Rulers like **Dhruva** and **Govinda III** defeated the Pratiharas but withdrew to the Deccan, acting as a cultural and economic bridge rather than permanently annexing the Ganga valley.

Q 2. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Following the death of Muizzuddin in 1206, Qutbuddin Aibak succeeded him and ruled the newly established Turkish domains from Lahore.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Drawing on Primary Textual Sources, Minhaj-i-Siraj's Tabaqat-i-Nasiri specifically praises Aibak's extreme generosity, famously granting him the title of Lakh Bakhsh (giver of lakhs).

- **Statement 3 is correct:** By fiercely rejecting Yalduz's claims, Aibak severed links with Ghazni, preventing India from being drawn into volatile Central Asian politics.
- **Statement 4 is incorrect:** Aibak ruled exclusively from Lahore until he died of injuries from a fall while playing chaugan (polo) in 1210. It was his successor, Iltutmish, who subsequently transferred the capital to Delhi.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Strategic Geography (Standard Academic Histories): Operating from Lahore was not merely a preference but a strategic necessity. Aibak needed to maintain a heavy presence in the northwest to guard against rival Ghurid commanders, especially Tajuddin Yalduz, who claimed suzerainty over Delhi from Ghazni.
 - ✓ Despite being the de facto independent ruler of northern India, early Sultanate numismatics show that Aibak rarely struck coins in his own name or formally assumed the legal title of Sultan, initially maintaining a degree of formal deference to Ghurid sovereignty.
 - ✓ Although he ruled from Lahore, Aibak initiated the construction of the Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque near the Qutub Minar in Delhi to mark the Turkish victory. This early Indo-Islamic monument repurposed pillars from demolished local temples to build the cloister surrounding its courtyard.

Q 3. Ans. B

Explanation:

The Vijayanagara Empire was successively ruled by four distinct dynasties over three centuries:

1. **Sangama Dynasty (1336–1485):** The foundational dynasty established by the brothers **Harihara I and Bukka I**.
2. **Saluva Dynasty (1485–1505):** Founded by the powerful regional commander **Saluva Narasimha**, who usurped the throne to save the weakening empire from internal rebellions and external invasions (an event known as the **First Usurpation**).
3. **Tuluva Dynasty (1505–1570):** Founded by **Vira Narasimha** following the assassination of the last Saluva ruler (the **Second Usurpation**). This dynasty represents the imperial zenith of Vijayanagara and produced its greatest sovereign, **Krishnadevaraya**.

4. **Aravidu Dynasty (1570–1646):** Founded by **Tirumala Deva Raya** (brother of Aliya Rama Raya) following the catastrophic destruction of the capital at the **Battle of Talikota (1565)**. The Aravidus ruled over a gradually declining and fragmenting empire from new capitals at Penukonda, Chandragiri, and Vellore.

Q 4. Ans. A

Explanation

- **Option A is correct:** Farid Khan (Sher Shah Suri) was assigned the administration of the Sasaram pargana by his father, Hasan Sur, who held this specific jagir and it was here that young Farid gained his foundational administrative and revenue management experience.
 - **Option B is incorrect:** **Chunar** was acquired much later in his political career, secured not through an administrative grant from his father, but by strategically marrying **Lad Malika**, the wealthy widow of the fort's former commander, **Taj Khan Sarangkhani**.
 - **Option C is incorrect:** Jaunpur served as Farid Khan's primary centre for higher **education**, where he spent his early years studying **Arabic** and **Persian literature**, but he did not exercise administrative authority over the city during his youth.
 - **Option D is incorrect:** **Kalpi** was a distinct territory located further west and possessed no connection to Hasan Sur's initial jagir holdings.
 - **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ During his tenure managing Sasaram, Farid Khan successfully curbed the influence of local zamindars and implemented strict measures to protect the peasantry from arbitrary and illegal tax exactions.
 - ✓ Due to domestic disputes, specifically the influence of his father's Indian slave-girl (stepmother), Farid was eventually forced to relinquish his administrative position over the pargana.
 - ✓ Following his displacement, Farid travelled to the imperial court of **Sultan Ibrahim Lodi** at Agra to formally request the transfer of his father's jagir into his own name.
 - ✓ Sultan Ibrahim Lodi initially rejected this request, citing Farid's contentious relationship with his father as grounds for dismissal.
- systematically issued by the Portuguese **Estado da Índia** to Asian merchant vessels during the 16th century. Backed by the overwhelming artillery power of their galleons, the Portuguese enforced this protection racket ruthlessly; indigenous ships navigating without this purchased document were officially classified as hostile prizes and subjected to brutal confiscation, cargo seizure, or deliberate sinking by Portuguese armadas.
- A **Dastak** was a commercial **free-transit pass** heavily utilised and notoriously abused after the pivotal 1717 royal decree of Emperor Farrukhsiyar, by the British East India Company to illegally bypass inland customs duties and local transit tolls within the highly lucrative province of Bengal.
 - A **Farman** represented an official **imperial decree** or royal mandate, such as the famous 1632 "Golden Farman" issued by the Sultan of Golconda, which formally granted foreign entities like the English East India Company specific legal rights, territorial concessions, or highly favourable trading privileges.
 - A **Hundi** was a traditional indigenous **financial instrument** functioning as a sophisticated bill of exchange, heavily utilised by prominent regional banking networks (such as the Jagat Seths) to securely transfer commercial capital across vast distances without risking the physical overland transportation of gold or silver bullion.

Additional facts:

- ✓ To enforce the Cartaze system and physically monopolise Asian maritime trade routes, Portuguese strategists under **Afonso de Albuquerque** strategically captured critical geopolitical choke points, most notably establishing fortified control over **Malacca** (1511) in the east and **Hormuz** (1515) in the Persian Gulf.
- ✓ The entire administrative, bureaucratic, and licensing apparatus for this naval system was heavily centralised at Goa, which had been captured from the **Bijapur Sultanate** in 1510 and subsequently served as the capital of the Portuguese seaborne empire.
- ✓ The issued passes contained strict commercial limitations; the Estado da Índia explicitly prohibited rival Asian merchants holding a Cartaze from transporting highly lucrative royal monopoly commodities, specifically spices (including pepper), drugs, dyes, arms & ammunition, and war horses.
- ✓ The geopolitical supremacy of this naval

Q 5. Ans. A

Explanation:

- The Cartaze was a compulsory **naval pass**

extortion system was so absolute during the sixteenth century that even the massive imperial pilgrim ships of the Mughal Empire (such as the royal vessel **Rahimi**) were structurally compelled to acquire a pass to ensure safe transit to Mecca.

- ✓ To physically intercept smugglers attempting to bypass these regulations, Portuguese naval squadrons heavily patrolled the western Malabar coast, leading to decades of sustained naval warfare with the indigenous **Mappila** merchants and the fleets of the **Zamorin** of Calicut.

Q 6. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Pietra Dura** (Italian for “hard stone”) is the highly specialised lapidary technique of precisely cutting, polishing, and seamlessly inlaying highly colored, semi-precious stones into a carved base matrix of solid white marble. This exact technique, indigenously referred to in Persian court chronicles as **Parchin Kari**, reached its absolute aesthetic zenith under the direct architectural patronage of **Emperor Shah Jahan**.
- **Fresco** (murals executed upon freshly laid lime plaster) is fundamentally a painting technique rather than a lapidary one. While extensively utilised in earlier Mughal structural interiors, such as the palaces at Fatehpur Sikri built under Emperor Akbar, it does not involve the physical inlay of stone.
- **Stucco** (intricately carved lime plaster) was heavily utilised throughout the Delhi Sultanate and early Mughal periods to create deep geometric and floral relief work on ceilings and interior arches, but it completely lacks the structural integration of hard, semi-precious gems into a solid stone matrix.
- A **Jali** refers to a perforated, intricately carved stone lattice screen heavily utilised in Indo-Islamic architecture to facilitate passive cooling (ventilation) and permit viewing without compromising privacy (*purdah*). While Shah Jahan commissioned spectacular marble jalis (such as the octagonal screen surrounding the royal cenotaphs in the Taj Mahal), it is a reductive carving technique, not an inlay process.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ While perfected under Shah Jahan, the first extensive, large-scale application of Pietra Dura in Mughal India was executed in the **Tomb of Itimad-ud-Daulah** (commissioned in 1622 by Empress Nur Jahan in Agra), representing the critical architectural transition phase between

red sandstone and pure marble.

- ✓ The imperial workshops sourced specific semi-precious stones from across the Asian continent to achieve the vibrant inlay colours, most notably importing deep blue Lapis Lazuli from the **Badakhshan** region of **Afghanistan**, **Carnelian** from **Gujarat**, and **Jade** from **Chinese Turkestan** (Xinjiang).
- ✓ The thematic focus of Mughal Pietra Dura was overwhelmingly botanical, featuring hyper-realistic floral sprays and arabesque patterns that were heavily influenced by the influx of illustrated European botanical herbals into the Mughal court via **Jesuit missionaries**.
- ✓ Demonstrating direct European artistic exchange, the marble baldachin behind the emperor’s throne in the **Diwan-i-Am** (Hall of Public Audience) at the Red Fort in Delhi features a famous Pietra Dura panel depicting the Greek mythological figure **Orpheus** playing a lute, executed utilising imported Florentine inlay plaques.

Q 7. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Before Firoz Shah’s reign, the Jizya (the Islamic poll tax levied on non-Muslim subjects, or **zimmis**) was practically amalgamated with the **Kharaj** (general land tax). Firoz Shah Tughlaq was the first ruler to strictly enforce it as a completely independent, distinct tax category with its own dedicated collection mechanism.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** According to **Shams-i-Siraj Afif’s** Tarikh-i-Firoz Shahi, previous Sultans of Delhi had historically exempted Brahmins from paying this tax. Heavily influenced by orthodox Ulema, Firoz Shah abolished this customary privilege. Afif records that when the Brahmins of Delhi violently protested this imposition by fasting at the palace gates, the other Hindu castes eventually compromised and agreed to pay the required tax on their behalf.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Firoz Shah governed his fiscal policy strictly according to orthodox Islamic law (Sharia). He officially abolished over 20 miscellaneous, **non-Islamic cesses** (**abwabs**), declaring that the state would only collect the four taxes explicitly sanctioned by the Quran: **Kharaj** (land tax), **Zakat** (charity tax on Muslims), **Jizya**, and **Khums** (1/5th share of war booty).

- ✓ The Sultan actively utilised the burden of the Jizya as an overt state instrument to encourage religious conversion. He issued public proclamations stating that anyone who embraced Islam would be immediately and permanently exempted from the tax, which led to a significant wave of conversions among the lower economic classes.
- ✓ Jizya was regressively tiered based on the wealth of the non-Muslim subject. It was divided into **three distinct income classes**, paying **40, 20, and 10** silver tankas respectively, while women, children, and the disabled were entirely exempt.

Q 8. Ans. D

Explanation:

- Emperor Akbar explicitly commissioned the immense Buland Darwaza (Gate of Magnificence) to commemorate his remarkably rapid and decisive military conquest of the prosperous maritime province of Gujarat in 1572–1573. This lightning campaign, where Akbar famously marched from Agra to Ahmedabad in just nine days, permanently secured Mughal access to the highly lucrative Arabian Sea maritime trade networks.
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ Standing at a staggering elevation of 54 meters from the ground level, the Buland Darwaza functions architecturally as the imposing southern entrance to the imperial Jama Masjid complex.
 - ✓ The structural facade of the gateway integrates a massive central semi-dome—a classic Persian Iwan design, while the interior features a famous Arabic inscription quoting Jesus that emphasises the transient nature of the world, reflecting Akbar's evolving theological inclusivity.
 - ✓ The imperial complex also houses the Panch Mahal, a distinct five-story columnar pavilion featuring precisely 176 intricately carved pillars that gradually diminish in size on each consecutive floor, structurally mimicking the tiered design of a traditional Buddhist vihara (monastery).
 - ✓ Another notable architectural feature of the city is the intricately carved central pillar of the Diwan-i-Khas (Hall of Private Audience), which possesses a massive lotus-shaped corbelled capital upon which the emperor's central seat was suspended.

- ✓ Despite the immense financial and architectural investment, Akbar was forced to abandon Fatehpur Sikri as the primary imperial capital in 1585, permanently relocating the court to Lahore due to a combination of severe local water shortages and pressing strategic military threats from the Uzbeks on the northwestern frontier.

Q 9. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Malik Ambar**, the powerful regent of **Ahmadnagar**, made extensive use of Maratha forces in his military system. However, these Marathas were not integrated into the formal imperial hierarchy as mansabdars nor were they granted revenue assignments like jagirdars. Instead, they functioned as **loose auxiliaries**, meaning they were irregular troops who provided military support without being part of a rigid administrative structure. Their mobility, local knowledge, and guerrilla-style tactics made them particularly effective in the Deccan's political and military environment.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The rise of the Marathas in the Deccan was closely tied to the political conditions of the time. They occupied significant positions in both **Bijapur** and **Ahmadnagar**, and their influence grew steadily as the Mughal Empire expanded southwards, prompting both sides to seek their support. Prominent Maratha families such as the **Mores**, **Ghatages**, and **Nimbalkars** exercised considerable local authority, although they had not yet established large, centralised states like the Rajputs.
 - ✓ **Shahji Bhonsale** emerged as an important figure who, for a time, acted as a **kingmaker** in Ahmadnagar and resisted Mughal expansion. Following the treaty of **1636**, he entered the service of **Bijapur** and shifted his focus to **Karnataka**, where he attempted to carve out a semi-independent principality at Bangalore. Similar tendencies toward regional assertion were visible in the actions of **Mir Jumla** on the **Coromandel coast** and the **Sidis** along the western seaboard.
 - ✓ These developments created a fragmented but opportunity-rich political landscape, which ultimately enabled Shivaji to consolidate power and lay the foundation of a strong Maratha state around Poona.

Q 10. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement A is correct:** The mahasabha or sabha operated mainly in Brahman settlements known as agraharams or Brahmadeya villages. These villages contained large tracts of rent-free lands granted to Brahmans and enjoyed substantial autonomy in local administration.
- **Statement B is incorrect:** Members of the executive committees were not selected through hereditary succession. Educated persons possessing property qualifications were chosen either through rotation or by drawing lots, a system often referred to as the Kudavolai system. Members generally retired after three years, indicating a structured and partially elective mechanism rather than a purely hereditary one.
- **Statement C is correct:** The Chola village administration had highly specialised committees. These committees supervised different branches of administration, such as:
 - ✓ assessment and collection of land revenue,
 - ✓ maintenance of law and order,
 - ✓ judicial work,
 - ✓ irrigation management.
 - ✓ Among them, the tank committee was especially important because irrigation formed the backbone of Chola agrarian expansion. Tanks, wells, canals, and river waters, especially from the Kaveri, were carefully regulated for agriculture.
- **Statement D is correct:** The mahasabha possessed wide financial and administrative authority at the village level. It could levy local taxes, raise loans for public purposes, distribute newly cultivated lands, and exercise ownership rights over such lands. These powers reflected the high degree of autonomy enjoyed by Brahmadeya villages under the Cholas.

Q 11. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Option A is correct:** Following the collapse of central Lodi authority, Bahar Khan Lohani declared himself the independent ruler of Bihar (assuming the title Sultan Muhammad) and employed young Farid Khan in his service, formally bestowing upon him the title “Sher Khan” after Farid reportedly killed a tiger single-handedly to protect him.
- **Option B is incorrect:** Mahmud Lodi was a brother of Ibrahim Lodi and a rival Afghan political leader whom Sher Khan temporarily, and somewhat

reluctantly, supported much later during the anti-Mughal coalition that culminated in the **Battle of Ghaghra (1529)**.

- **Option C is incorrect:** Ibrahim Lodi was the Sultan of Delhi who perished at the **First Battle of Panipat (1526)**; while Farid Khan served in his military briefly, the Sultan never bestowed this specific title upon him.
- **Option D is incorrect:** **Islam Shah (Jalal Khan)** was the capable **second son of Sher Shah Suri**, who succeeded his father to the imperial throne in **1545**.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Recognising his administrative competence, Bahar Khan Lohani elevated Sher Khan to the critical position of deputy governor (**Vakil**) of Bihar.
 - ✓ Bahar Khan also appointed Sher Khan as the personal tutor (**Ataliq**) and guardian to his minor son, **Jalal Khan Lohani**.
 - ✓ The rapid political ascent of Sher Khan deeply alienated the established Lohani nobility, who successfully poisoned Bahar Khan’s mind against him, temporarily forcing Sher Khan out of Bihar.
 - ✓ Following his expulsion, Sher Khan briefly sought refuge in the military camp of the newly arrived Mughal Emperor Babur, participating in the Mughal campaign against **Chanderi** in 1528 to study Mughal military tactics firsthand.
 - ✓ Sher Khan subsequently defected from the Mughal camp and returned to Bihar, where he resumed his service to the Lohani dynasty and eventually seized complete control of the state following Bahar Khan’s death.

Q 12. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correctly matched:** A Khanqah was a Sufi hospice, lodge, or monastery. It served as the focal point of a Sufi order’s spiritual and social life, where the Pir (master) resided with his family, trained his murids (disciples), and offered shelter and food to travellers and the poor.
- **Pair 2 is correctly matched:** Ziyarat refers to the widespread practice of pilgrimage to the tombs (dargahs) of revered Sufi saints. Devotees from all social and religious backgrounds undertook this journey to seek the spiritual grace (barakat) of the deceased saint.
- **Pair 3 is incorrectly matched:** Malfuzat (literally meaning “uttered”) refers to the compiled, recorded

conversations or discourses of a Sufi master, highly valued as spiritual literature. State-sponsored land grants or revenue assignments were instead known as jagirs, inams, or **madad-i-ma'ash**.

- **Pair 4 is correctly matched:** Futuh translates to unsolicited charity or unasked-for gifts. Orders like the early Chishtis, who practised severe asceticism and refused guaranteed state funding or land, relied entirely on futuh to run their khanqahs and feed the destitute.

- **Additional facts:**

- ✓ One of the most historically significant compilations of Malfuzat in India is the **Fawa'id-al-Fu'ad** (Morals for the Heart). It was compiled by **Amir Hasan Sijzi** and contains the discourses of the great Chishti saint **Shaikh Nizamuddin Auliya**.
- ✓ Closely tied to Ziyarat is the celebration of Urs (literally "marriage"). It is the death anniversary of a Sufi saint, celebrated as the moment the saint's soul finally united with the Supreme God.
- ✓ Alongside Malfuzat and Maktubat (letters), another crucial literary genre in Sufism is **Tazkiras**. These are **biographical accounts** or memoirs of Sufi saints (such as the **Siyar-ul-Auliya**), which provide immense historical data about the social life of medieval India.
- ✓ The Khanqah featured an open kitchen (langar), which operated daily and served free food to everyone, regardless of their caste, religion, or social status, heavily promoting communal harmony.

Q 13. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Statement 1 is correct: The Pala empire was founded when Gopala was elected king by the notable men of the area to end the prevailing anarchy.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Gopala was not born into a high or royal family, and he unified Bengal while bringing **Magadha** (not Malwa) under his control.
- **Additional related facts:**
 - ✓ The foundation of the Pala empire is placed around AD 750. Gopala laid the initial groundwork and ruled until AD 770, when he was succeeded by his son, **Dharmapala**.
 - ✓ While Gopala established the base in Bengal and Bihar, it was the foundation he built that allowed Dharmapala to project Pala power outward, eventually holding a **grand darbar** at

Kanauj attended by vassal rulers from Punjab and eastern Rajasthan.

- ✓ The foundation of the dynasty secured a region with rich resources and well-developed imperial traditions (extending from Banaras to south Bihar), which became the power base for the Palas during the ensuing Tripartite Struggle against the Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas.

Q 14. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Assertion (A) is correct:** Iltutmish deliberately cultivated this corps of loyal military slaves (**mamluks**) to consolidate his fragile, newly established empire against rival **Ghurid** commanders like **Yalduz** and **Qubacha**. Ziauddin Barani's **Tarikh-i-Firoz Shahi** details that following Iltutmish's death in 1236, this oligarchy became "drunk with power." They transformed from loyal servants into kingmakers, successfully usurping the sovereign authority of the crown by assassinating uncooperative monarchs and installing weak puppet rulers.
- **Reason (R) is also correct:** **Tarikh-i-Firoz Shahi** mentions their strict racial exclusivity. The Chahalgani functioned as a closed Turkish brotherhood that fiercely protected its **monopoly** over the state apparatus. They violently revolted when **Raziya Sultan** attempted to elevate an **Abyssinian**, **Yaqut Khan**, and later resisted the rise of Indian Muslim converts (like Imaduddin Raihan).
- **R is not the correct explanation of A:** The Chahalgani's usurpation of monarchical power was fundamentally driven by the political vacuum left by Iltutmish's death and their inherent ambition to become the de facto rulers of the Sultanate, not just by their racial exclusivity. Their racism was a characteristic of their faction, but their usurpation was a result of unchecked political ambition in a destabilised state.
- **Additional Facts:**
 - ✓ To financially sustain these elite Turkish commanders without paying them direct cash salaries, Iltutmish formalised the **iqta system**. These nobles were granted the revenue-collection rights of vast territorial tracts, which heavily subsidised their personal wealth and private cavalry units, ironically giving them the military and economic leverage needed to challenge the crown later.

- ✓ The eventual destruction of the Chahalgani was orchestrated by one of their own. **Balban**, a former member of “The Forty,” understood their threat to the monarchy perfectly. Upon taking the throne, he employed a ruthless “**blood and iron**” policy, using poison and public execution to physically eliminate his former peers and fully restore the divine prestige of the Sultan.

Q 15. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Babur employed the Ottoman device at the First Battle of Panipat (1526). He lashed together hundreds of baggage carts with rawhide. This formation created a solid defensive barrier. Matchlock men fired safely from behind movable mantlets placed between these carts. This tactic effectively neutralised the numerical superiority of the Afghan army.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The Tulughma was not an artillery technique and was not acquired from the Safavid Empire. Babur learned this highly specialised flanking manoeuvre from the **Uzbeks in Central Asia**. It involved deploying highly mobile cavalry divisions to the extreme right and left wings. These cavalry units swept around to attack the enemy from the rear. This manoeuvre created a deadly pincer movement against the Afghan forces.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Babur’s artillery was commanded by two highly skilled master gunners. These gunners were named **Ustad Ali** and **Mustafa**.
 - ✓ Ibrahim Lodi deployed massive war **elephants** in his vanguard. These elephants panicked due to the deafening noise of the Mughal cannons. The terrified elephants stampeded backwards, crushing their own Afghan soldiers in the chaos.
 - ✓ **Ibrahim Lodi** was killed directly on the battlefield, and he remains the **only Sultan** of Delhi to die in combat.
 - ✓ This battle officially ended the Lodi dynasty.
 - ✓ This battle marked the definitive introduction of field artillery into large-scale North Indian warfare.

Q 16. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Assertion (A) is true:** The powerful political faction known as the Nur Jahan Junta, which had exercised near-absolute dominance over Mughal state

policies and administrative appointments since the royal marriage in **1611**, began to rapidly fragment and lose its supreme influence over the imperial court after the year of **1622**.

- **Reason (R) is true and correctly explains Assertion (A):** The decline in this political group’s power began after the death of **Itimad-ud-Daula** in **1622**, who had been a key stabilising figure. Soon after, serious disagreements emerged over who should succeed the emperor. Nur Jahan wanted her son-in-law, **Prince Shahryar**, to become the next ruler, as he was more likely to remain under her influence. In contrast, her brother **Asaf Khan** supported his own son-in-law, **Shah Jahan**. This disagreement broke their unity and created deep divisions within the group. As a result, Prince Khurram felt threatened and was pushed into open rebellion to secure his claim to the throne.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Born as Mehr-un-Nisa, Nur Jahan was previously married to the rebellious Afghan noble **Sher Afghan (Ali Quli Istajlu)**, who was killed in Bengal in 1607, after which she was brought to the imperial harem in Agra as an attendant to Akbar’s widow before eventually marrying Emperor Jahangir in May 1611.
 - ✓ Demonstrating her unprecedented political authority and deep integration into the sovereign functions of the state, Nur Jahan was the **only Mughal empress** to have her name minted alongside the emperor’s on imperial silver coins, and official royal decrees (farmans) were frequently issued bearing her signature alongside the imperial seal.
 - ✓ She actively patronised magnificent Mughal architecture, most notably commissioning the exquisite Tomb of **Itimad-ud-Daula** in Agra between 1622 and 1628, which marks a critical architectural transition by being the **first Mughal structure** built entirely of **white marble** and extensively utilising the intricate **pietra dura** (floral stone inlay) technique.
 - ✓ Following Jahangir’s death in October 1627 and the subsequent ascension of Shah Jahan, who, with the brutal military assistance of **Asaf Khan**, swiftly executed **Shahryar** and nullified Nur Jahan’s political influence, she was formally forced into retirement with a generous annual pension of two lakh rupees, spending her remaining years in **Lahore** overseeing the construction of Jahangir’s mausoleum at **Shahdara** before her own death in **1645**.

Q 17. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Timur (Tamerlane) utilised religion as a strategic pretext for his devastating campaign. He explicitly justified his invasion by proclaiming that the weakened Tughlaq Sultans were too lenient towards their non-Muslim subjects, thereby framing his brutal expedition of plunder as a holy war (jihad).
 - **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The reigning sovereign, Mahmud Shah Tughlaq, did not formally surrender or become a vassal. After his army was decisively routed outside the capital, the Sultan cowardly fled Delhi, seeking asylum first in **Gujarat** and later in **Malwa**. This abandonment left the citizens entirely undefended during the 15-day massacre and created an absolute political vacuum in northern India.
 - **Statement 3 is correct:** Timur's primary objective was the extraction of immense wealth and human capital. Before departing the devastated city, he spared the lives of skilled Indian carpenters, masons, and stonecutters, systematically enslaving and deporting them to Central Asia to construct his magnificent **Friday Mosque** and other monuments in **Samarqand**.
 - **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The immediate aftermath of the invasion was apocalyptic for Delhi; the destruction of granaries and the thousands of unburied corpses left in the streets triggered a massive famine and sweeping pestilence that plagued the city for months.
 - ✓ The invasion decisively shattered the geographical unity of the Delhi Sultanate. Seizing upon the absolute collapse of central authority, powerful provincial governors in **Gujarat, Malwa, and Jaunpur** rapidly declared **total independence**, fragmenting the empire into regional kingdoms.
 - ✓ Before retreating from the subcontinent, Timur appointed **Khizr Khan**, a former governor of **Multan** who had actively assisted the invading forces, as his viceroy over **Punjab, Lahore, and Dipalpur**. Khizr Khan would subsequently exploit this established power base to march on Delhi and found the **Sayyid Dynasty in 1414**.
- branched out from the Suhrawardi silsila. It was initially introduced to India by Shaikh Badruddin of Samarkand.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The Firdausi order was highly regionalised. Unlike other major orders, it reached the absolute zenith of its influence almost exclusively within Bihar.
 - **Statement 3 is correct:** The Firdausi order did not rely heavily on oral traditions. Its complex philosophy was systematically preserved through the **Maktubat**. These were extensive collections of letters written by the Shaikh to his disciples.
 - **Statement 4 is incorrect:** Shaikh Sharfuddin Yahya Maneri never relocated to the imperial capital of Delhi. He steadfastly remained in Bihar for his entire life. Furthermore, he explicitly refused the highly politicised religious title of Shaikh-ul-Islam.
 - **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Shaikh Sharfuddin was an erudite scholar. He successfully synthesised **Tariqa** (Sufi mysticism) with Sharia (orthodox Islamic law).
 - ✓ He firmly argued against abandoning orthodox duties. He taught that true spiritual realisation is impossible for a mystic who neglects the Sharia.
 - ✓ He was deeply influenced by **Ibn Arabi's** controversial philosophy of **Wahdat-ul-Wujud** (Unity of Being). However, he carefully moderated this philosophy to avoid heretical pantheism. This moderation made his teachings acceptable to orthodox Sunni scholars.
 - ✓ His most famous compilations are the **Maktubat-i-Sadi** (A Hundred Letters) and **Maktubat-i-Do Sadi** (Two Hundred Letters). He wrote these to his disciples and to the governor of Bihar.
 - ✓ Sultan **Muhammad bin Tughlaq** held him in immense esteem. The Sultan issued a farman (royal decree) to construct a magnificent khanqah for him in Bihar. The Sultan also assigned the revenue of a pargana for its upkeep.
 - ✓ His political influence continued after Muhammad bin Tughlaq. **Firoz Shah Tughlaq** specifically halted in Bihar to seek the Shaikh's spiritual blessings before marching on a military campaign to Bengal.
 - ✓ He is popularly venerated by the title **Makhdum-ul-Mulk** (Spiritual Master of the Realm).

Q 18. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Firdausi order originally

Q 19. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Option B is the correct:** In the comprehensive Deccan settlement of 1636, Shah Jahan extinguished the Nizam Shahi dynasty of Ahmadnagar and pragmatically divided its territories, granting the southern districts, including the Konkan and Poona, to the Adil Shahi ruler of Bijapur in exchange for his formal acceptance of Mughal suzerainty and an annual tribute of twenty lakh rupees.
- **Option A is incorrect:** Bijapur did not absorb the entire Ahmadnagar kingdom; instead, the Mughal Empire directly annexed the major, highly lucrative northern portions of the Nizam Shahi state, strictly limiting Bijapur's territorial expansion to create a manageable and pacified southern frontier.
- **Option C is incorrect:** Bijapur never surrendered its capital city or its sovereign core during the 1636 settlement, as the Adil Shah successfully retained complete internal administrative autonomy and the Mughals deliberately refrained from posting imperial administrators inside Bijapuri territory.
- **Option D is incorrect:** The treaty did not mandate the disarmament of the Bijapuri state or the imposition of Mughal commanders, fully allowing Bijapur to maintain its own independent military forces and artillery as long as it strictly adhered to the diplomatic terms of peace.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Following the successful conclusion of the 1636 treaties with both Bijapur and Golconda, Shah Jahan appointed his young son **Aurangzeb as the Viceroy of the Deccan**, a powerful administrative position he held for two distinct terms (1636–1644 and 1652–1657).
 - ✓ The **Qutb Shahi** kingdom of **Golconda** signed a parallel treaty of submission in **1636**, which explicitly required the Sultan to abolish the names of the **Safavid Shahs** of Iran from the **Friday khutba** (sermon) and replace them with the name of the Mughal Emperor Shah Jahan, while also paying an annual tribute of two lakh huns.
 - ✓ During his second viceroyalty, Aurangzeb actively collaborated with his highly capable provincial diwan, **Murshid Quli Khan**, to thoroughly reorganise the devastated Deccan agrarian economy by introducing **Todar Mal's Zabti** (measurement) system and standardising cash revenue demands across the region.

- ✓ The diplomatic settlement of **1636** effectively stabilised the Mughal southern frontier for nearly twenty years, temporarily securing the region and allowing Shah Jahan to confidently redirect his massive military resources toward his ambitious, though ultimately disastrous, Central Asian campaigns in **Balkh** and **Badakhshan** in **1646**.

Q 20. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Option A is correct:** According to the Archaeological Survey of India, Sher Khan captured the Rohtasgarh Fort in 1539, coinciding with his victory at the **Battle of Chausa**. Rather than launching a direct military assault against the resident Hindu chieftain, Sher Khan secured the stronghold through a tactical stratagem. He requested the fort's governor to provide temporary sanctuary for the women of his household, but systematically concealed armed soldiers inside the covered palanquins. Once the palanquins were permitted inside the gates, the concealed troops quickly overpowered the internal garrison, resulting in the fort's capitulation without a protracted siege.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Rohtasgarh possessed significant strategic value, subsequently functioning as Sher Khan's **primary treasury** and the secure depository for his accumulated military wealth.
 - ✓ Establishing firm control over this fortification in Bihar provided Sher Khan with a highly secure rear administrative base.
 - ✓ This regional stability directly facilitated his sustained westward military campaigns against Emperor Humayun, ultimately culminating in the pivotal battles of Chausa in June 1539 and Kannauj in 1540.

Q 21. Ans. C

Explanation:

- The Dutch East India Company (VOC) established its first Indian commercial trading factory at Masulipatnam on the Coromandel Coast in 1605, having successfully obtained a trading farman from the Qutb Shahi rulers of the Golconda Sultanate. The primary strategic objective of this coastal settlement was to procure finely dyed Indian cotton textiles (such as Kalamkari), which the Dutch subsequently exported as a highly lucrative barter commodity to exchange for cloves, nutmeg, and mace in the Indonesian archipelago (Spice Islands).

- Located on the western coast in the Mughal subah of Gujarat, Surat served as the site of the English East India Company's first permanent trading factory, officially established in 1613 via an imperial decree from Emperor Jahangir following the decisive English naval victory over the Portuguese fleet at the Battle of Swally (1612).
- While Pulicat emerged as a major Dutch stronghold on the Coromandel Coast, it was captured slightly later from the local Nayaks in 1610. It subsequently replaced Masulipatnam as the official administrative headquarters of the VOC's Coromandel Directorate and became the site of their heavily fortified military installation, Fort Geldria (1613).
- Cochin, situated on the southwestern Malabar Coast, initially functioned as the earliest massive Portuguese administrative headquarters (Fort Manuel) in India until it was strategically captured by Dutch VOC naval forces under Admiral Rijckloff van Goens in 1663, an offensive designed to physically monopolise the region's highly profitable pepper trade.
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ The Dutch East India Company, officially incorporated by the States General of the Netherlands in 1602 as the Vereenigde Oostindische Compagnie (VOC), was the world's first formal joint-stock company to issue public shares.
 - ✓ The English East India Company formally received its foundational royal charter, granting a 15-year monopoly on all Eastern trade, from Queen Elizabeth I on December 31, 1600.
 - ✓ In 1608, Captain William Hawkins arrived at Emperor Jahangir's court in Agra aboard the vessel Hector and was granted the prestigious Mughal rank of a Mansabdar of 400, though intense Portuguese diplomatic pressure at the court ultimately prevented him from securing a permanent factory license at that time.
 - ✓ Serving as the official royal ambassador of King James I, Thomas Roe arrived at Jahangir's court in 1615 and successfully utilised sustained diplomatic negotiations to obtain an imperial Farman granting the English explicit legal rights to establish fortified factories across the entire Mughal Empire.
 - ✓ The geopolitical trajectory of European colonialism fundamentally shifted following the 1623 Amboyna Massacre, during which

the Dutch Governor-General of the Moluccas (Herman van Speult) brutally executed ten English EIC merchants under forced confessions of treason.

- ✓ Consequently, expelled from the Indonesian spice monopoly, the English East India Company strategically shifted its entire commercial and military focus to the Indian subcontinent, heavily prioritising the mass export of regional cotton textiles, Gujarat's indigo, and Bihar's saltpetre.

Q 22. Ans. C

Explanation:

- Sikandar Lodi founded Agra on the banks of the Yamuna in 1504. He formally transferred the seat of the Delhi Sultanate there in **1506**. The explicit strategic objective was to maintain a tighter military grip over the turbulent Doab and actively suppress the defiant rulers of Gwalior, Dholpur, and Biyana.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The Sultan's original royal residence in this new capital was the brick fortification known as **Badalgarh** (which was later dismantled by the Mughals to build the current Agra Fort).
 - ✓ To standardise land revenue assessment across his newly consolidated territories, he introduced a uniform **32-inch** measurement yardstick known as the **Gaj-i-Sikandari**.
 - ✓ Despite his strict religious orthodoxy, he was a patron of literature who actively composed **Persian poetry** under the pseudonym **Gulrukhi**.

Q 23. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Option A is incorrect:** Rajaraja I initiated the Chola maritime expansion by conquering Northern Ceylon (Anuradhapura) and the Maldives (Munnir Palam Tivu). While he established the naval infrastructure necessary for imperial growth, his maritime activities were primarily focused on securing regional dominance over the Pandyas and Cheras rather than launching long-distance military expeditions against the Southeast Asian kingdoms.
- **Option B is correct:** Rajendra I (1014–1044 CE) executed a massive naval campaign in 1025 CE against the Srivijaya Kingdom, which controlled the Malaya peninsula and Sumatra. This expedition was a strategic response to Srivijayan attempts to

monopolise the maritime trade routes between India and the Song Dynasty of China. The Chola fleet captured several crucial ports, including Kadaram (Kedah), ensuring the safety of Indian merchant guilds like the Manigramam and Nanadesi.

- **Option C is incorrect:** Kulottunga I was a diplomat and reformer who famously abolished internal transit duties, earning the title Sungam Thavirtha Cholan. While he maintained significant commercial interest in the East and sent a large trade embassy of 72 merchants to China in 1077 CE, he utilised diplomatic channels and commercial treaties to facilitate trade rather than conducting aggressive naval warfare against Malayan territories.
- **Option D is incorrect:** Vijayalaya Chola was the 9th-century founder of the Imperial Chola dynasty who captured Tanjore from the Muttarayar chiefs. During his reign, the Cholas were a small regional power still emerging from the shadow of the Pallavas. They lacked the imperial treasury, advanced shipbuilding technology, and geopolitical reach required to project military power across the Bay of Bengal.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Following his successful naval conquest of the Srivijaya kingdom, Rajendra I adopted the prestigious title Kadaram Kondan (Conqueror of Kedah) to commemorate his victory.
 - ✓ The Chola navy was uniquely organised into different classes of vessels, including the Dharani (ships for coastal defence) and the Lola (heavy vessels designed for deep-sea combat and long-distance transport).
 - ✓ The Tiruvalangadu copper plates serve as a primary epigraphic record, providing a detailed account of the fleet's journey across the sea to capture 14 major Srivijayan ports.
 - ✓ Trade between the Cholas and China was so robust that a dedicated Chinese quarter and several Hindu temples were established in the Chinese port city of Quanzhou to serve Indian merchants.
 - ✓ The Chola administration used these naval expeditions to secure the "String of Pearls" across the Indian Ocean.

Q 24. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The brothers Harihara and Bukka began their political careers serving as treasury officials under the Kakatiya ruler

Prataparudra II of Warangal. Following the kingdom's fall to the Delhi Sultanate in 1323, they migrated and entered the service of the **Raja of Kampili**.

- **Statement 2 is correct:** When Muhammad bin Tughlaq conquered **Kampili** in 1327 to suppress a rebellion, the brothers were taken as prisoners of war to Delhi. They were forcibly converted to Islam and subsequently dispatched back to the Deccan by the Sultan as administrators to quell local Hindu uprisings.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Far from opposing them, the prominent Shaivite ascetic Vidyananya was the fundamental spiritual catalyst for their rebellion. He successfully facilitated their formal readmission into the Hindu fold through purification rites (shuddhi), providing them with the necessary religious legitimacy to throw off their Tughlaq allegiance.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The brothers strategically established their new capital city on the southern banks of the **Tungabhadra River**. It was initially named **Vidyanagara** (City of Learning) in explicit honour of their guru Vidyananya, before eventually becoming globally renowned as **Vijayanagara** (City of Victory).
 - ✓ Their dynastic name, **Sangama**, was not territorial but patronymic, adopted directly from the name of their biological father, **Bhavan Sangama**.
 - ✓ To further legitimise their unprecedented political ascent without provoking the hostility of established traditional Hindu monarchs, Harihara and Bukka initially refrained from assuming full imperial titles. They declared that they were ruling merely as the humble deputies of the patron deity **Sri Virupaksha**, famously signing all royal edicts in the name of the god.

Q 25. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correctly matched:** Khusrau Mirza, the eldest son of Jahangir, rebelled within the very first year of his father's reign (1606) and subsequently received a monetary blessing from the fifth Sikh Guru, **Guru Arjan Dev**, an act that deeply enraged the emperor, leading to the Guru's execution and Khusrau's being blinded.
- **Pair 2 is correctly matched:** Mahabat Khan, a

prominent and highly capable Mughal general who felt deeply marginalised and actively targeted by the rising political faction of **Nur Jahan** (the Nur Jahan Junta), staged a dramatic military coup in **1626**, successfully capturing Emperor Jahangir near the banks of the Jhelum river while the royal camp was en route to Kabul.

- **Pair 3 is incorrectly matched:** Prince Shahryar Mirza, who was married to Nur Jahan's daughter from her first marriage (Ladli Begum), did not rebel against Jahangir following Akbar's death; rather, he launched his brief, ill-fated war of succession in Lahore only after Jahangir's death in **1627**, where he was swiftly defeated, blinded, and executed by the forces of his brother, **Prince Khurram (Shah Jahan)**.
- **Pair 4 is correctly matched:** Prince Khurram (the future Emperor Shah Jahan) launched his major rebellion in **1622** because he adamantly refused Jahangir's direct imperial order to march to the difficult northwestern frontier and recover the strategic fortress of **Kandahar** from the **Safavids**, harbouring deep suspicions that **Nur Jahan** was deliberately trying to remove him from the political centre in Agra to secure the succession for **Shahryar**.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ To physically manifest his commitment to impartial royal equity, Jahangir commissioned the installation of the famous **Zanjir-i-Adl** (Chain of Justice) at the **Agra Fort**, consisting of sixty bells attached to a pure gold chain that any aggrieved subject could pull to demand direct audience with the emperor.
 - ✓ Upon his formal accession to the throne in 1605, Jahangir promulgated twelve definitive edicts (ordinances) designed to consolidate his authority, which explicitly banned the forcible seizure of private property by state officials, abolished severe physical mutilations as legal punishments, and prohibited the brewing and sale of intoxicating liquors.
 - ✓ During his reign, the English East India Company secured its initial trading footholds in India through formal diplomatic missions, specifically with the arrival of **Captain William Hawkins in 1608**, who was granted a high mansab but failed to secure a definitive treaty, followed by the highly successful mission of **Thomas Roe in 1615**, who obtained an imperial farman allowing the English to establish factories across the empire.

- ✓ Jahangir's reign marked the absolute zenith of Mughal miniature painting, as the emperor was a profound connoisseur of art who heavily patronised master painters like **Ustad Mansur** (renowned for his incredibly detailed naturalistic studies of flora and fauna) and **Abul Hasan** (famous for his majestic imperial portraits).

Q 26. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Devapala, who turned his energies in other directions after failures in the north, successfully extended his control over Pragjyotishpur (Assam) and parts of Orissa.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The Sailendra dynasty built a **Buddhist** monastery (not a Hindu temple) at Nalanda, for which Devapala endowed five villages for its upkeep.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Devapala was the son of Dharmapala, succeeding to the throne in AD 810 and ruling for a span of 40 years.
 - ✓ In addition to Assam and Orissa, it is probable that a **part of modern Nepal** was also brought under Pala suzerainty during his reign.
 - ✓ **Sailendra dynasty:** This powerful dynasty was Buddhist in faith and ruled over **Malaya, Java, Sumatra**, and the neighbouring islands. They sent numerous embassies to the Pala court, demonstrating the close diplomatic relations between the two empires.
 - ✓ The trade with Southeast Asia during this period was highly profitable. It added significantly to the prosperity of the Pala empire and resulted in a substantial influx of **gold and silver** from these countries into Bengal.

Q 27. Ans. A

Explanation:

- The iqta system formalised by Iltutmish was fundamentally a mechanism for agricultural surplus extraction and military administration, granting the assignee the **strict right to collect land revenue**, but absolutely nothing more.
- The military commander was legally **prohibited from claiming proprietary ownership** over the physical land itself or the peasants who farmed it. The assigned revenue was specifically calculated and utilised to maintain a required contingent of **cavalry troops** for the state, with the remainder

serving as the commander's personal salary.

- Because it was functionally a wage paid in the form of a territorial assignment, it carried **no legal right of succession**; the central government retained the absolute authority to **revoke, resize, or transfer an iqta at will**. Any assumption of autonomous sovereignty by the muqti was constitutionally invalid under the Sultanate framework, as they functioned merely as bureaucratic agents required to remit any excess collected wealth (fawazil) directly back to the imperial treasury.

- **Additional Facts:**

- ✓ The institutional blueprint for this administrative mechanism was not indigenous to India; it was formally theorised and perfected in the Seljuq Empire to manage decentralised military elites without depleting the central cash reserves.
- ✓ To prevent commanders from hiding wealth and defrauding the central government, subsequent rulers implemented strict parallel checks. Balban, for example, appointed an independent state accountant known as a **khwaja** to every major administrative assignment to audit the actual collections against the declared military expenditures.
- ✓ The strict, non-permanent nature of this system eventually collapsed during the later Sultanate period. Firoz Shah Tughlaq drastically altered its fundamental mechanics by making these military assignments officially hereditary, effectively weakening the central authority's control over its army.

Q 28. Ans. C

Explanation:

- The Battle of Chanderi occurred in **1528**. Babur decisively defeated the powerful Rajput chieftain, **Medini Rai**. Medini Rai was a dominant political figure in Malwa. He was also a crucial military ally of Rana Sanga.
- **Silhadi** was the prominent Rajput chief of **Raisen**. He fought at Khanwa but notoriously defected to Babur's side during the battle.
- **Rao Maldeo** was the powerful Rajput ruler of **Marwar** (Jodhpur). He did not fight Babur at Chanderi. He is historically famous for his later conflicts against Sher Shah Suri.
- Rana Sanga was the supreme leader of the Rajput confederacy. He was defeated a year earlier at the Battle of Khanwa.

- **Additional facts:**

- ✓ Chanderi was considered an almost impregnable fortress. It strategically controlled the vital trade and military routes entering Malwa.
- ✓ Babur offered Medini Rai the fortress of **Shamsabad** in exchange for surrendering Chanderi. Medini Rai fiercely rejected this diplomatic peace proposal.
- ✓ The Mughal forces subsequently initiated a massive siege of the fort. Realising defeat was imminent, the Rajput women inside the fort performed the ritual of **Jauhar**. They immolated themselves in massive fires to avoid capture and dishonour.
- ✓ The Rajput men then rushed out to fight to the death in a final suicidal charge. Babur successfully captured the massive fortress in just a few hours. He erected a tower of enemy skulls to commemorate this victory. This specific battle completely shattered the remaining organised Rajput resistance in Central India.

Q 29. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Shaikh Abdul Qadir Gilani** originally founded the Qadiri silsila (order) in **Baghdad** during the 12th century. It is one of the oldest and most widespread Sufi orders in the Islamic world.
- Khwaja Baqi Billah is credited with introducing the orthodox Naqshbandi order to India; Shaikh Ahmad Sirhindi was his most prominent Naqshbandi disciple, who opposed syncretic philosophies; and Shaikh Nizamuddin Auliya was one of the most venerated saints of the Chishti order in Delhi.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ While founded earlier in Baghdad, the Qadiri order was introduced to the Indian subcontinent much later, during the 15th century, by **Sayyid Muhammad Jilani** and his descendants. It established its strongest foundational roots in the **Punjab** and **Sindh** regions.
 - ✓ The most famous royal adherent of this order was the Mughal prince **Dara Shikoh** (the eldest son and designated heir of Shah Jahan). He and his sister, **Princess Jahanara Begum**, became initiated disciples of the revered **Qadiri saint Mian Mir** (who is historically famous for laying the foundation stone of the **Harmandir Sahib/ Golden Temple in Amritsar**) and later studied under his successor, **Mullah Shah Badakhshi**.

- ✓ Deeply influenced by the pantheistic and tolerant teachings of the Qadiri mystics, Dara Shikoh sought to bridge the gap between Islamic Sufism and Hindu Vedanta. He authored the **Majma-ul-Bahrain** (The Mingling of the Two Oceans) to highlight their philosophical similarities and sponsored the translation of fifty Upanishads from Sanskrit into Persian under the title **Sirr-i-Akbar** (The Great Secret).
- ✓ The liberal, syncretic approach of the Qadiri order under Dara Shikoh was fiercely challenged by the rigidly orthodox Naqshbandi order. This ideological war culminated in the Mughal war of succession, resulting in Aurangzeb executing Dara Shikoh and decisively shifting the empire away from Qadiri liberalism.

Q 30. Ans. D

Explanation:

- Statement D is incorrect: Nicolo de Conti visited the Vijayanagara Empire around 1420–1421 during the reign of Deva Raya I, not Deva Raya II. (It was the Persian ambassador Abdur Razzaq who later visited during the reign of Deva Raya II).
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ Nicolo de Conti noted the impressive engineering of the empire, specifically mentioning that the ruler (Deva Raya I) had constructed a massive **dam** across the **Tungabhadra River** to bring water into the capital for irrigation and urban use.
 - ✓ He was astounded by the military mobilisation of the empire, writing that the Vijayanagara army consisted of over a million men during major campaigns.
 - ✓ He is one of the **earliest European sources** to vividly describe Hindu festivals such as Deepavali (the lighting of lamps) and Holi (the throwing of colored water).

Q 31. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Introduced by the imperial finance minister **Raja Todar Mal in 1580**, the Dahsala (ten-year) system calculated the state's revenue demand by meticulously averaging both the agricultural yields of specific crops and their local market prices over the preceding continuous ten-year period (from the 15th to the 24th year of Akbar's reign).
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Unlike the later British

Permanent Settlement, the Dahsala revenue assessment was **never permanently fixed**; the Mughal state firmly rejected permanent land settlements and periodically updated the **Dastur-ul-Amal** (cash rate schedules) to accommodate ongoing economic fluctuations and changing regional market prices.

- **Statement 3 is correct:** To ensure taxation was fair and explicitly based on actual soil productivity, the administration systematically classified agricultural land into four distinct categories strictly according to their continuous cultivation status: **Polaj** (cultivated annually), **Parauti** (left fallow briefly to recover fertility), **Chachar** (left uncultivated for three to four years), and **Banjar** (barren or uncultivated for five years or more).
- **Statement 4 is incorrect:** The Mughal administration did not uniformly enforce this highly standardized system across the entire empire, as the Dahsala system operated primarily within the core **Zabti** provinces (stretching from **Lahore to Allahabad**, including **Malwa** and parts of **Gujarat**), while distant or geographically distinct provinces like **Bengal**, **Sindh**, and **Kashmir** deliberately retained their traditional, localized revenue systems such as **Batai** or **Ghallabakhshi** (crop-sharing).
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ To eliminate the massive discrepancies caused by the older measurement system that utilised a fluctuating hemp rope, which expanded when wet, Akbar officially introduced a standardised bamboo measuring rod permanently joined by iron rings known as the **jarib**.
 - ✓ The imperial administration formally replaced the older **Sikandari Guz** with a new, standardised linear measurement unit called the **Ilahi Guz**, which measured exactly 41 digits (approximately 33 inches) and was utilised uniformly across the core provinces for land surveys.
 - ✓ Under this specific revenue framework, the imperial state's official tax demand was strictly fixed at **one-third** of the calculated average produce, and while the initial assessment was physically calculated in kind, the peasantry was required to remit the actual tax to the treasury in cash.
 - ✓ To actively facilitate agricultural recovery and assist the peasantry during periods of severe drought or famine, the Mughal treasury systematically disbursed specialised state

agricultural loans known as **taccavi**, which were strictly earmarked for the purchase of seeds, draft cattle, and essential farming implements.

- ✓ The exhaustive statistical data, provincial cash rates, and exact operational mechanics of the Dahsala system are meticulously preserved in the administrative manual **Ain-i-Akbari**, compiled by the court historian **Abul Fazl**.

Q 32. Ans. D

Explanation:

- **Option A is incorrect:** A **Muqaddam** was the designated local headman of an individual village (**Mauza**), representing a specific administrative person and title rather than a distinct territorial subdivision like a Pargana.
- **Option B is incorrect:** A Subah was a much larger provincial unit that formally integrated **multiple Sarkars**. Emperor **Akbar** formally introduced the comprehensive Subah administrative system in 1580, several decades after the Sur dynasty.
- **Option C is incorrect:** An Iqta was a traditional land grant assignment and administrative system primarily utilised by the earlier **Delhi Sultans** (such as the Ilbari Turks and Khaljis) to compensate military commanders, not a specific territorial subdivision within Sher Shah's civilian administration.
- **Option D is correct:** In the highly centralised administrative structure established by Sher Shah Suri, the Pargana functioned as the **fundamental territorial unit** situated immediately below the level of a Sarkar (district). A Sarkar comprised multiple Parganas, and the empire contained thousands of these localised administrative divisions.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ To systematically streamline regional governance, Sher Shah divided his entire empire into exactly **forty-seven distinct Sarkars**, each supervised by two principal officers: the **Shiqdar-i-Shiqdaran** (chief executive) and the **Munsif-i-Munsifan** (chief judicial and revenue officer).
 - ✓ Notably, Sher Shah deliberately refrained from grouping these Sarkars into larger Subahs governed by powerful provincial governors, a strategic administrative decision designed to prevent the concentration of regional power and mitigate the risk of armed rebellions.
 - ✓ At the foundational level, the village (**Mauza**)

constituted the **lowest tier** of the imperial administration, operating with a high degree of traditional autonomy through local councils (Panchayats).

- ✓ Within the village, the **Patwari** served as the crucial state-recognised official responsible for meticulously maintaining the localised agricultural and land revenue records, forming the absolute basis of the imperial taxation system.
- ✓ To ensure administrative integrity, Sher Shah's central government enforced strict, direct supervision over all localised Pargana officials, frequently transferring them to prevent the entrenchment of corrupt local power bases.

Q 33. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Treaty of Purandar, formally executed on **June 11, 1665**, altered the territorial balance in the Deccan by forcing Chhatrapati Shivaji to surrender **twenty-three major forts**, including critical strategic strongholds such as Sinhadgad, Purandar, and Rudramal, which collectively yielded an annual agrarian revenue of four lakh huns. Orchestrated by Mughal commander **Mirza Raja Jai Singh** after a highly destructive imperial siege, this capitulation crippled the Maratha state's offensive capabilities, leaving Shivaji with a heavily reduced network of only twelve forts yielding one lakh huns, strictly conditioned upon his absolute tributary submission to Emperor Aurangzeb.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** As a primary diplomatic mechanism to ensure ongoing Maratha compliance without demanding Shivaji's permanent physical presence at the Mughal darbar, the treaty instituted a dynastic hostage protocol by integrating his young heir, **Sambhaji**, into the imperial military-administrative apparatus. Sambhaji was officially awarded a high-ranking **panjhazari mansab** (a designated rank of 5,000 zat and 5,000 sawar) and was mandated to be permanently stationed alongside a Maratha cavalry contingent within the Mughal Deccan encampment, effectively subordinating the Maratha leadership to imperial dictates.
- Additional facts regarding the Treaty of Purandar (1665):
 - ✓ Shivaji was explicitly exempted from mandatory personal attendance at the Mughal

court (darbar), a rare imperial concession, but was structurally bound to deploy a **5,000-strong cavalry** force for Aurangzeb's military campaigns in the Deccan.

- ✓ The treaty deliberately weaponised Maratha forces against the rival **Adil Shahi Sultanate**, as Shivaji was forced to formally commit to assisting **Mirza Raja Jai Singh** in the immediate, though ultimately unsuccessful, Mughal invasion of Bijapur.
- ✓ Aurangzeb nominally recognised Shivaji's right to exact **chauth** and **sardeshmukhi** from specific lowland Bijapuri territories in the Konkan and Balaghat regions, strictly contingent upon a staggered Maratha tribute payment of forty lakh huns over a thirteen-year period.
- ✓ The details of the siege of Purandar are preserved in the **Haft Anjuman**, a primary Persian source compiled by Jai Singh's personal secretary, **Udiraj**.
- ✓ The Venetian traveller **Niccolao Manucci**, functioning directly as an artillery captain in the Mughal camp during the Purandar campaign, recorded a detailed eyewitness account of the military operations and Shivaji's ultimate capitulation in his extensive memoir, **Storia do Mogor**.

Q 34. Ans. C

Explanation:

- Khazain-ul-Futuh (The Treasures of Victory), written in highly ornate prose, serves as the primary contemporary source for the reign of Alauddin Khilji. It provides a crucial, eyewitness account of **Malik Kafur's** extensive **Deccan** expeditions and the brutal suppression of the **Mongol** invasions, though it deliberately omits Alauddin's assassination of his uncle, **Jalaluddin**.
- Ashiqi is a historical romance (masnavi) that chronicles the tragic love story between Alauddin Khilji's eldest son, Khizr Khan, and Deval Devi, the fugitive Rajput princess of **Gujarat**. Beyond its romantic core, the work provides vital historical data regarding the Khilji conquest of Gujarat and Malwa.
- Nuh Siphir (The Nine Heavens) was composed during the reign of Qutbuddin Mubarak Shah Khilji. Khusrau enthusiastically praises India's climate, architecture, and sciences, explicitly asserting the cultural superiority of Indian languages (**Hindavi**) and classical music over foreign traditions.

- Tughlaq Nama was Amir Khusrau's **final** historical masnavi. It was specifically commissioned to commemorate the military victory of the provincial governor **Ghazi Malik** (who assumed the title Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq) over the usurper Khusrau Khan, thereby detailing the official foundation of the Tughlaq dynasty in 1320.

● Additional facts:

- ✓ Amir Khusrau was deeply entrenched in the spiritual landscape of the Delhi Sultanate as the most prominent disciple (murid) of the revered Chishti Sufi saint, **Hazrat Nizamuddin Auliya**. Khusrau famously died of grief merely months after his master's passing in 1325 and was buried at his master's feet in Delhi.
- ✓ Amir Khusrau proudly styled himself as **Tuti-i-Hind** ("The Parrot of India"). He is credited with significantly transforming North Indian classical music by blending indigenous musical traditions with **Persian-Arabic** elements.
- ✓ In the literary sphere, he pioneered a sophisticated style of Persian poetry known as **Sabaq-i-Hindi** (the Indian style). Recognised as a nayak (master) in both the theory and practice of music, Khusrau also introduced several **Perso-Arabic** melodic forms (ragas), including **aiman**, **ghora**, and **sanam**.

Q 35. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Option A is correct:** The Battle of Khanwa took place in 1527. It pitted Babur against a massive Rajput confederacy. Rana Sanga of Mewar led this alliance.
- **Option B is correct:** Babur's troops were terrified by the martial reputation of the Rajputs. Babur smashed his gold and silver wine cups to inspire his men. He formally declared the battle a Jihad to unify his demoralised army.
- **Option C is incorrect:** Rana Sanga was not killed on the battlefield of Khanwa. He was severely wounded during the fighting. His loyal followers carried him away to safety in an unconscious state. He later attempted to organise another military campaign against Babur. His own nobles vehemently opposed this disastrous plan. They subsequently poisoned Rana Sanga to death.
- **Option D is correct:** Babur won a decisive victory at Khanwa. He subsequently assumed the formal title of Ghazi.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Rana Sanga's confederacy was not exclusively

Rajput; it actively incorporated powerful Afghan nobles who sought to overthrow Babur. This included **Hasan Khan Mewati**, who commanded the Rajput vanguard, and **Mahmud Lodi**, the brother of the deceased Ibrahim Lodi.

- ✓ Babur secured his victory by deploying the exact same advanced military tactics he had tested at Panipat. He utilised the Ottoman device of chaining baggage carts together to create a defensive wall, from behind which he unleashed devastating artillery barrages coordinated by his master gunner, **Ustad Ali**.
- ✓ As part of his desperate, multi-pronged effort to boost the morale of his troops right before the clash, Babur formally abolished the **Tamgha** (a lucrative commercial stamp tax) exclusively for all his Muslim subjects.
- ✓ The victory at Khanwa was arguably more significant than Panipat, as it definitively crushed the Rajput bid for supremacy and permanently shifted the political centre of Mughal power away from Kabul and directly into Agra.

Q 36. Ans. A

Explanation:

- In Sher Shah Suri's administrative system, the **Shiqdar-i-Shiqdaran** functioned as the **chief executive officer of a Sarkar** (district), tasked with maintaining law and order, commanding the district police force, and preempting regional uprisings by local zamindars.
- Operating alongside him at the district level, the **Munsif-i-Munsifan** served as the **chief judicial and revenue assessment officer**, supervising overall revenue collection, resolving agrarian civil disputes, and auditing subordinate staff.
- At the foundational **Pargana level**, the **Shiqdar** managed local **policing**, maintained civil peace, and provided enforcement support to revenue collectors.
- The **Munsif** (also designated as an **Aamil**) was responsible for the localised **assessment of land revenue**, which involved measuring agricultural tracts and calculating the specific tax demand for the subdivision.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ To prevent the consolidation of localised power bases and mitigate institutional corruption, Sher Shah implemented a systematic policy of transferring these administrative officials across different jurisdictions every two to three years.

- ✓ At the Pargana level, the daily administrative and revenue operations were supported by two specialised clerks (**Karkuns**); one clerk maintained the official state records in **Persian**, while the other recorded the data in the local **Hindi** script to ensure transparency with the peasantry.
- ✓ The physical financial assets and collected land revenues within the Pargana were secured and managed by a dedicated local treasurer designated as the **Fotdar** (or **Khazandar**).

Q 37. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Unlike the massive public temple complexes (such as the **Virupaksha** or **Vitthala** temples), which were located in the "Sacred Centre" of the city along the river, the Hazara Rama temple was situated strictly within the "**Royal Centre**." It functioned exclusively as the private place of worship for the Vijayanagara emperors and their immediate household.
- Archaeological surveys of Hampi distinctly identify separate, secular structures for the state mint, royal treasury, and military arsenals (such as the elephant stables and guards' quarters) located elsewhere within the palace complex.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The temple is globally celebrated for its extensive, continuous bas-reliefs carved onto the exterior walls of the shrine and the courtyard. These carvings serve as a visual narrative, heavily depicting sequences from the **Ramayana** (hence the name "Hazara Rama," meaning a thousand Ramas).
 - ✓ In addition to religious iconography, the lower tiers of the outer walls uniquely feature secular state imagery. They vividly depict the grand military and cultural processions of the **Mahanavami** festival, showing marching infantry, Arabian horses, war elephants, and dancing girls.
 - ✓ The interior **ardha-mandapa** (half-pavilion) contains four exquisitely carved, highly polished black basalt pillars. This is a significant architectural anomaly, as almost all other major structures in the Vijayanagara capital were constructed using the locally abundant granite.
 - ✓ While the temple saw later additions by **Krishnadevaraya**, architectural historians generally date the core construction of the temple to the early 15th century, during the reign of **Deva Raya I** of the Sangama dynasty.

Q 38. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Option A is correct:** Bahadur Shah harboured Afghan rebels. He also gave asylum to Timurid prince **Muhammad Zaman Mirza**. Humayun demanded the surrender of this prince. Bahadur Shah refused this diplomatic request. This direct provocation triggered Humayun's military response.
- **Option B is incorrect:** Bahadur Shah attacked Chittor, but he did not challenge Mughal supremacy in the Doab region. His immediate expansionist focus remained on Malwa and Rajputana.
- **Option C is incorrect:** Control of coastal trade was a secondary benefit. It was not the primary strategic reason for the 1534 invasion. Humayun prioritised crushing immediate political rivals.
- **Option D is incorrect:** The Persian Shah had no involvement in this early regional conflict. Humayun sought Persian assistance much later during his exile.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Bahadur Shah employed an Ottoman gunner named **Rumi Khan**, who commanded the Gujarati artillery.
 - ✓ Humayun captured the impenetrable fort of **Champaner** in 1535 and scaled the sheer fort walls using iron spikes.
 - ✓ Askari was appointed as the Mughal governor of Gujarat who failed to maintain administrative control over the province.
 - ✓ Bahadur Shah reclaimed Gujarat within a single year.

Q 39. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Assertion (A) is true, and Reason (R) is its correct explanation.** The Nalanda University, which had been famous all over the world, was explicitly revived by Dharmapala, who set apart 200 villages to meet its expenses.
- **Additional Facts:**
 - ✓ In addition to reviving Nalanda, Dharmapala founded the **Vikramasila** University, which became second only to Nalanda in fame and was located on a hill on the banks of the Ganga in Magadha.
 - ✓ The Pala rulers broadly supported the monastic community by building many viharas in which a large number of Buddhist monks lived.
 - ✓ The Palas had close cultural relations with **Tibet**,

inviting noted scholars like **Santarakshita** and **Dipankara (Atisa)** to introduce a new form of Buddhism there. Consequently, many Tibetan Buddhists flocked to the universities of Nalanda and Vikramasila for study.

- ✓ Despite their strong patronage of Buddhist institutions like Nalanda, the Palas were also supporters of **Saivism** and **Vaishnavism**, granting lands to a large number of brahmins.

Q 40. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Iltutmish took the highly unprecedented step of nominating his daughter as his successor. He broke with orthodox Islamic political tradition because he accurately judged that his surviving sons were incompetent and incapable of managing the heavy responsibilities of the centralised state.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Ziauddin Barani and Minhaj-i-Siraj mentions that the elite Turkish oligarchy (Turkan-i-Chahalgani) fiercely rejected Iltutmish's dying wish. Unwilling to bow before a woman, they completely bypassed Razia upon his death in 1236 and crowned his eldest surviving son, Ruknuddin Firuz. It was only after Ruknuddin plunged the capital into chaos through his debauchery that Razia successfully seized the throne by appealing directly to the populace and the army of Delhi during a Friday prayer.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** Razia actively attempted to break the Chahalgani's political monopoly by creating an alternate, loyal nobility. When she appointed Jamaluddin Yaqut, an African Abyssinian, to the highly prestigious military office of Amir-i-Akhur (Superintendent of the Royal Horses), it deeply alienated the Turkish nobles who strictly guarded their racial monopoly over all senior administrative and military positions.
- **Additional Facts:**
 - ✓ To firmly establish her authority over a patriarchal court, Razia completely discarded the traditional female **purdah** (veil). She donned male attire (the qaba and kulah), rode elephants in public, and conducted open court sessions, visually asserting her divine right to rule as a Sultan rather than a Sultana.
 - ✓ The coordinated political conspiracy that ultimately toppled her was triggered outside of Delhi. **Malik Ikhtiyaruddin Altunia**, the powerful governor of **Tabhindah (Bhatinda)**, raised the standard of open revolt. During

her campaign to suppress this specific rebellion, her own Turkish officers mutinied, assassinated Yaqut, and imprisoned her, leading to the crowning of her half-brother Muizuddin Bahram.

Q 41. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Sher Khan stalled negotiations for three months. He waited for the monsoon rains to begin. The Mughal camp was situated in a low-lying area. Floodwaters inundated the Mughal encampment. This caused widespread chaos among Humayun's troops.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Sher Khan destroyed the Mughal army at Chausa. He declared his independent sovereignty immediately after this victory. He assumed the royal title of Sher Shah. He struck coins bearing his new imperial title. He commanded clerics to read the khutba in his name.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Humayun barely escaped the battlefield with his life.
 - ✓ A water carrier named Nizam saved Humayun from drowning in the Ganges.
 - ✓ Humayun later rewarded Nizam by granting him nominal rule for half a day.
 - ✓ The battle resulted in the complete annihilation of the Mughal artillery.
 - ✓ Sher Shah gained uncontested control over Bengal and Bihar.

Q 42. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Option A is correct:** To standardise land measurement across his empire, Sher Shah Suri officially adopted the **Sikandari Gaz**, a linear metric originally introduced by Sultan Sikandar Lodi that measured approximately **thirty-two inches** in total length.
- **Option B is incorrect:** The **Ilahi Gaz** was introduced at a much later date by Emperor **Akbar** as a new imperial standard, officially replacing the older Sikandari Gaz in the revenue administration.
- **Option C is incorrect:** A Bigha represents a distinct metric of total land area or acreage, rather than a specific unit of linear distance utilised for the physical act of measurement.
- **Option D is incorrect:** A **Jarib** referred to the **physical measuring chain** or rope utilised by surveyors as an instrument in the field.
- **Additional facts:**

- ✓ Sher Shah implemented a systematic and comprehensive measurement of all cultivable land across his empire to rationalise the agrarian revenue system.
- ✓ For the purpose of accurate tax assessment, the administration systematically classified agricultural soil into **three distinct categories based on yield:** good, middle, and bad.
- ✓ The official state revenue demand was calculated and fixed at exactly **one-third** of the average agricultural produce derived from these specific soil classifications.
- ✓ While peasants were legally permitted to remit their taxes in either **cash or kind** (raw crop grain), the central administration heavily preferred receiving payments in cash.
- ✓ To seamlessly facilitate this cash payment system, the state regularly published standardised crop price lists (**ray**) to accurately convert the assessed grain demand into local currency values.

Q 43. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Zafar Khan was an Afghan adventurer who rose to prominence during a massive rebellion of the **Amiran-i-Sada** (centurion nobles) against the oppressive policies of the Delhi Sultan, **Muhammad bin Tughlaq**. Upon successfully establishing the independent empire, Zafar Khan ascended the throne under the regal title **Alauddin Hasan Bahman Shah**.
- He is widely remembered in historical folklore by his earlier name, **Hasan Gangu**. According to the 16th-century chronicler **Firishta**, "Gangu" was the name of a Brahmin astrologer in Delhi who had originally employed Hasan and prophesied his future kingship, though modern historians often debate the literal accuracy of this legend.
- **Ismail Mukh** (an elderly and respected Afghan noble) was actually the first leader chosen by the rebel amirs in the Deccan, briefly taking the title **Nasir-ud-Din Ismail Shah**. However, realising he lacked the military vigour to fend off the Delhi imperial army, he voluntarily abdicated the throne in favour of the much more capable Zafar Khan (Hasan Gangu).
- **Mahmud Gawan:** While he is arguably the most famous figure of the Bahmani era, he was not the founder. He was a brilliant Persian merchant who later served as the Prime Minister (**Vakil-us-Sultanat**) under Muhammad Shah III, taking the empire to its absolute territorial and cultural zenith in the late 15th century.

- **Quli Qutb Shah:** He was a later provincial governor of the Bahmani Empire who declared independence after the empire's fragmentation in the 16th century, founding the **Qutb Shahi dynasty of Golconda**.

- **Additional facts:**

- ✓ First capital: Upon founding the empire, Hasan Gangu established his capital at Gulbarga (which he renamed Ahsanabad). The capital was later shifted to Bidar by Ahmad Shah Wali in the 1420s.
- ✓ To consolidate his vast new territory, Hasan Gangu divided his empire into four primary provinces called **Tarafs (Gulbarga, Daulatabad, Berar, and Bidar)**, placing each under the strict military and administrative control of a loyal governor (Tarafdar).
- ✓ During his reign of eleven years, he engaged in almost continuous warfare, expanding his borders from the **Wainganga River** in the north to the **Krishna River in the south**, actively contesting the newly formed Vijayanagara Empire for control of the Raichur Doab.

Q 44. Ans. D

Explanation:

- Saltpetre was the **critical oxidative ingredient** for manufacturing gunpowder. During the 17th century, the heavily nitrated soils of Bihar (centred strategically around Patna and Chapra) yielded the highest quality and volume of saltpetre globally, prompting intense commercial rivalry between European joint-stock companies seeking to secure the supply chain for their domestic militaries.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The physical extraction, lixiviation (washing), and preliminary refining of saltpetre from the **nitrate-rich topsoil of Bihar** were exclusively performed by a specialised, marginalised indigenous peasant caste historically known as the **Nunias**.
 - ✓ To consolidate their lucrative supply chain, the Dutch East India Company (VOC) established a massive, highly efficient saltpetre refinery at Chapra, while the English East India Company (EIC officially appointed Job Charnock as the chief of their Patna factory in 1658 to secure direct procurement.
 - ✓ The astronomical surge in European demand for Bihar's saltpetre during this specific period was directly fueled by the intense, continent-wide military conflicts transforming European

statecraft, most notably the **Thirty Years' War** (1618–1648) and the **English Civil War**.

- ✓ Due to the vast quantities required, refined saltpetre was transported in bulk via flat-bottomed heavy river barges (**patellas**) down the Ganges River to the deep-water port of Hugli in Bengal, where it was loaded onto heavily armed European East Indiamen.
- ✓ Recognising the extreme strategic military value of the chemical, the Mughal state, particularly under Emperor Aurangzeb, periodically imposed strict export embargoes on saltpetre to prevent European entities from stockpiling munitions during regional hostilities, such as the **Anglo-Mughal War** (Child's War) in 1689.

Q 45. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** **Vishweshwar**, widely known as **Gaga Bhatta**, a prominent Brahmin scholar from Varanasi, officially presided over the coronation at **Raigad fort** on June 6, 1674. His involvement provided the essential orthodox religious sanction required for the ceremony.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** During the ritual, Shivaji explicitly assumed the Sanskrit title **Haindava Dharmoddharak (Protector of the Hindu Faith)**. This title was strategically chosen to project ideological leadership and rally regional support against the Mughal Empire and the Adil Shahi Sultanate.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** To legally claim the sovereign title of Chhatrapati, orthodox tradition required the ruler to belong to the Kshatriya varna. Gaga Bhatta established this legitimacy by genealogically linking Shivaji's Bhonsle clan to the prestigious **Sisodiya Rajputs of Mewar**.
- **Statement 4 is incorrect:** The coronation did not abolish Maratha taxation policies but rather institutionalised them. Instead of ending Chauth, acquiring independent sovereign status gave Shivaji the legal authority to formally demand this **25 percent** territorial tax, alongside **Sardeshmukhi**, from rival domains without being labelled a subordinate rebel.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Shivaji held a supplementary coronation on September 24, 1674, overseen by **Nischal Puri Goswami** using Tantric rituals to ward off perceived bad omens following his mother Jijabai's death.

- ✓ To mark the beginning of his independent royal administration, Shivaji introduced a new **calendar era** known as the **Rajyabhisheka Shaka**.
- ✓ He asserted his sovereign economic authority by minting an independent **gold coin** called the **Hon** and a **copper coin** named the **Shivrai**.
- ✓ **Henry Oxinden**, an envoy from the English East India Company, was officially present at Raigad during the ceremony to negotiate a regional trade treaty.
- ✓ The formal council of eight state ministers was officially structured as the **Ashtapradhan Mandal**, replacing their previous Persian administrative titles with Sanskrit equivalents like Peshwa and Amatya.

Q 46. Ans. C

Explanation:

- Jaunpur reached its highest peak of cultural, literary, and architectural brilliance under Sultan **Ibrahim Shah Sharqi**. His extensive royal patronage attracted thousands of Islamic scholars, Sufis, poets, and artists who had fled the devastation of Delhi during Timur's invasion. This massive influx of intellect transformed the provincial capital into the premier centre of Islamic learning in northern India, earning it the celebrated title "**Shiraz of the East**."
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The Sharqi (Eastern) dynasty was originally founded by **Malik Sarwar**, a powerful noble and eunuch who served as the Wazir under the later Tughlaqs before exploiting the political vacuum to declare independence.
 - ✓ Ibrahim Shah Sharqi was responsible for the completion of the **Atala Masjid** in 1408. This monument defined the distinct "**Jaunpur style**" of architecture, which is heavily characterised by massive sloping walls, square pillars, intricate stone screens, and a prominent absence of minarets.
 - ✓ The independent Sharqi kingdom was eventually extinguished and permanently re-annexed into the Delhi Sultanate after **Bahlul Lodi** decisively defeated its final ruler, **Husain Shah Sharqi** (who was himself a renowned patron of classical music and credited with developing/popularising the **Khayal style**).

Q 47. Ans. A

Explanation:

- The Brihadeshwara Temple, built by the Chola ruler **Rajaraja I** at **Thanjavur** around 1010 CE, is popularly

known as "**Dakshina Meru**" (Southern Meru). The name reflects its massive **pyramidal vimana (tower)**, symbolically compared to Mount Meru, the sacred cosmic mountain in Indian tradition. Its 13-storeyed vimana rises to about 60 metres and is one of the tallest temple towers of medieval India.

- The temple is dedicated to **Lord Shiva** and is also called **Rajarajesvaram**.
- It is the finest example of mature Chola architecture and is now part of the UNESCO-listed Great Living Chola Temples.
- **Gangaikonda Cholapuram Temple** was built by **Rajendra I** and is another major Chola temple'
- **Airavatesvara Temple** was built by **Rajaraja II** and is known for its exquisite stone carvings.
- **Nageswaraswamy Temple** is located at **Kumbakonam** and represents the **Early Chola architectural phase** (attributed to **Aditya I**), famous for its life-size, hyper-realistic external portrait sculptures.

Q 48. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Option A is incorrect:** **Sumant**, previously known by the Persian title **Dabir**, functioned as the **foreign minister** of the Maratha state. This official was strictly responsible for managing diplomatic relations, receiving foreign envoys, and advising Chhatrapati Shivaji on strategic alliances and conflicts with neighbouring powers like the Mughal Empire and Bijapur.
- **Option B is incorrect:** **Sachiv**, formerly known as the **Shurnis**, was the **superintendent of royal correspondence**. This minister's primary role was to draft and dispatch royal edicts (farmans), affix the official seal to documents, and maintain the textual accuracy of state letters. They reviewed the registers of specific administrative districts (parganas).
- **Option C is correct:** **Amatya**, previously titled **Majumdar**, served directly as the finance minister of the Maratha administration. This official was responsible for auditing all public accounts of the kingdom, monitoring imperial income and expenditure, and specifically counter-signing all state financial documents to maintain economic stability and prevent administrative fraud.
- **Option D is incorrect:** **Peshwa**, or **Mukhya Pradhan**, acted as the Prime Minister and the **highest-ranking official** in the **Ashtapradhan Mandal**. Peshwa oversaw the general administration of the empire and could deputise for the Chhatrapati during his absence or in military campaigns.

● **Additional facts:**

- ✓ All ministers within the council, with the strict exception of the **Panditrao** (head of religious affairs) and the **Nyayadhish** (chief justice), were militarily obligated to command armies and lead expeditions during wartime.
- ✓ To prevent the rise of a rebellious feudal aristocracy, Shivaji strictly paid these eight ministers through direct **cash salaries** (nagad) from the state treasury rather than granting them autonomous land assignments (jagirs or saranjams).
- ✓ **Ramchandra Pant Amatya**, who served as the **Amatya** and later the **Hukumatpanah**, authored the **Adnyapatra**, a highly influential Marathi treatise detailing Maratha statecraft, naval policy, and fort architecture.
- ✓ Each primary minister was administratively supported by a standardised departmental staff of eight clerks, which included specific roles like the **Diwan** (chief secretary) and **Phadnis** (deputy auditor).
- ✓ The transition from Persian administrative titles (such as Majumdar and Dabir) to their Sanskrit equivalents (Amatya and Sumant) was officially executed during Shivaji's 1674 coronation to align with his **Haindava Dharmoddharak** ideology.

Q 49. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Mahmud Gawan did not abolish the Khalisa lands. To curb the financial independence of the powerful nobles, he significantly expanded the Khalisa (tracts of land whose revenue went directly to the Sultan's central treasury) by carving them out of the provincial territories.
- **Statements 1 and 3 are correct:** Gawan recognised that the vast original four provinces (established by Hasan Gangu) made the governors (tarafdars) dangerously powerful. He divided them into eight smaller provinces. Furthermore, he systematically stripped the governors of their absolute military monopoly by placing at least one major fort in each province under the direct control of an officer appointed by the Sultan (Qiladar).
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Gawan was not a native noble. He was a Persian merchant (an Afaqi or Gharib) who rose to become the **Vakil-us-Sultanat** (Prime Minister) under **Muhammad Shah III**.

- ✓ He heavily modernised the Bahmani military, employing **Persian** and **Turkish chemists** to introduce the organised use of **gunpowder** and artillery in the Deccan.
- ✓ He built a magnificent, Persian-style Madrasa at Bidar, which became a premier Islamic university equipped with a massive library of 3,000 manuscripts.
- ✓ His centralising reforms deeply angered the older, native nobility (the Deccanis). They forged a treasonous letter implicating Gawan in a conspiracy, leading the intoxicated Sultan to order his execution in **1481**, an event that triggered the rapid fragmentation of the Bahmani Empire.

Q 50. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Option B is the correct:** Watan Jagirs were a highly specialised category of **non-transferable, hereditary** land grants specifically designed to pragmatically accommodate subjugated Rajput chieftains (and later other prominent local Zamindars), allowing them to retain autonomous administrative control over their ancestral territories in exchange for formally acknowledging Mughal suzerainty and providing military service.
- **Option A is incorrect:** Standard revenue assignments granted to regular Mughal nobles (such as the **Turanis, Iranis, or Indian Muslims**) in lieu of cash salaries were simply known as standard Jagirs, and these were deliberately made transferable every three to four years by the imperial centre to strictly prevent the nobility from establishing entrenched, autonomous power bases in any single province.
- **Option C is incorrect:** Lands whose revenue was reserved directly for the imperial treasury rather than being assigned to nobles were classified as **Khalisa**, and the massive income generated from these highly productive territories was utilised specifically to maintain the emperor's personal household, the royal court, and his direct standing army (such as the Ahadis).
- **Option D is incorrect:** Tax-free, charitable land grants bestowed upon religious scholars, destitute widows, and Sufi mystics for their daily sustenance were legally classified as **Madad-i-Ma'ash** or **Suyurghal**, and unlike standard jagirs, these grants were typically held for life and were fundamentally divorced from any required military or administrative obligations to the state.

● **Additional facts:**

- ✓ A Jagirdar was never granted actual proprietary ownership of the land itself; the imperial assignment solely conferred the right to collect the state's share of the land revenue and associated local taxes from the peasantry within that specific jurisdiction.
- ✓ The imperial revenue administration strictly maintained two separate financial metrics for these assignments: the **Jama** (the officially estimated revenue calculated by the state on paper) and the **Hasil** (the actual revenue practically collected by the noble on the ground).
- ✓ During the later decades of Aurangzeb's reign, the massive expansion of the nobility following the Deccan campaigns, combined with a severe shortage of productive unassigned land (**Pai-baqi**), directly triggered the famous "Jagirdari crisis," where the Hasil fell drastically below the Jama, effectively crippling the nobles' financial ability to maintain their required cavalry contingents.
- ✓ To ensure the Jagirdars did not illegally extort or oppress the peasantry while collecting their assigned revenue, the Mughal state appointed independent imperial officers directly accountable to the centre, such as the **Faujdar** (military commander) and the **Amal-guzar** (revenue collector), to heavily monitor local administrative practices within the jagirs.

Q 51. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correct:** The Sumant (Persian title: Dabir) functioned as the foreign minister, responsible for receiving envoys and managing external diplomacy.
- **Pair 2 is correct:** The Senapati (Persian title: Sar-i-Naubat) served directly as the commander-in-chief of the Maratha military. This official organised troop recruitment, maintained army discipline, and held the primary responsibility of leading major expeditionary campaigns against the Mughal Empire and the Adil Shahi Sultanate.
- **Pair 3 is incorrect:** Nyayadhish acted as the chief justice, resolving civil and criminal disputes based on Hindu legal texts (Smritis). The actual supervision of royal correspondence, drafting state letters, and affixing the official seal (muhur) was the specific duty of the Sachiv (Persian title: Shurnis).
- **Pair 4 is correct:** The Panditrao (Persian equivalent: Sadar) headed the religious administration of the state. This minister was specifically tasked with

overseeing theological disputes, honouring religious scholars, and distributing state-funded charities and land grants (inams) to temples and Brahmins.

● **Additional facts:**

- ✓ The council did not function as an independent, modern cabinet; all eight ministers acted strictly as advisory secretaries who executed Chhatrapati Shivaji's direct royal orders.
- ✓ Except for the Nyayadhish and Panditrao, the remaining six state ministers were legally obligated to command military contingents and lead wartime expeditions.
- ✓ To prevent regional rebellions, the Maratha state paid these ministers direct cash salaries (nagad) from the central treasury, strictly prohibiting the assignment of hereditary land grants (jagirs).
- ✓ The Peshwa (Mukhya Pradhan) acted as the prime minister, coordinating all state departments, and was the sole minister authorised to deputise for the king during his physical absence.
- ✓ During the 1674 coronation, Shivaji systematically replaced the Persian administrative titles of these ministers (such as Majumdar and Dabir) with Sanskrit equivalents (like Amatya and Sumant).

Q 52. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Dharmapala founded the Vikramasila University to expand Buddhist learning in eastern India. The institution was strategically located at the **top of a hill** on the banks of the Ganga River in the Magadha region.
- **Additional Facts:**
 - ✓ While it was a premier centre of learning, historical and textual records indicate it became second only to Nalanda in international fame.
 - ✓ The foundation of the university was accompanied by extensive construction; the Palas built many viharas (monasteries) in which a large number of **Buddhist monks** lived.
 - ✓ Kamrup (Assam) was a region Devapala expanded into, Malwa was contested by the Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas, and Tirhut (north Bengal) was a distinct territory mentioned later in the Sultanate period.

Q 53. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** According to Barani, Balban, who was himself a former member of this

elite Turkish slave nobility established by Iltutmish, understood that the Sultan's absolute authority could never be secure as long as these powerful nobles existed. Balban used a mix of **espionage**, harsh punishments for minor transgressions (as seen in the brutal public floggings of **Malik Baqbaq and Haibat Khan**), and covert assassinations (such as the suspected poisoning of his cousin, **Sher Khan**) to entirely annihilate the political influence of his former peers.

- **Statement 2 is correct:** Balban's "Blood and Iron" policy was the operationalisation of extreme state violence to restore the prestige and writ of the Crown. As recorded in the **Tarikh-i-Firoz Shahi**, the **Doab** region and the immediate outskirts of Delhi were plagued by highway robbers and rebellious Rajput groups, particularly the **Mewatis**, who routinely plundered the capital. Balban responded with ruthless military suppression: he ordered the clearing of dense forests that served as rebel hideouts, established military outposts (thanas) manned by **Afghan soldiers**, and slaughtered thousands of rebels, effectively securing the capital and reopening trade routes.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Balban did not elevate indigenous non-Turkish nobles; in fact, he was a staunch elitist who aggressively championed the racial supremacy of pure-blooded Turks. **Barani** mentions Balban's intense disdain for low-born individuals, famously recording the Sultan's declaration that seeing a man of base origin caused his hand to instinctively reach for his sword. Instead of replacing the Chahalgani with Indian Muslims or commoners (**a policy later adopted by the Khaljis**), Balban relied strictly on elevating his own dynastic prestige and centralising military power to fill the vacuum left by the destroyed aristocracy. He summarily dismissed officials like **Kamal Mahiyar** simply because of their indigenous, non-aristocratic lineages.

Additional facts:

- To philosophically justify his despotic rule and elevate himself above the remaining nobility, Balban adopted ancient **Persian concepts of monarchy**. He declared the Sultan to be the **Zill-i-Ilahi** (the Shadow of God on Earth) and the **Niyabat-i-Khudai** (the Deputy of God), asserting that his power was derived directly from the divine, not from the consensus of the nobles.
- He introduced rigid, highly formal Persian court

protocols, most notably **Sijda** (prostration before the monarch) and **Paibos** (kissing the Sultan's feet). These rituals were specifically designed to break the pride of the Turkish nobles and enforce total physical submission to the Crown. He also introduced the celebration of the Persian New Year festival, **Nauroz**, to project imperial splendour.

- Recognising that his "Blood and Iron" policy required a highly efficient standing army independent of the nobles' feudal levies, Balban separated the military department from the financial department (**Diwan-i-Wazarat**). He established the **Diwan-i-Arz** and placed it under the command of a highly competent and trusted officer, **Imad-ul-Mulk**, who served as the **Ariz-i-Mumalik**.
- To preempt rebellions and monitor the activities of ambitious nobles and local administrators, Balban instituted a pervasive and highly organised espionage system. Spies (**Barids**) were placed in every province and department. They functioned independently of provincial governors and reported directly to the Sultan; failure to report a nobleman's transgression resulted in the spy's own execution.

Q 54. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Assertion (A) is true:** The Battle of Kannauj was a decisive encounter. Humayun lost his entire army in this battle. He was forced to flee from Agra and Delhi. This event marked the temporary end of Mughal rule in India. It initiated the fifteen-year **Sur Interregnum**.
- **Reason (R) is false:** Kamran and Hindal did not fight for Sher Shah. They simply refused to cooperate with Humayun. Kamran withdrew his battle-hardened troops to Lahore before the clash. This lack of unity crippled Mughal military strength. The brothers did not commit direct battlefield treason at Kannauj.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The Battle of Kannauj is also known as the **Battle of Bilgram**.
 - ✓ Humayun's army suffered from severe demoralisation and poor organisation.
 - ✓ Heavy rains disrupted the Mughal camp setup.
 - ✓ Sher Shah pursued Humayun relentlessly into the Punjab.
 - ✓ Humayun eventually sought refuge in **Safavid Persia**.
 - ✓ **Shah Tahmasp I** eventually provided Humayun with military support.

Q 55. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correctly matched:** The Adil Shahi dynasty was founded by **Yusuf Adil Shah** and ruled the Sultanate of Bijapur.
- **Pair 2 is incorrectly matched:** The Nizam Shahi dynasty, founded by **Malik Ahmad**, ruled the Sultanate of **Ahmadnagar**. Bidar was ruled by the Barid Shahi dynasty.
- **Pair 3 is correctly matched:** The Qutb Shahi dynasty, founded by **Quli Qutb Shah**, ruled the wealthy Sultanate of Golconda.
- **Pair 4 is incorrectly matched:** The Imad Shahi dynasty, founded by **Fathullah Imad-ul-Mulk**, ruled the Sultanate of **Berar**.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The fragmentation of the Bahmani Empire began shortly after the unjust execution of its brilliant Prime Minister, **Mahmud Gawan**, in **1481**, which sparked intense infighting between the Deccani (native) and Afaqi (foreign) nobles.
 - ✓ **Berar (Imad Shahi)** was the **first** to declare independence (**1490**), but it was also the **first** to be **extinguished** when it was annexed by its neighbour, **Ahmadnagar**, in **1574**.
 - ✓ **Bijapur** and **Golconda** were the most powerful and the longest-lasting of the five sultanates. They survived for nearly two centuries until they were finally conquered and annexed into the **Mughal Empire** by **Aurangzeb** in **1686** and **1687**, respectively.
 - ✓ These sultanates became distinct, magnificent centres of **Dakhni culture**. The **Qutb Shahis** built the **Charminar** in Hyderabad, and the **Adil Shahis** constructed the **Gol Gumbaz** in Bijapur (which possesses one of the **largest domes in the world**).

Q 56. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The **Zat rank** functioned as the primary indicator of a noble's personal position and hierarchical status within the vast imperial Mughal administration, directly dictating his personal cash remuneration and standing at the imperial court.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Akbar structurally categorised his mansabdars into three distinct tiers within each numerical grade, classifying a noble as first-class

if his **Sawar rank** was exactly equal to his **Zat rank**, second-class if it was half or more, and third-class if the **Sawar rank** fell strictly below half of his **Zat rank**.

● Additional facts:

- ✓ The **Mansabdari** framework was formally institutionalised into a **dual-rank system** (**Zat** and **Sawar**) during the **40th regnal year of Akbar** (1595–1596), replacing the tribal and hereditary structures of the earlier nobility with a purely merit-based bureaucracy.
- ✓ To prevent military fraud and ensure the accurate maintenance of the **Sawar rank** (which dictated the exact number of cavalymen a noble had to maintain), Akbar heavily enforced the **Dagh** (branding of horses) and **Chehra** (descriptive rolls of soldiers) systems, a practice originally pioneered by **Alauddin Khalji** and **Sher Shah Suri**.
- ✓ Salaries were disbursed either in direct cash (**Naqdi**) from the imperial treasury or, more commonly, through non-hereditary territorial revenue assignments known as **Jagirs**, which were subject to frequent administrative transfers to prevent the nobles from establishing entrenched local power bases.
- ✓ Unlike European feudalism, the system was strictly **non-hereditary** due to the rigorous application of the law of escheat, which mandated that upon the death of a mansabdar, all his personal wealth and assigned jagirs automatically reverted to the imperial state.

Q 57. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Option A is correct:** In 1719, Peshwa Balaji Vishwanath secured three historic imperial edicts (farmans) brokered by the powerful Sayyid brothers. This officially granted Chhatrapati Shahu the legal right to extract **Chauth** (25% of revenue) and **Sardeshmukhi** (an additional 10%) from the six Mughal provinces (subahs) of the Deccan. This monumental agreement formally transitioned the Maratha state from a rebel faction into a legally recognised tributary power within the Mughal system.
- **Option B is incorrect:** The recognition of Maratha dominance over the Malwa province was not achieved in 1719. The formal imperial cession of Malwa occurred much later in 1741 under Peshwa Balaji Baji Rao, following the aggressive military campaigns previously launched by Baji Rao I across the Narmada River.

- **Option C is incorrect:** The 1719 agreement strictly recognised Shahu as a high-ranking vassal, not an independent emperor. It did not grant the Marathas the sovereign right to mint imperial Mughal silver (rupiya) in Shahu's name, as such an act would directly challenge the core sovereignty of the Mughal throne.
- **Option D is incorrect:** The treaty strictly covered the internal Deccan provinces and explicitly excluded Gujarat. Maratha control over Gujarat and its lucrative coastal ports was systematically established in the subsequent decades by independent military commanders like Khanderao Dabhade and the Gaikwad clan.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ As a primary condition for collecting these revenues, Shahu was legally obligated to maintain a permanent contingent of 15,000 Maratha cavalry for imperial Mughal service in the Deccan.
 - ✓ In exchange for the Chauth and Sardeshmukhi rights, the Maratha administration agreed to pay a fixed annual tribute of ten lakh rupees to the central Mughal treasury.
 - ✓ A crucial diplomatic victory of this treaty was the secure release of Shahu's mother, Yesubai, who had remained a Mughal political hostage since the capture of Raigad fort in 1689.
 - ✓ Balaji Vishwanath marched with a force of 15,000 Maratha soldiers to Delhi alongside Sayyid Husain Ali Khan, playing a direct military role in the deposition of Emperor Farrukhsiyar.
 - ✓ The British historian Richard Temple famously termed these 1719 imperial edicts the "Magna Carta of the Maratha Dominion" because they provided the ultimate legal foundation for the Maratha Confederacy.

Q 58. Ans. B

Explanation:

- The Adina Mosque was built in **1374** by Sikandar Shah to project the imperial majesty of the newly independent Bengal Sultanate after successfully defending his territory against the invasions of the Delhi Sultanate (under Firoz Shah Tughlaq).
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The dynasty was founded by **Shamsuddin Ilyas Shah** in **1342**. He achieved the historic milestone of uniting the three warring principalities of **Lakhnauti**, **Sonargaon**, and

Satgaon into a singular geopolitical and cultural entity known as **Bangalah**.

- ✓ The Ilyas Shahi rulers fiercely maintained political independence from Delhi and actively fostered a distinct Bengali cultural identity by extending royal patronage to both Persian scholars and indigenous Bengali literature.
- ✓ The Bengal architectural style heavily utilised local brick and intricate terracotta ornamentation due to the lack of stone. Its most defining feature is the "**curved cornice**" (a drooping roofline), directly adapted from traditional Bengali bamboo huts to quickly drain heavy monsoon rain.
- ✓ Alongside the Adina Mosque, the other defining structure of this era is the **Eklakhi Mausoleum at Pandua**, built by the **Sultan Jalaluddin Muhammad Shah**. It serves as the earliest surviving prototype of the square, single-domed brick tomb in Bengal.

Q 59. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Chauth was a mandatory military tribute exacted by the Maratha state, representing exactly **one-fourth (25 percent)** of the standard land revenue assessment of a targeted region. Shivaji legally justified this collection from neighbouring Mughal and Adil Shahi provinces as a necessary protection fee to guarantee those territories' absolute immunity from Maratha cavalry raids.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** **Sardeshmukhi** was an extra **10 percent** revenue surcharge levied strictly in addition to the Chauth. Shivaji claimed this specific exaction based on his legal assertion of being the premier, hereditary Sardeshmukh (chief revenue collector) of Maharashtra, utilising the tax to assert his supreme sovereign authority over all other regional landlords (zamindars and deshmunhs).
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Paying Chauth functioned strictly as a military protection treaty, essentially a ransom to prevent Maratha invasions. It did not result in political annexation, nor did it transfer the internal civil administration, local law enforcement, or regional judicial authority of the paying territory into the Maratha imperial state apparatus.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The earliest documented instance of Shivaji successfully demanding Chauth occurred in **1665** from the rural districts of the Mughal province of **Khandesh**.

- ✓ During the later Peshwa era, the Chauth was systematically divided into four shares: **Babti** (25% for the Chhatrapati), **Sahotra** (6% for the Sachiv), **Nadgaunda** (3% for royal grants), and **Mokasa** (66% assigned to military commanders to maintain troops).
- ✓ Mughal Emperor **Farrukhsiyar** formally legitimised the Maratha right to exact both Chauth and Sardeshmukhi across the six Mughal provinces of the **Deccan** in 1719, following a treaty brokered by the Sayyid brothers.
- ✓ The Maratha administration appointed specific regional revenue agents known as **Gumashtas** to formally audit and collect the Sardeshmukhi dues from subdued foreign territories.
- ✓ The financial calculation for these external tributes was heavily reliant on the existing Mughal standard revenue assessments originally formalised by Todar Mal, rather than requiring fresh Maratha land surveys.

Q 60. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement B is correct:** The Ayagar system was the fundamental bedrock of local village administration in the Vijayanagara Empire. It consisted of a body of twelve village functionaries (Ayagars), including the headman (**Gouda**), accountant (**Karnam**), watchman (**Talari**), and various **artisans**.
- In exchange for their services to the village community, they were granted tax-free lands (often termed **Manya** or **Umbali**) and a fixed share of the agricultural harvest.

Q 61. Ans. C

Explanation:

- In the Mughal administrative system, Karkhanas functioned as highly specialised imperial manufacturing centres where skilled artisans operated directly under state supervision to produce high-quality luxury items such as silk textiles, fine jewellery, and ornate weaponry exclusively for the royal court.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The prominent 17th-century French physician and traveller **François Bernier** provided extensive contemporary documentation regarding the internal organisation and scale of these imperial workshops.
 - ✓ To ensure absolute quality control and mitigate independent commercial risk, the central

administration supplied raw materials directly to the state-employed artisans.

- ✓ Unlike independent village craftsmen, the specialised artisans operating within the imperial Karkhanas received regular, guaranteed cash wages from the state treasury.
- ✓ These institutional workshops also functioned as vital centres for generational skill transmission, where master craftsmen rigorously trained young apprentices in highly specialised trades.
- ✓ The Karkhanas were specifically responsible for manufacturing the magnificent imperial robes of honour (**khilat**) routinely bestowed by the emperor upon prominent nobles and foreign dignitaries.
- ✓ Crucially, these state-sponsored workshops operated entirely outside the traditional economy and strictly did not produce goods for sale on the open commercial market.

Q 62. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Dnyaneshwar (also spelled Jnaneshwar) was a thirteenth-century poet-saint. He authored the Dnyaneshwari around 1290 CE. It is a Marathi-language philosophical commentary on the Bhagavad Gita. It is considered the foundational text of the Varkari literary tradition.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The Dasbodh was not composed by Eknath. It was authored by Swami Ramdas. Swami Ramdas belonged to the entirely distinct Samarth sect, not the Varkari tradition. Eknath was a sixteenth-century Varkari saint. Eknath is celebrated for his social reform work, particularly his outreach to lower castes and untouchables. He also produced the Eknathi Bhagavata, a Marathi commentary on the eleventh canto of the Bhagavata Purana.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** Tukaram was a seventeenth-century Varkari saint. He composed abhangas (short devotional verses) in Marathi. His compositions carried a consistently egalitarian social message. He openly criticised Brahminical ritual exclusivity. His teachings helped unify diverse social groups under a common devotional identity. This directly contributed to the broader social cohesion that enabled Shivaji's Swarajya.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The Varkari (Pilgrim) socio-religious movement geographically and spiritually centered entirely on the biannual vari pilgrimage

to the **Vithoba** (Vitthal) temple complex at **Pandharpur**, situated on the banks of the **Bhima** (Chandrabhaga) river in Maharashtra.

- ✓ **Namdev**, a prominent 14th-century Shudra tailor and early Varkari saint-poet, traveled extensively into the Punjab; acknowledging his profound spiritual impact, 61 of his devotional hymns were later officially canonized within the Sikh holy scripture, the **Adi Granth** (Guru Granth Sahib).
- ✓ To systematically dismantle the elitist, Sanskrit-dominated orthodox religious monopoly, Varkari saints exclusively utilized the vernacular Marathi language, specifically popularizing the **Ovi** and **Abhanga** poetic meters to democratise spiritual access for the marginalized agrarian and artisanal classes.
- ✓ **Saint Eknath** aggressively challenged deeply entrenched caste orthodoxy by publicly dining with untouchables (Mahars) and utilizing the indigenous **Bharud** (folk drama-poem) format to effectively disseminate socio-spiritual reforms among the illiterate rural masses.
- ✓ The prolonged period of Varkari-driven cultural, spiritual, and linguistic unification across severe caste divides directly established the foundational socio-political cohesion that **Chhatrapati Shivaji** later harnessed to mobilize the **Maratha Swarajya**.

Q 63. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement B is incorrect:** The most remarkable engineering achievement of the **Gol Gumbaz** is that it does not use any internal pillars to support the dome. Instead, it utilises a brilliant system of **eight intersecting arches** (known as pendentives) created by the overlapping of two rotated squares. This specific design supports the massive dome while leaving the interior as one giant, uninterrupted open space.
- The structure was built to be a grand tomb for **Muhammad Adil Shah** and is globally renowned for its acoustic engineering (the **Whispering Gallery**).
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The central chamber is one of the **largest** single-chamber spaces in the world, and its dome is frequently cited as the second largest in the world (only behind St. Peter's Basilica in Rome) and the largest in India.
 - ✓ The "Whispering Gallery" runs along the

interior base of the dome. Because of the perfect symmetry and the curvature of the dome, a single clap or whisper is reflected multiple times, producing echoes that can be heard up to ten times before fading.

- ✓ The monument is primarily constructed out of dark grey basalt rock and decorated with intricate stucco work, standing as the absolute zenith of **Adil Shahi** architectural style in the Deccan.
- ✓ The square base of the mausoleum is anchored by four massive, seven-story octagonal minarets topped with smaller hemispherical domes, each containing a winding staircase leading up to the gallery.

Q 64. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Hari Vijay Suri is matched with Jainism:** Invited by the emperor to participate in the theological discussions, the highly venerated **Svetambara Jain monk** Hari Vijay Suri profoundly influenced Akbar's dietary policies, convincing him to prohibit animal slaughter on certain sacred days and earning the prestigious imperial title of **Jagadguru** (Teacher of the World) for his immense spiritual wisdom.
- **Father Monserrate is matched with Christianity:** Arriving from the **Portuguese** enclave of Goa as a key member of the **First Jesuit Mission in 1580** alongside **Father Rodolfo Acquaviva**, Father Monserrate actively engaged in vigorous theological debates at the Mughal court and was specifically appointed by Akbar to serve as the personal **tutor** to his second son, **Prince Murad**.
- **Purushottam is matched with Hinduism:** Serving as a primary representative of orthodox Hindu theology in the imperial debates, the learned Brahmin scholars **Purushottam** and **Devi** were instrumental in explaining complex Vedic, Vedantic, and **Upanishadic philosophies** to the emperor, laying the groundwork for the massive state-sponsored project of translating major Sanskrit epics into Persian.
- **Dastur Meherji Rana is matched with Zoroastrianism:** Travelling from the traditional Parsi stronghold of **Navsari** in Gujarat, the eminent Zoroastrian priest Dastur Meherji Rana so deeply impressed Akbar with the tenets of his faith that the emperor ordered a sacred fire to be kept burning perpetually at the Mughal court and formally adopted the **Persian Ilahi (solar) calendar** for state administration.

● **Additional facts:**

- ✓ Akbar originally commissioned the construction of the **Ibadat Khana** (House of Worship) in 1575 within the precincts of his newly established imperial capital at **Fatehpur Sikri**.
- ✓ While initially restricted exclusively to Sunni Islamic clerics (Shaikhs, Sayyids, and Ulema), Akbar officially opened the debates in 1578 to scholars of **all religions**, including Shia Muslims, Sufis, Hindus, Jains, Christians, Zoroastrians, and Jews.
- ✓ The contemporary historian **Abdul Qadir Badauni** extensively documented the proceedings in his **Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh**, explicitly noting the bitter, and sometimes physical, altercations that broke out between the leading orthodox Sunni clerics **Makhdum-ul-Mulk** and **Sheikh Abdun Nabi** over trivial seating arrangements and legal interpretations.
- ✓ The fierce theological gridlock and sectarian hostility displayed by the orthodox Muslim clerics during these debates directly alienated Akbar from traditional Islamic dogma, prompting him to promulgate the **Mahzar** in 1579 to strip the Ulema of their definitive legal authority.

Q 65. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Odantapuri was a prominent centre of learning that was geographically located in Bihar.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Along with Nalanda and Vikramasila, it functioned as a Buddhist vihara that successfully drew students from distant places, including Tibet.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Odantapuri was established by Gopala (the founder of the Pala dynasty) in the 8th century, not by Devapala.
- **Statement 4 is correct:** The **Tabaqat-i-Nasiri** provides critical primary evidence of the Turkish conquest of Bihar. It records that Khalji's forces mistook the high, walled Mahavihara of Odantapuri for a heavily fortified military garrison, leading to a sudden assault and the massacre of its resident monks.
- **Additional Facts:**
 - ✓ **Secular and Religious Curriculum:** Standard academic histories note that education at these Buddhist viharas provided a more formal kind of learning, with a significant emphasis placed

on secular subjects alongside religious texts.

- ✓ **Economic Patronage:** Epigraphic records and secondary historians highlight that the survival of these massive universities relied on royal patronage; rulers gave lavish grants of money and revenue-bearing lands to meet their extensive expenses.
- ✓ **Cultural Exchange:** The influx of Tibetan students to Odantapuri, Nalanda, and Vikramasila serves as primary evidence of the deep cultural and religious diplomacy maintained by the empires of eastern India

Q 66. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The **Shahna-i-Mandi** was the chief superintendent of the central grain market in Delhi. To prevent hoarding and ensure a steady supply at the Sultan's strictly fixed prices, this official maintained a mandatory register of all the **banjaras** (itinerant merchants) and wholesale grain dealers. These merchants were compelled to settle near the capital, and their families were often monitored to ensure absolute compliance with the state's rigorous pricing regulations.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Ziauddin Barani's **Tarikh-i-Firoz Shahi** is the primary textual source for Alauddin's market regulations. Barani explicitly details the establishment of the separate markets, the appointed officers, and the price lists. Ibn Battuta visited India decades later during the reign of **Muhammad bin Tughlaq**; while he noted the lingering legacy of low grain prices in Delhi, he is not the source for the administrative mechanics of Alauddin's economic policies.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Alauddin Khilji established **three** distinct and heavily guarded markets in Delhi: one for food grains, a second for costly cloth, sugar, ghee, and oil (known as the **Sarai-i-Adl**), and a third for horses, slaves, and cattle. Each market operated under its own specific tariff and regulations.
 - ✓ To oversee the entire market apparatus and eliminate corruption, Alauddin created an overarching economic department called the **Diwan-i-Riyasat**. It was headed by the **Sadr-i-Riyasat** (usually a strict official like **Malik Yaqub**), to whom all individual market superintendents (**Shahnas**) and intelligence gatherers (**Munhiyans**) reported directly.

- ✓ The foundational motivation behind these drastic economic measures was military necessity. By forcibly suppressing the prices of all essential commodities to an artificially low rate, Alauddin could afford to pay his massive standing army a very low cash salary, keeping the treasury stable while defending the empire against severe Mongol invasions.

Q 67. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Option A is correct:** Serving as the primary political capital of the Maratha state during the reign of **Chhatrapati Rajaram**, the fortress of Satara was subjected to a protracted siege personally commanded by Emperor Aurangzeb, who successfully captured the stronghold in April 1700 and subsequently renamed it **Azamtara** to reflect imperial administrative sovereignty.
- **Option B is incorrect:** **Raigad** functioned as the original imperial capital founded by **Chhatrapati Shivaji**, but this specific fortress was captured much earlier in October 1689 by the prominent **Mughal general Zulfiqar Khan**, a critical military victory that resulted in the capture of **Sambhaji's** surviving royal family, including his queen, **Yesubai** and infant son, **Shahu**.
- **Option C is incorrect:** **Jinji** was a fortification located in the distant southern **Carnatic** region that served as **Rajaram's** government-in-exile, and it was subjected to an exhaustive eight-year military siege commanded by **Zulfiqar Khan** before the Mughal forces finally breached its defensive walls in January 1698.
- **Option D is incorrect:** **Panhala** was a highly strategic defensive stronghold situated in the western Ghats that successfully resisted multiple preliminary Mughal assaults before Aurangzeb finally secured its capitulation later in **May 1701** following a comprehensive military encirclement.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Emperor Aurangzeb permanently departed the imperial core of Northern India in 1681, relocating his primary royal encampment to the Deccan for the final twenty-six years of his reign to initially suppress the joint rebellion of his son, **Prince Akbar**, and the allied Rajput confederacy.
 - ✓ Following the capture and execution of **Chhatrapati Sambhaji in 1689**, the nature of the Maratha conflict transitioned from

conventional state warfare into a highly decentralised, agrarian-based insurgency led by autonomous Maratha commanders, most notably **Santaji Ghorpade** and **Dhanaji Jadhav**, who utilised rapid light-cavalry tactics to continuously disrupt heavily encumbered Mughal supply lines.

- ✓ The continuous, decades-long military mobilisation in the Deccan severely depleted the accumulated financial reserves of the imperial treasury and simultaneously triggered a severe shortage of productive jagir assignments (**pai-baqi**) for the rapidly expanding Mughal nobility, precipitating a systemic institutional and agrarian crisis.
- ✓ The prolonged physical absence of the emperor from the northern provinces led directly to a significant degradation of provincial administrative oversight, actively facilitating the rise of regional agrarian revolts, including the uprisings of the **Jats** under **Churaman** in the **Mathura** region and the **Sikhs** in the **Punjab**.
- ✓ Aurangzeb ultimately passed away at his military encampment in **Bhingar**, near **Ahmadnagar**, in March 1707 at the age of eighty-eight, and was interred in a modest, unroofed grave in **Khuldabad**, directly adjacent to the shrine of the prominent Sufi saint **Shaikh Zainuddin Shirazi**.

Q 68. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Assertion (A) is true:** The **Qabuliyat** functioned as a formal deed of agreement signed by the peasant, which explicitly documented his legal consent to pay the specified financial tax liability to the state. This mechanism ensured that the imperial revenue was collected strictly according to a recorded **contract**, providing a transparent basis for taxation.
- **Reason (R) is true and correct explanation of (A):** Prior agrarian frameworks relied heavily on intermediaries and local zamindars who frequently engaged in the exploitation of the peasantry. By establishing a direct bureaucratic link through the **Qabuliyat**, **Sher Shah** sought to protect the cultivators and secure a consistent flow of revenue to the central government without the interference of predatory middlemen.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ **Patta** served as an official imperial title

deed provided to the peasant, which legally documented his rights over the land and specified the exact area of the holding.

- ✓ Patta also meticulously listed the **types of crops** cultivated on the specific land to ensure the accuracy of the revenue assessment.
- ✓ In a significant move to ensure agricultural security, Sher Shah imposed strict punishments on soldiers who damaged standing crops during military movements.
- ✓ If accidental crop destruction occurred due to state actions, the administration provided direct **compensation** to the affected peasants from the imperial treasury.

Q 69. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Under the Nayankara system, the emperor granted territories called Amaram to top military chiefs known as Nayakas (or Amaranayakas).
 - ✓ **Bhandaravada:** These were the “crown lands.” The revenues from these villages were not assigned to any commanders but went directly into the imperial treasury to fund the central administration and the personal standing army of the king.
 - ✓ **Manya:** These were tax-free land grants given specifically to Brahmins, temples, or religious institutions (maths) for their maintenance, completely separate from military obligations.
 - ✓ **Umbali:** These were smaller plots of land granted at the village level to local officials and functionaries (like village accountants or watchmen) as remuneration for their local administrative services.
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ From the revenue of these lands, Nayakas were legally bound to do two things: maintain a fixed quota of **soldiers, horses, and elephants** for imperial military campaigns, and remit a specified annual financial tribute to the central treasury.
 - ✓ Under strong rulers like Krishnadevaraya, these grants were strictly **non-hereditary**. The emperor retained absolute authority to transfer or confiscate the Amaram if a Nayaka failed his duties.
 - ✓ Within their territories, Nayakas acted as local administrators responsible for clearing forests, expanding agriculture, and maintaining law and order (through the **Kaval policing system**).

- ✓ The detailed understanding of the exact troop quotas and mechanics of this system comes from the writings of the Portuguese chronicler **Fernao Nuniz**.

Q 70. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Humayun died from a fall in the **Dinpanah library**. Akbar was campaigning in the Punjab at that time. Bairam Khan arranged an immediate coronation at Kalanaur. This prevented a power vacuum during a critical period. A simple brick platform was constructed for the ceremony.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Akbar was only thirteen years old. Bairam Khan assumed the role of regent. He received the title of **Vakil-i-Mutlaq**. This title translates to principal minister with full powers. He effectively ruled the empire on Akbar's behalf for **four years**.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Bairam Khan was a Shia Muslim. However, religious differences did not cause his downfall. His arrogance alienated the prominent **Sunni Chagatai nobles**. **Maham Anaga** and other court factions manipulated Akbar against him. Akbar desired to assert his own sovereign authority.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Bairam Khan held the prestigious title of **Khan-i-Khanan**.
 - ✓ He successfully defeated **Hemu** at the **Second Battle of Panipat**.
 - ✓ Akbar officially dismissed Bairam Khan in **1560**.
 - ✓ Bairam Khan rebelled shortly after his dismissal.
 - ✓ Akbar defeated him at the **Battle of Gunachaur**.
 - ✓ Bairam Khan was assassinated by an **Afghan** in **Gujarat** on his way to **Mecca**.

Q 71. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Option A is incorrect:** Yesubai, the wife of Chhatrapati Sambhaji, could not lead the resistance in 1700 because she was a high-profile imperial hostage. Following the fall of Raigad fort in 1689, Mughal forces captured her alongside her infant son, **Shahu**. She remained imprisoned in Aurangzeb's military camp for thirty years, only returning to Maharashtra in 1719 under a treaty negotiated by **Peshwa Balaji Vishwanath**.
- **Option B is correct:** Following Chhatrapati

Rajaram's death at **Sinhagad** in March 1700, his senior widow, **Tarabai**, immediately assumed leadership of the Maratha state. She crowned her infant son, **Shivaji II**, at **Panhala fort** and acted as the supreme regent. She personally directed Maratha commanders to launch devastating cavalry raids into Mughal provinces like **Malwa** and **Gujarat**, successfully sustaining the guerrilla war against Emperor Aurangzeb.

- **Option C is incorrect:** **Soyarabai**, a younger wife of **Chhatrapati Shivaji** and the biological mother of Rajaram, was not alive during this period. Her political influence peaked in 1680 when she unsuccessfully attempted to bypass **Sambhaji** to crown the ten-year-old Rajaram. Following Sambhaji's successful accession to the throne, she was executed in 1681 on charges of treason and conspiracy.
- **Option D is incorrect:** **Ahilyabai Holkar** did not participate in the Mughal-Maratha wars of 1700. Instead, she was the highly capable ruler of the **Holkar dynasty in Malwa**, reigning from **Maheshwar** between 1767 and 1795, long after the Maratha Empire had transitioned into a decentralised confederacy.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Tarabai utilised the decentralised **Saranjami** system, granting prominent military commanders like **Dhanaji Jadhav** autonomous land rights to independently finance and maintain troops against Mughal forces.
 - ✓ The contemporary Mughal historian **Khafi Khan** explicitly praised Tarabai's administrative and military genius in his Persian text **Muntakhab-ul-Lubab**, noting her central role in the Maratha empire's survival.
 - ✓ Following the release of Shahu by the Mughals in 1707, Tarabai fought him for dynastic control but was defeated at the **Battle of Khed**, leading her to establish a rival Maratha court at **Kolhapur**.
 - ✓ To legitimise her political faction, Tarabai publicly declared that Shahu was an imperial impostor cultivated by the Mughals to divide and destroy the Maratha state.
 - ✓ In 1714, Tarabai was overthrown and imprisoned at **Panhala fort** by her co-wife, **Rajasbai**, who placed her own son **Sambhaji II** on the Kolhapur throne, temporarily ending Tarabai's political dominance.

Q 72. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Option A is correct:** After an eight-month siege where the formidable fortress walls successfully withstood continuous heavy artillery bombardment, Aurangzeb ultimately secured victory by heavily bribing a treacherous Afghan noble named **Abdullah Pani**, who secretly opened the main fortress gate (the **Fateh Darwaza**) at midnight, allowing the Mughal forces to suddenly enter and overwhelm the garrison.
- **Option B is incorrect:** Although the Mughal engineering corps dug extensive explosive mines beneath the massive granite walls, the highly vigilant Qutb Shahi forces successfully counter-mined these subterranean tunnels, and a catastrophic premature detonation ended up severely damaging the Mughal trenches and killing hundreds of imperial soldiers instead of breaching the fort.
- **Option C is incorrect:** While a devastating famine and a subsequent cholera epidemic ravaged the Mughal military camp stationed directly outside the fort, the well-prepared defenders inside Golconda possessed incredibly ample food stores and granaries, meaning starvation actually threatened to destroy the besieging imperial army far more than it did the trapped garrison.
- **Option D is incorrect:** The traditional siege tactic of escalade (climbing walls using tall wooden ladders) was rendered completely impossible by the vertical height and smooth construction of Golconda's massive stone battlements, and early, desperate Mughal attempts to physically scale the walls were brutally repulsed by the defenders, ending in disastrous military failures.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The final Mughal campaign to systematically absorb the remaining Deccan sultanates ended with the formal surrender of **Sikandar Adil Shah** of **Bijapur** in September 1686, followed exactly a year later by the capture of **Abul Hasan Qutb Shah** (often referred to as **Tana Shah**) of Golconda in September 1687.
 - ✓ Prior to its annexation, Golconda's immense economic prosperity and staggering political wealth were heavily sustained by its absolute monopoly over the incredibly lucrative global **diamond trade**, specifically the **Kollur Mine** on the banks of the **Krishna River**, which historically produced world-renowned gems like the **Koh-i-Noor** and the **Hope Diamond**.

- ✓ During the brutal eight-month siege of Golconda, the heroic defence of the fortress was primarily orchestrated by the fiercely loyal Qutb Shahi military commander **Abdur Razzaq Lari**, who fought to the end and reportedly sustained over seventy severe sword and lance wounds during the final Mughal breach before finally collapsing.
- ✓ Following the successful capture of the kingdom, Aurangzeb ordered the defeated ruler Abul Hasan Qutb Shah to be permanently imprisoned within the heavily guarded confines of the **Daulatabad fort**, granting him an imperial state pension of 50,000 rupees annually until his eventual death in captivity.
- ✓ By decisively eliminating the independent, stabilising buffer states of **Bijapur** and **Golconda**, Aurangzeb inadvertently brought the sprawling Mughal Empire into direct, unmediated territorial conflict with the highly mobile Maratha light cavalry across the vast, rugged expanses of the Deccan plateau, a monumental strategic miscalculation that overextended imperial supply lines.

Q 73. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** In 1228, Sukapha, a **Tai-Shan prince**, crossed the **Patkai Mountains** into the Brahmaputra valley. He systematically subjugated and assimilated the local indigenous tribes, such as the **Morans** and **Borahis**, and established his first permanent royal capital at Charaideo in 1253.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The Ahoms introduced a strong tradition of compiling meticulous historical records. These official state chronicles, known as **Buranjis**, were initially written in the native **Tai-Ahom language** and were later systematically composed in **Assamese** as the kingdom culturally integrated.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The Ahom economy and military were entirely sustained by the **Paik system**. Every adult male was registered as a **paik** and was legally obligated to render rotational labour or military service to the state.
 - ✓ The kingdom successfully resisted multiple massive Mughal invasions, most notably defeating the imperial forces at the decisive **Battle of Saraighat (1671)** under the legendary Ahom commander **Lachit Borphukan**.

- ✓ Over the centuries, the Ahom rulers gradually underwent Hinduisation. King **Suhungmung** (reigned 1497–1539) was the **first** Ahom sovereign to officially adopt a Hindu title, **Swarganarayan**, marking a major cultural shift in the administration.

Q 74. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Following the death of Emperor Aurangzeb in 1707, **Prince Azam Shah**, acting on the strategic counsel of **Zulfiqar Khan**, authorised the release of Shahu from the Mughal camp at **Doraha**. The primary geopolitical objective was to disrupt the unified Maratha resistance led by Tarabai by introducing a legitimate rival claimant to the throne. This calculated move successfully fractured the Maratha state into two warring factions, one centred at **Satara under Shahu** and the other at **Kolhapur under Tarabai**, effectively neutralising the Maratha threat to Mughal territories during the ensuing imperial succession struggle.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** **Balaji Vishwanath**, an influential **Chitpavan Brahmin** who initially served as a **Karkun** (revenue official), played a pivotal role in consolidating Shahu's authority during the civil war. At the **Battle of Khed** in October 1707, his diplomatic manoeuvring and logistical support were instrumental in Shahu's victory over Tarabai's forces. By successfully persuading powerful Maratha commanders like **Dhanaji Jadhav** to defect from Tarabai's camp to Shahu's side, Balaji Vishwanath secured Shahu's coronation at Satara in **1708** and laid the foundation for his own eventual elevation to the office of Peshwa in **1713**.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Despite being a Mughal captive for eighteen years, Shahu was treated with imperial dignity and received a formal Mughal mansab of 7,000, which influenced his later policy of seeking legitimacy through Mughal farmans.
 - ✓ The Battle of Khed did not permanently end the conflict; the rivalry persisted until **1731**, when the **Treaty of Warna** formally partitioned the Maratha kingdom into the **Northern State (Satara)** and the **Southern State (Kolhapur)**.
 - ✓ Balaji Vishwanath was officially conferred the title of **Sena Karte** (Organiser of Armies) by Shahu in recognition of his role in rebuilding the Maratha military administration after the civil war.

- ✓ Tarabai's faction continued to challenge Shahu by declaring him an imperial puppet, forcing Shahu to rely heavily on the Peshwas to establish administrative control over the rebellious Deshmukhs.
- ✓ Shahu's victory marked a transition from the Chhatrapati-centric administration to a system where the Peshwa emerged as the de facto executive head of the Maratha confederacy.

Q 75. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** While a grand alliance of Sultanates was formed against the de facto ruler **Aliya Rama Raya**, the Sultanate of Berar did not participate. Berar stayed out of the coalition due to its bitter, ongoing territorial feud with Ahmadnagar. The alliance consisted only of **Bijapur, Ahmadnagar, Golconda, and Bidar**.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The battle resulted in the sacking of **Hampi**, but not the end of the empire. Rama Raya's brother, **Tirumala**, escaped the battlefield with the puppet emperor **Sadasiva Raya** and the treasury. He successfully relocated the capital south to **Penukonda** and founded the **Aravidu Dynasty**, which continued to rule for another century.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The Battle of Talikota is also known as the **Battle of Rakshasa-Tangadi**.
 - ✓ During the battle, **Rama Raya** was captured and personally beheaded by **Husain Nizam Shah I**, the Sultan of Ahmadnagar.
 - ✓ The Vijayanagara army was initially dominating the battlefield until two prominent Muslim commanders in Rama Raya's artillery divisions defected to the Sultanates mid-battle, causing the imperial lines to collapse.

Q 76. Ans. D

Explanation:

- In the Mughal agrarian system, the term **Khudkasht** designated **resident** cultivators who held **proprietary rights** over the physical land they farmed within their own ancestral village. These primary agriculturalists constituted the rural elite among the peasantry, typically possessing their own essential farming capital, including ploughs, oxen, and seed.
- **Pahi-kasht** referred to **non-resident** or migrant cultivators who temporarily leased and farmed

land in villages other than their own. This class of peasantry was highly mobile, often driven to migrate and seek better revenue terms elsewhere due to localised famines or oppressive tax extraction by regional officials.

- **Muzarian** (plural of muzara) is a generic Persian administrative term broadly translating to a cultivator, tenant, or peasant, functioning as an overarching demographic classification that does not structurally distinguish between a resident landholder and a migrant labourer.
- **Raiyat** (or Ryot) is a broad administrative and legal term referring generally to a revenue-paying subject or peasant. While utilised during the Mughal period to describe the peasantry en masse, it did not specify the socio-economic residency status of the cultivator, and the term was later heavily institutionalised by British colonial administrators.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Khudkasht peasants formed the dominant socio-economic core of the village community, exercising strict customary control over the utilisation of common village lands, pastures, and water resources.
 - ✓ Operating outside the traditional village hierarchy, Pahi-kasht peasants functioned on a more contractual basis, negotiating their specific revenue demands and tenancy terms directly with the village headman (muqaddam) or local landowning elites.
 - ✓ To maximise agricultural expansion and increase their personal revenue base, local Zamindars actively incentivised Pahi-kasht cultivators to settle and develop newly cleared forests or previously abandoned arable tracts.
 - ✓ During periods of severe economic distress, natural calamities, or famine, structural pressures frequently forced established Khudkasht peasants to abandon their ancestral holdings and migrate, thereby transforming them into Pahi-kasht labourers in neighbouring territories.
 - ✓ Because continuous cultivation was the fundamental basis of imperial taxation, the Mughal state administration implemented stringent administrative measures—and occasionally utilised localised force, in desperate attempts to prevent Khudkasht peasants from abandoning their highly taxed ancestral lands.

Q 77. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Adi Shankara** propounded **Advaita** (Absolute Non-Dualism) in the 8th century. He argued that Brahman is the only reality, and the individual soul (Atman) is entirely identical to Brahman. The material world is merely an illusion (Maya).
 - **Ramanuja** propounded **Vishishtadvaita** (Qualified Non-Dualism) in the 11th century. He argued against Adi Shankara's absolute illusion, stating that while Brahman is the ultimate reality, the individual souls and the material world are real, distinct attributes (or body) of Brahman, completely dependent upon Him but not completely identical.
 - **Madhvacharya** propounded **Dvaita** (Strict Dualism) in the 13th century. He radically opposed Advaita, arguing that Brahman (God), individual souls, and the material world are eternally and fundamentally distinct from one another.
 - **Vallabhacharya** propounded **Shuddhadvaita** (Pure Non-Dualism) in the 15th century. He argued that Brahman is absolutely pure and totally free from Maya. Unlike Adi Shankara, he taught that the physical universe is a real, joyous manifestation of God's essence, not an illusion.
 - Additional facts:
 - ✓ All of these philosophies are **sub-schools** of **Vedanta** (also known as **Uttara Mimamsa**), which is one of the **six orthodox (astika)** schools of Hindu philosophy. They all base their arguments on their specific interpretations of the **Prasthanatrayi** (The Three Sources): The Upanishads, the Brahma Sutras, and the Bhagavad Gita.
 - ✓ Other philosophical schools:
 - **Dvaitadvaita** (Dualistic Non-Dualism) was propounded by **Nimbarkacharya**.
 - **Achintya Bheda Abheda** (Inconceivable Oneness and Difference) was propounded by **Chaitanya Mahaprabhu**.
 - ✓ The central, multi-century debate among all these acharyas revolved around a single, highly complex theological problem: What is the exact mathematical and spiritual relationship between God (Brahman), the individual human soul (Jiva), and the physical universe (Jagat)?
- Persian chronicle **Tabaqat-i-Nasiri**, Lakshmana Sena was taken by surprise at his palace in the pilgrimage centre of Nadia. Following Bakhtiyar Khalji's sudden attack in **1204**, Lakshmana Sena escaped through a back door and relocated his administration to **Sonargaon** in south Bengal, where his dynasty continued to rule.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** After capturing the wealth and royal insignia at Nadia, the Turkish forces under Muhammad bin Bakhtiyar Khalji marched onward and officially occupied the established Sena capital, **Lakhnauti**, without facing any significant military opposition.
 - **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The Sena rulers did not expand into the Brahmaputra valley. It was actually the Turkish commander Bakhtiyar Khalji who foolishly undertook an expedition into the Brahmaputra valley in Assam, where his exhausted army suffered a catastrophic defeat at the hands of the **local Assamese and Magh forces**.
 - Additional facts:
 - ✓ While the Senas lost their western territories and the strategic centre of Lakhnauti, copper-plate inscriptions from the period confirm their sustained administrative and revenue control over eastern and southern Bengal (operating out of Sonargaon) long after the initial Turkish conquest.
 - ✓ Before the Turkish incursions, historical records and regional inscriptions indicate that Lakshmana Sena had been a prominent military leader who had successfully defeated the powerful **Gahadavala** ruler, **Jaichandra**, demonstrating the Sena dynasty's earlier capability to project power beyond Bengal.
 - ✓ The primary evidence detailing the fall of Nadia comes from **Minhaj-i-Siraj's** *Tabaqat-i-Nasiri*. It records that Turkish horse-merchants had become a very common sight in the region, which allowed Bakhtiyar Khalji to disguise his heavily armed vanguard as traders and penetrate the palace grounds without raising any immediate alarm.

Q 79. Ans. B

Explanation:

- The Diwan-i-Riyasat was a specialised economic department created by Alauddin Khilji to enforce his sweeping market control policies. Its primary function was to regulate central commerce, oversee the merchant guilds (banjaras), and strictly maintain the artificially low prices of essential

Q 78. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** According to the primary

commodities (such as grains, cloth, and livestock) across the capital's markets.

- **Additional facts:**

- ✓ The department was headed by the Sadr-i-Riyasat (most notably Malik Yaqub), an overarching commerce minister who held supreme authority over all the individual market superintendents (Shahnas).
- ✓ To ensure absolute compliance and prevent hoarding or black marketing, the Diwan-i-Riyasat maintained a mandatory registry of all wholesale dealers.
- ✓ It operated in tandem with a network of secret spies (Munhiyans) and intelligence officers (Barids), who reported minor price fluctuations and merchant transgressions directly to the Sultan, resulting in brutal punishments for offenders.

Q 80. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Assertion (A) is true:** Following the premature death of Islam Shah in 1553, the highly centralised Sur administration immediately plunged into severe political chaos, leading to the complete structural collapse of the unified Afghan state within a span of merely two years.
- **Reason (R) is true and correctly explains (A):** The sudden political vacuum triggered a massive and destructive civil war as multiple rival claimants fractured the empire's military strength by simultaneously declaring regional sovereignty. Specifically, after Muhammad Adil Shah initially seized the imperial throne, the realm was immediately torn apart by armed rebellions from Sikandar Shah Suri in the Punjab, Ibrahim Shah Suri in Delhi, and Muhammad Shah Suri in Bengal. This internal fragmentation and widespread dynastic infighting systematically destroyed Afghan military supremacy, providing the exact vulnerability required for the Mughal restoration.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Recognising the critical weakness of the divided Afghan forces, Humayun strategically secured his western logistical base by capturing **Kabul** and **Kandahar**, utilising military contingents provided by the **Safavid Shah Tahmasp of Persia**, before launching his decisive invasion of the Indian subcontinent.
 - ✓ The returning Mughal army systematically dismantled the fragmented Sur resistance

through consecutive military victories, decisively defeating the Afghan forces at the **Battle of Machhiwara**, and subsequently crushing the main army of **Sikandar Shah Suri** at the pivotal **Battle of Sirhind in 1555**.

- ✓ Despite the overarching imperial collapse, the eastern Sur faction nominally led by **Muhammad Adil Shah** retained significant military capability, an operational resilience largely sustained by the tactical brilliance and administrative competence of his Hindu prime minister and commanding general, **Hemu**.
- ✓ Emperor Humayun did not survive long enough to formally consolidate this newly reclaimed territory, suffering a fatal fall on the stairs of his library (the Sher Mandal) months after successfully reoccupying the city of Delhi.

Q 81. Ans. D

Explanation:

- In his "forward policy", Baji Rao I used this exact metaphor in the Maratha court to convince Chhatrapati Shahu to bypass Deccan rivals like the Nizam of Hyderabad and directly invade core Mughal provinces such as Malwa, Gujarat, and Rajputana. He argued that the Mughal Empire was fundamentally decaying; by attacking its centre at Delhi (the trunk), the regional Mughal governors and vassal states (the branches) would automatically fall under Maratha control.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Chhatrapati Shahu enthusiastically approved this strategy, reportedly telling Baji Rao that he was the worthy son of a worthy father and would plant the Maratha flag on the Himalayas.
 - ✓ Executing this doctrine, Baji Rao I led a rapid, highly mobile cavalry dash directly to the outskirts of Delhi in 1737, creating panic in the court of Mughal Emperor Muhammad Shah.
 - ✓ This direct offensive strategy culminated in the Battle of Bhopal (1737), where Baji Rao surrounded and defeated the combined forces of the Nizam and the Mughals.
 - ✓ The victory at Bhopal resulted in the Treaty of Doraha Sarai, which formally ceded the entire province of Malwa to the Marathas and granted a war indemnity of 50 lakh rupees.
 - ✓ To manage this rapid territorial expansion, Baji Rao I permanently decentralized military administration by delegating newly conquered northern regions to rising commanders like the Scindias (Gwalior) and Holkars (Indore).

Q 82. Ans. D

Explanation:

- Statement 1 is correct: The Mashrut (meaning conditional in Persian) rank functioned as a specialised administrative mechanism that temporarily augmented a noble's Sawar rank to enhance his immediate cavalry capability without permanently altering his foundational Zat status or requiring a formal, permanent promotion through the standard imperial channels.
- Statement 2 is correct: To maintain operational flexibility during periods of acute military necessity, the imperial administration explicitly issued these conditional ranks to commanders tasked with specific, demanding provincial assignments, such as urgent border campaigns or the suppression of internal rebellions and systematically revoked the supplementary troop allotment the moment the designated military objective was formally concluded.
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ Aurangzeb formally institutionalised the specific administrative category of Mashrut ranks to address the military requirements of his prolonged Deccan campaigns (1681–1707) without permanently inflating the foundational imperial payroll or destabilising the broader ranking hierarchy.
 - ✓ During the latter half of his reign, Aurangzeb integrated an unprecedented number of Maratha and Deccani commanders into the imperial hierarchy, resulting in a significant numerical expansion of the nobility, where the total number of mansabdars increased from approximately 8,000 under Shah Jahan to nearly 14,500 by the year 1690.
 - ✓ This rapid influx of newly appointed nobility directly precipitated the structural economic deficit known as the Jagirdari crisis, characterised by a critical shortage of productive, unassigned state lands (pai-baqi), which frequently forced nobles to wait for extensive periods, often years, to receive their official revenue-generating land assignments.
 - ✓ The chronic inability of the imperial treasury to disburse timely cash salaries or allocate profitable jagirs systemically degraded the military efficiency of the Mughal army, as financially constrained mansabdars were fundamentally unable to maintain their state-mandated cavalry quotas, leading to

widespread military unpreparedness during the critical final years of the empire.

Q 83. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Pair 1 is correctly matched: Allasani Peddana was revered as the **Andhra Kavita Pitamaha** (Grandfather of Telugu Poetry). His magnum opus, **Manucharitramu**, served as the foundational blueprint for all future Telugu Prabandhas.
- Pair 2 is correctly matched: Nandi Thimmana (Mukku Timmana) authored the **Parijatapaharanamu**, a highly celebrated Vaishnavite work dedicated to Emperor Krishnadevaraya.
- Pair 3 is incorrectly matched: Pingali Surana was famous for his complex, dual-meaning poetry and authored the **Raghavapandaveeyamu** and **Kalapurnodayamu**. The highly ornate Vasu Charitramu was actually written by another Ashtadiggaja, **Ramarajabhushanudu** (Bhattumurthi).
- Pair 4 is incorrectly matched: Dhurjati was a devout Shaivite poet who wrote the **Kalahasti Mahatyamu**. The Panduranga Mahatyamu, considered one of the five great Telugu epics, was written by the scholar and legendary wit, **Tenali Ramakrishna**.

Additional facts:

- The primary literary role of the Ashtadiggajas was shifting Telugu literature from the **Age of Translation** (translating Sanskrit epics) to the **Age of Prabandha**. They composed independent, highly structured, and original poetic narratives based on obscure Puranic myths.
- Operating out of the imperial court known as the **Bhuvana Vijayam**, they were not just poets but political assets. By elevating Telugu to a classical imperial standard, they helped Krishnadevaraya project an image of supreme cultural sovereignty across South India.
- The court was a microcosm of Vijayanagara's religious inclusivity. **Shaivite poets (like Dhurjati)** and **Vaishnavite poets (like Nandi Thimmana)** received equal imperial patronage, actively synthesising competing traditions into a unified courtly culture.

Q 84. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Statement 1 is correct: The saints opened the path of bhakti to **everyone**, including women (like Andal) and lower castes who had historically been

excluded from Vedic scholarship and worship. They looked upon religion as a living bond of love rather than formal austerity. However, while they disregarded caste in matters of devotion, they **did not attempt** a broader social revolution to oppose or dismantle the **caste system** as such.

- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The eleven volumes collected under the name **Tirumurai** (compiled in the early 12th century and considered the fifth Veda) represent the sacred writings of the **Saivite Nayanmars**, not the Vaishnavite Alvars. The teachings of the Alvars were separately collected and systematised by acharyas led by **Nathamuni**.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** By rejecting formal Sanskrit and preaching directly in Tamil, the saints easily reached the masses and dominated the religious landscape of the Tamil kingdoms between the **sixth** and **ninth centuries**. However, this same reliance on the local language inherently restricted the geographical spread of their specific movement outside of South India.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The Tirumurai, the eleven-volume collection of Shaivite Nayanmar writings compiled in the early 12th century, is held in such high religious esteem in South India that it is traditionally revered as the “**Fifth Veda**.”
 - ✓ This devotional wave profoundly influenced the broader landscape of Tamil literature. The age of **Kamban** (11th–12th century), who wrote the classic **Tamil Ramayana** while believed to be at the Chola court, is considered a golden age, bringing high Sanskrit epics directly to the vernacular masses.
 - ✓ While the Shaivite hymns were compiled into the Tirumurai, the Vaishnavite hymns of the Alvars (known as the **Nalayira Divya Prabandham**) were collected and systematised by a series of acharyas led by **Nathamuni**, who similarly declared them equivalent to the Vedas.
 - ✓ A fascinating historical irony of their massive success is that by preaching exclusively in Tamil, they easily captured the hearts of the southern masses, but this exact reliance on a localised vernacular inherently limited the outward spread of their specific movement into Northern or Western India.

- The Virashaiva (or Lingayat) saints, including prominent figures like **Basavanna** and **Akka Mahadevi**, communicated their theology and social critique through short, rhythmic prose-poems called **Vachanas** (literally meaning “that which is said” or “sayings”). By composing these exclusively in the colloquial **Kannada** language rather than formal Sanskrit, they ensured their egalitarian message was deeply accessible to the common masses.

- **Additional facts:**

- ✓ The **Virashaivas** actively rejected the worship of Shiva in static, structural temples (which they called **sthavara**), believing instead that the human body itself was the true temple (**jangama**). Followers wear a small personal Linga (the **Ishtalinga**) on their bodies at all times.
- ✓ Basavanna established the **Anubhava Mantapa** (Hall of Spiritual Experience), which acted as an early socio-religious parliament. People from all castes and professions, including women, gathered here to openly discuss spiritual and social issues.
- ✓ Besides Basavanna (a Brahmin minister in the **Kalachuri court**), other incredibly prominent sharanas who composed Vachanas included **Allama Prabhu** and the revered female saint **Akka Mahadevi**, who challenged strict patriarchal norms.
- ✓ A foundational tenet of the movement was the concept of **Kayakave Kailasa** (Work is Heaven). It taught that every profession, regardless of how “menial” orthodox society deemed it, was sacred and a path to spiritual liberation.

Q 86. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Ibrahim Lodi aggressively attempted to expand his empire into Rajputana but was severely defeated by the forces of Rana Sanga at the Battle of Khatoli (1517). This decisive Rajput victory severely weakened Lodi authority and established Mewar as the paramount military power in northern India.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ During this brutal engagement, Rana Sanga famously lost an arm by a sword cut and sustained a severe arrow wound to his leg, leaving him with a permanent limp.
 - ✓ The Rajput forces successfully captured a prominent Lodi prince during the battle, who

Q 85. Ans. B

Explanation:

was only released back to the Sultan after the payment of a massive financial ransom.

- ✓ Following Khatoli, Ibrahim Lodi dispatched another army under his commander **Mian Makhan**, to avenge the humiliation, but this force was also completely routed by Rana Sanga at the subsequent **Battle of Dholpur**.

Q 87. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correctly matched:** Hemu adopted the royal title of **Vikramaditya**. He commanded his forces from atop an elephant named **Hawai**. He personally led the powerful central division of the army. His devastating elephant charge initially broke the Mughal wings.
- **Pair 2 is correctly matched:** Ali Quli Khan Shaibani commanded the Mughal vanguard. He intercepted Hemu's artillery train before the main battle. This preemptive strike severely weakened the Afghan offensive capability. He played a crucial role in the final victory.
- **Pair 3 is incorrectly matched:** Sikandar Shah Suri was not present at Panipat. He was fighting Mughal forces in the distant Punjab hills. **Shadi Khan Kakkar** and **Ramya** commanded the Afghan flanks. Hemu acted as the supreme commander of Adil Shah's forces.
- **Pair 4 is correctly matched:** Iskandar Khan Uzbek commanded the Mughal right wing. **Abdullah Khan Uzbek** commanded the left wing. The Mughal wings initially collapsed under Hemu's elephant assault. They rallied only after Hemu was gravely wounded.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ During the Second Battle of Panipat, Hemu was struck in the eye by a stray arrow, which incapacitated him at a decisive moment in the battle. His sudden collapse created confusion within his ranks, leading to panic and the eventual disintegration of his army.
 - ✓ Seizing the advantage, the Mughal forces under Bairam Khan captured the unconscious Hemu and ordered his execution soon after. This act was symbolically significant, as it is often associated with Akbar being conferred the title of Ghazi.
 - ✓ The Mughal victory in this battle decisively re-established their authority over North India, marking a crucial turning point in the consolidation of the Mughal Empire.

Q 88. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Option A is correct:** Bejagiri translates to the absence of available jagirs. As the number of imperial nobles expanded under Aurangzeb's prolonged military campaigns in the Deccan, the total amount of available productive land remained static. This structural imbalance created a systemic shortage of revenue assignments necessary to compensate the growing nobility.
- **Option B is incorrect:** **Ijara** refers to the practice of **revenue farming**, where the state or a noble auctioned tax collection rights to regional bidders. While this practice exacerbated peasant impoverishment, it functioned as a secondary symptom of the state's financial decline rather than the structural root cause of the crisis.
- **Option C is incorrect:** **Khalisa** denoted the **crown lands**, the revenue of which was routed directly to the imperial treasury. To finance his ongoing military expenditures, Aurangzeb actively expanded the Khalisa lands late in his reign, a policy that further reduced the pool of land available for jagir assignments.
- **Option D is incorrect:** **Taccavi** refers to **state-sponsored agricultural loans** disbursed to peasants during famines or droughts to facilitate the purchase of seeds and livestock, an administrative mechanism designed to stabilise cultivation.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ By the end of Aurangzeb's reign in 1707, the total number of mansabdars had increased to approximately 14,449, drastically depleting the reserve of unassigned, productive state lands known as **pai-baqi**.
 - ✓ The historian **Irfan Habib**, in his 1963 work *The Agrarian System of Mughal India*, articulated that the frequent transfer of jagirdars incentivised them to extract maximum short-term revenue, which systematically degraded the agricultural base over time.
 - ✓ The intense, localised revenue extraction by economically strained nobles directly precipitated organised agrarian uprisings in the northern provinces, including the Jat rebellion led by **Gokula** in the Mathura region in **1669** and the **Satnami revolt** in **Narnaul** in **1672**.
 - ✓ Due to the acute shortage of viable jagirs, the imperial administration increasingly assigned nobles to **zor-talab territories** (areas controlled by resistant zamindars where revenue

collection required constant military force), which severely impeded the nobles' financial ability to maintain their state-mandated sawar (cavalry) contingents.

Q 89. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Nathamuni (an 8th-9th century Vaishnavite theologian) was the **first Sri Vaishnava acharya**. He is famously credited with travelling across South India to recover the lost hymns of the Alvars, systematically compiling them into the Nalayira Divya Prabandham, and setting them to music for temple recitation.
- Ramanuja was a much later, immensely famous **Vaishnavite philosopher** (11th-12th century) who propounded the doctrine of **Vishishtadvaita** (qualified non-dualism). While he heavily utilised the Prabandham in his philosophy, he was not its compiler.
- **Nambi** (specifically Nambi Andar Nambi) was the scholar who compiled the **Shaivite** equivalent of this text. He collected the hymns of the Nayanmars into the eleven-volume Tirumurai.
- Kambar was the great Tamil poet of the Chola period (11th-12th century) who authored the Ramavataram, the celebrated Tamil classic epic based on the Ramayana.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The term Nalayira translates to "Four Thousand," referring to the approximately 4,000 Tamil verses contained within the compilation.
 - ✓ Because of **Nathamuni's** efforts, this text was formally elevated to the exact same ritual and theological status as the Sanskrit Vedas within the Sri Vaishnava tradition, earning it the title of the "**Tamil Veda**" or "**Dravida Veda**."
 - ✓ The compilation contains the passionate, devotional poetry of all twelve Alvars, prominently including the female saint **Andal** (who composed the famous Tiruppavai) and **Nammalvar** (whose verses make up the largest portion of the text).

Q 90. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The state utilised Madad-i-Maash grants to facilitate economic development by assigning tracts of barren wasteland to religious scholars, thereby creating a structural incentive to

clear forests and expand agricultural cultivation into peripheral territories.

- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** These charitable land grants were not initially hereditary; early Mughal emperors routinely reassigned the lands upon a grantee's death until Aurangzeb officially rendered them hereditary through an imperial decree in 1690.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** The Sadr-us-Sudur exercised central authority over religious patronage, verifying the credentials of applicants, maintaining the official records of tax-free land assignments, and possessing the administrative prerogative to cancel fraudulent claims.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ These specific land assignments were structurally exempt from standard imperial revenue assessments.
 - ✓ While the grantee held the right to collect the local revenue, the Mughal state legally retained the ultimate proprietary ownership of the physical land.
 - ✓ The imperial administration distributed these charitable grants to prominent religious figures and institutions across both Hindu and Islamic traditions.
 - ✓ Over successive generations, many Madad-i-Maash grantees consolidated local economic power and effectively evolved into regional zamindars.
 - ✓ Women belonging to respected scholarly or administrative families were legally eligible to receive and manage these state land assignments.
 - ✓ In certain administrative instances, the state substituted physical land grants with direct cash stipends paid from the imperial treasury.

Q 91. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Al-Biruni sharply criticised the insular attitude of the learned Brahmins, noting they were niggardly in communicating knowledge and took great care to withhold it from other castes and foreigners.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** According to Foreign Travellers' Accounts and historiography, Al-Biruni compiled his monumental ethnographic work, Kitab-ul-Hind, in the Arabic language, not Persian.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** He was a noted scientist and scholar from Central Asia who lived in India for about ten years during the early part of the eleventh century.

- **Statement 4 is correct:** Even though he found the Brahmans to be haughty, vain, and self-conceited, he remained a great admirer of Indian science and learning. Comprehensive
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ **Kitab-ul-Hind** stands as a masterclass in objective primary evidence. Al-Biruni extensively translated Sanskrit texts and meticulously recorded India's mathematical, astronomical, and philosophical achievements, demonstrating a deep methodological rigour rarely seen in medieval chronicles.
 - ✓ While the Ghaznavid court under Mahmud (Al-Biruni's contemporary) heavily patronised the **Iranian cultural** renaissance and the Persian language (such as **Firdausi's Shah Namah**), Al-Biruni deliberately chose **Arabic** for **Kitab-ul-Hind** due to its established status as the lingua franca of international scientific discourse at the time.
 - ✓ Al-Biruni's specific observations on Brahmanical exclusivity explain the broader stagnation of Indian science during this period. The refusal to share scientific knowledge, coupled with an increasing isolation from the main currents of thought outside India, is cited as a primary reason Indian scientific advancement slowed down.

Q 92. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correctly matched:** According to Ziauddin Barani's *Tarikh-i-Firoz Shahi*, the 1299 Gujarat campaign was led by Alauddin's generals **Nusrat Khan** and **Ulugh Khan**. They defeated the **Vaghela ruler, Rai Karan**, who fled south to seek refuge in **Devagiri**.
- **Pair 2 is incorrectly matched:** The ruler of Ranthambore during the 1301 siege was the **Chauhan king Hamir Deva**, not **Pratap Rudra Deva**. Amir Khusrau's *Khazain-ul-Futuh* details how Alauddin personally took command of this siege after his general **Nusrat Khan** was killed by a stone from a siege engine. **Pratap Rudra Deva** was actually the **Kakatiya** ruler of Warangal, defeated much later during the Deccan campaigns.
- **Pair 3 is correctly matched:** As per **Amir Khusrau's Khazain-ul-Futuh** Alauddin besieged and captured the formidable fort of Chittor in 1303, defeating the **Guhila king, Rawal Ratan Singh**.
- **Pair 4 is incorrectly matched:** The ruler of Malwa defeated in 1305 by the Khilji commander

Ain-ul-Mulk Multani was **Mahalak Deva**. **Ramachandra Deva** was the **Yadava king** of **Devagiri**, who was subdued by **Malik Kafur** in **1307**.

● **Additional facts:**

- ✓ The Ranthambore campaign was explicitly triggered because Hamir Deva granted asylum to rebel "New Muslim" (Mongol convert) commanders, most notably **Muhammad Shah**, who had mutinied over the distribution of the war booty from the Gujarat campaign.
- ✓ During the sack of Gujarat, the Khilji army looted the wealthy port city of **Khambhat** (Cambay). Here, **Nusrat Khan** forcefully acquired a prominent **Hindu slave** named **Malik Kafur** for 1,000 dinars (Hazar-Dinari), who would later convert to Islam and lead Alauddin's massive southern expeditions.
- ✓ Following the bloody victory at Chittor, Alauddin ordered the massacre of **30,000 local Rajputs**. He subsequently renamed the fort **Khizrabad** in honour of his son, **Khizr Khan**, and appointed him as the region's governor.

Q 93. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Islam Shah Suri centralised judicial administration by issuing detailed, codified state regulations (**zawabit**), a structural policy designed to bypass the traditional reliance on orthodox Islamic clerics (**ulema**) and ensure uniform adherence to written royal decrees across the empire.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Rather than granting political autonomy to unite the nobility, Islam Shah exhibited deep suspicion toward the prominent Afghan chieftains. He actively dismantled their independent regional power bases and centralised all military and administrative authority firmly under his direct personal command.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Prior to his royal accession and assumption of the imperial title, Islam Shah was known as **Jalal Khan**.
 - ✓ He successfully suppressed a major armed rebellion orchestrated by the powerful **Niazi Afghan tribe** in the Punjab region.
 - ✓ For strategic and administrative purposes, he officially shifted the imperial capital from Agra to the formidable fortress city of **Gwalior**.
 - ✓ The emperor established a highly efficient, pervasive **espionage network** to constantly monitor the political activities of the provincial nobility.

- ✓ To assert absolute royal supremacy and dismantle tribal egalitarianism, he strictly prohibited the traditional Afghan custom of noblemen sharing the royal carpet or sitting in the presence of the monarch.
- ✓ These severe centralisation policies ultimately generated significant resentment and alienation among the traditional tribal chiefs, systemically weakening the foundational political support of the Sur dynasty prior to Humayun's return.

Q 94. Ans. A

Explanation:

- In the Mughal agrarian system, Zamindars functioned as powerful rural aristocrats who held customary, hereditary rights over specific territories, acting as vital structural intermediaries who collected land revenue from the peasantry on behalf of the imperial treasury.
- The Muqaddam served merely as a local village headman who assisted in foundational village-level revenue collection and local administration, but completely lacked the extensive, autonomous hereditary privileges and regional influence of a Zamindar.
- The Patwari was strictly a local village accountant exclusively responsible for maintaining official agrarian and revenue records, holding absolutely no independent military or revenue-extracting authority.
- A Mansabdar was a state-appointed imperial military and administrative officer who was subjected to frequent geographic transfers by the central government and was structurally denied permanent, hereditary rights over their assigned lands or revenue grants.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The Zamindar legally retained a fixed percentage of the collected agricultural revenue as official remuneration for their local administrative and collection services.
 - ✓ This specific hereditary, proprietary claim over the land and its associated revenue-collection rights was legally defined in Mughal terminology as *milkiyat*.
 - ✓ To enforce local authority, suppress peasant resistance, and facilitate revenue collection, Zamindars routinely maintained their own private armed militias, including infantry and cavalry contingents.
 - ✓ They typically consolidated their regional

military and political power by constructing small, localised fortified strongholds formally known as *garhis*.

- ✓ Demographically and socially, the vast majority of these entrenched rural elites belonged to dominant upper-caste lineages, predominantly drawn from Rajput or Brahmin communities.
- ✓ During periods of acute agrarian crisis or severe state over-extraction, organised peasant rebellions frequently received direct military leadership, sanctuary, and logistical support from disgruntled local Zamindars seeking to protect their own regional autonomy.

Q 95. Ans. D

Explanation:

- In April 1758, a joint Maratha-Sikh coalition led by Raghunathrao successfully expelled the Afghan forces of **Timur Shah Durrani** from the Punjab, culminating in the capture of the strategic fort of **Attock** on the banks of the Indus River. This specific military victory represented the absolute zenith of Maratha territorial expansion, fulfilling the ideological ambition of extending their imperial influence from Cuttack to Attock.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The capture of Attock was facilitated by a strategic alliance between Maratha commander **Raghunathrao** and **Adina Beg Khan**, the ambitious faujdar of the Jalandhar Doab.
 - ✓ Following the conquest, **Sabaji Scindia** was appointed to command the Maratha garrison stationed at Attock, specifically tasked with guarding the Indus frontier against retaliatory Durrani invasions.
 - ✓ The Maratha treasury was severely strained by this northwestern expedition, yielding a crushing debt of 80 lakh rupees instead of profitable tribute, directly compromising their financial readiness for the subsequent **Third Battle of Panipat**.
 - ✓ **Malhar Rao Holkar** played a critical vanguard role with Raghunathrao in crossing the **Sutlej River** during this campaign, systematically routing the Afghan detachments stationed at **Sirhind** before the main assault on **Lahore**.
 - ✓ The Maratha occupation of the Punjab directly triggered **Ahmad Shah Abdali's** devastating 1759 invasion of India, as the Afghan monarch mobilised to reclaim his lost tributary provinces.

Q 96. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Chaitanya Mahaprabhu** (1486–1534) was a profoundly influential Bengali saint who revolutionised the Bhakti movement in Eastern India. He popularised the Sankirtan or Kirtan movement, which involved the ecstatic, congregational singing and dancing to the holy names of God (specifically Krishna) in public spaces.
- He also propounded the complex Vedantic philosophy of **Achintya Bheda Abheda**, which translates to the “inconceivable oneness and difference” between the Supreme Brahman (God) and the individual soul.
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ He is the foundational and most revered figure of **Gaudiya Vaishnavism** (Bengali Vaishnavism). His followers consider him to be the combined avatar of **Radha and Krishna**.
 - ✓ The Sankirtan movement was highly democratic. Chaitanya fiercely disregarded caste rigidities, untouchability, and religious creeds. He initiated people from all backgrounds into his fold, most notably the Muslim-born saint **Haridasa Thakur**.
 - ✓ Although he was born in **Navadwip** (Bengal) and spent his final years in **Puri** (Odisha) immersed in deep devotional trance at the **Jagannath Temple**, he directed his chief disciples, the “**Six Goswamis**”, to travel to Mathura and Vrindavan. They successfully excavated the lost holy sites of Krishna and established Vrindavan as the central theological hub of the sect.
 - ✓ While Chaitanya himself wrote almost nothing except the **eight-verse Siksastakam**, his life and ecstatic devotion inspired a massive corpus of Bengali and Sanskrit biographical literature, the most famous being the **Chaitanya Charitamrita** by **Krishnadasa Kaviraja**.

Q 97. Ans. C

Explanation:

- The primary building utilises a distinct **octagonal footprint**. This eight-sided structural design represents the architectural culmination of the **Afghan style** in the subcontinent, positioned centrally within the artificial water body.
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ The structural design and construction of the

122-foot high red sandstone mausoleum were overseen by the principal architect, **Aliwal Khan**.

- ✓ Physical access to the central island tomb from the mainland is facilitated by a continuous stone causeway.
- ✓ Historical records indicate that the exterior of the primary dome originally featured a white glazed tile finish.
- ✓ The architectural composition systematically integrates traditional indigenous elements, such as **chhatris** (domed pavilions) and **corbelled brackets**, with established Islamic structural forms.
- ✓ The central interior chamber functions as a dynastic crypt, containing the graves of Sher Shah Suri alongside several immediate family members.
- ✓ Although commissioned and substantially built during Sher Shah’s lifetime, the formal completion of the mausoleum occurred in **1545** during the reign of his son and successor, **Islam Shah Suri**.

Q 98. Ans. C

Explanation:

- Kavitawali was not composed by Surdas; it is a famous work by the 16th-century poet **Goswami Tulsidas**, who was a devotee of Lord Rama. Surdas, a profound devotee of Lord Krishna, is historically credited with composing three major literary works: the monumental **Sursagar (Ocean of Melody)**, the **Sur Saravali**, and the **Sahitya Lahari**.
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ Surdas was a prominent disciple of **Vallabhacharya** and followed his **Shuddhadvaita** (Pure Non-Dualism) philosophy and the **Pushtimarg** (Path of Grace) sect.
 - ✓ He was the foremost poet among the **Ashtachhap**, a highly venerated group of eight Krishna-bhakti poets established by Vallabhacharya’s son, **Vitthalnath**.
 - ✓ He composed his ecstatic devotional poetry almost exclusively in **Braj Bhasha** (a dialect of Hindi). This significantly elevated the literary status of the dialect.
 - ✓ Unlike saints who worshipped a formless God (Nirguna), Surdas was a champion of **Saguna Bhakti** (devotion to a God with attributes). The **Sursagar** focuses heavily on the Bala Lila (the endearing childhood exploits) and the romantic youth of **Lord Krishna** in Vrindavan.

- ✓ According to traditional biographical accounts, particularly the **Chaurasi Vaishnavan ki Varta**, Surdas was blind from birth and resided near the holy city of Mathura.

Q 99. Ans. D

Explanation:

- **Assertion (A) is false:** The Din-i-Ilahi was never established as a formal, traditional religion, as it completely lacked a designated priesthood, sacred scriptures, formalised theology, or specialised places of worship; rather, it functioned primarily as an elite socio-religious code of conduct and a formalised spiritual discipleship centred directly around the person of the emperor.
- **Reason (R) is true:** The principle of Sulh-i-Kul (universal peace), which formed the overarching ideological bedrock of Akbar's later reign, mandated absolute religious tolerance and harmony, explicitly rejecting religious discrimination in state affairs and ensuring that diverse ethnic and religious groups were treated equitably within the Mughal administrative framework.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The contemporary sources authored by Abul Fazl, most notably the **Ain-i-Akbari**, never use the term Din-i-Ilahi, but instead refer to this specific spiritual discipleship as **Tauhid-i-Ilahi** (Divine Monotheism).
 - ✓ The initiation ceremony for this order strictly occurred on Sundays, during which the prospective disciple would place his turban at the emperor's feet and receive a **Shast** (a ring or medallion) engraved with the "Great Name" and a portrait of Akbar.
 - ✓ The adherents of this imperial order were bound by highly specific behavioural mandates, including greeting one another with the phrase "Allahu Akbar" (to which the response was "Jalla Jalalahu"), hosting grand feasts on their birth anniversaries, and abstaining entirely from the consumption of meat during their birth month.
 - ✓ Despite its prominence in modern historical debates regarding Akbar's religious policies, the order remained an extremely restricted inner circle of the Mughal elite, comprising only about eighteen core members, with **Raja Birbal** standing out as the only prominent Hindu noble to ever formally accept the discipleship.

Q 100. Ans. B

Explanation:

- The Iqta system was the bedrock of the Sultanate's provincial administration. A Wali or Muqti was a provincial governor assigned a specific territory (Iqta). Their primary responsibility was to collect the assessed land revenue (Kharaj) from this area. From these collections, they were required to deduct their personal salary and, crucially, maintain a specified quota of equipped cavalry and infantry to fight for the Sultan upon request. They were also mandated to send the surplus revenue (**Fawazil**) directly to the central treasury (**Diwan-i-Wazarat**).
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The Iqta was strictly a revenue and administrative assignment; it did not confer permanent ownership rights over the land itself or the peasants.
 - ✓ To prevent governors from becoming too powerful, establishing local roots, or rebelling against the crown, early Sultans like Iltutmish and Balban frequently transferred Muqtis from one province to another, typically every three to four years.
 - ✓ During the reign of **Firoz Shah Tughlaq**, the Iqta system was disastrously made **hereditary**. This policy severely weakened the central authority and contributed directly to the eventual fragmentation of the Sultanate into regional kingdoms.

Q 101. Ans. C

Explanation:

- In the comprehensive land revenue system codified by Todar Mal, **Polaj** designated the **highest** tier of agricultural land that remained under continuous cultivation every single year without ever being left fallow, making it subject to standard annual state taxation.
- **Parauti** referred to land that was **intentionally left fallow** for a brief duration, typically a year or two, to allow the soil to naturally recover its agricultural fertility before active cultivation resumed.
- **Chachar** denoted land that had remained uncultivated for a period of **three to four years**, prompting the imperial administration to apply a heavily reduced, graduated tax rate to incentivise its gradual return to active agricultural use.
- **Banjar** categorised **barren or severely degraded** land left uncultivated for five consecutive years

or more; the state levied nominal or zero taxation on this category to systematically encourage its eventual reclamation.

● **Additional facts:**

- ✓ The imperial revenue administration assessed both Polaj and actively cultivated Parauti lands at the standard maximum tax rates.
- ✓ Once a plot of Parauti land was formally brought back into active cultivation, it was immediately subjected to the precise standard tax rate applied to Polaj land.
- ✓ For the purpose of highly accurate tax calculation, the administration further subdivided the Polaj land into three distinct yield categories: good, middling, and bad.
- ✓ The state calculated its official revenue demand by averaging the yield of these three sub-grades and officially extracting exactly **one-third** of that average produce as the standard imperial tax.
- ✓ Due to its uninterrupted, high-yield fertility, peasants primarily utilised Polaj land for the continuous cultivation of lucrative cash crops.
- ✓ This highly rationalised, four-tier land classification system is meticulously documented within **Abu'l-Fazl's** foundational administrative text, the **Ain-i-Akbari**.

Q 102. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti (revered as Gharib Nawaz) is historically credited with establishing the Chishti silsila in India. He arrived in the subcontinent from Central Asia and settled in Ajmer around 1192 CE, shortly after **Muizuddin Muhammad Ghori** defeated **Prithviraj Chauhan** in the **Second Battle of Tarain**. Ajmer was a strategic choice as it was a major political and religious hub.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** The foundational philosophy of the early Chishti saints was to maintain a strict distance from the state apparatus. They vehemently refused to accept jagirs (state land grants) or political titles, believing that association with the royal court would corrupt their spiritual purity. They relied entirely on **futuh** (unsolicited charity). In contrast, it was the **Suhrawardi** order that actively accepted state patronage and high religious posts (like **Shaikh-ul-Islam**).
- **Additional fact:**
 - ✓ His teachings were rooted in **Sulh-i-Kul** (peace with all). He drew massive crowds of

both Muslims and Hindus due to his ascetic lifestyle, tolerance, and empathy for the poor, helping bridge the socio-religious divide in early medieval India.

- ✓ A defining characteristic of the Chishti order that he popularised was the use of **Sama**, ecstatic musical gatherings (which eventually evolved into modern Qawwali) as a legitimate means to induce a state of spiritual trance and connect with the Divine. This practice was deeply **criticised** by orthodox Islamic clerics (**Ulema**).
- ✓ Although the saint himself avoided kings, his tomb (Dargah) in Ajmer later became one of the most venerated pilgrimage sites in South Asia. The Mughal Emperor **Akbar** famously made multiple pilgrimages on foot from Agra to Ajmer to pray at his shrine.
- ✓ His spiritual legacy was carried forward by immensely prominent disciples, most notably **Khwaja Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki** (after whom the Qutub Minar is named) and **Baba Farid**.

Q 103. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Shuja-ud-Daula, the Nawab of Awadh, actively aligned his military and financial resources with Ahmad Shah Abdali for the Third Battle of Panipat (1761). Despite initial Maratha diplomatic overtures, Shuja-ud-Daula was persuaded by the Rohilla chief Najib-ud-Daula, who framed the Afghan campaign as a holy war (Jihad) against Maratha expansion. Geopolitically, Shuja-ud-Daula feared the aggressive Maratha encroachment into the fertile Doab region more than Afghan hegemony. His defection was strategically catastrophic for Sadashivrao Bhau, as it denied the Marathas a vital logistical supply base in northern India and provided Abdali with crucial regional funding and geographical intelligence.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The Maratha artillery was commanded by Ibrahim Khan Gardi, who deployed European-trained, disciplined infantry (Telingas) and field guns that initially devastated the Afghan right wing before being outflanked.
 - ✓ Ahmad Shah Abdali countered the Maratha heavy artillery by effectively utilising highly mobile, camel-mounted swivel guns called zamburaks, which fired over the heads of his own advancing infantry to shatter the Maratha squares.
 - ✓ Prior to the decisive engagement on January

14, Abdali executed a brilliant strategic manoeuvre by crossing the Yamuna River at Baghpat, severing the Maratha supply lines to Delhi and subjecting Bhau's enclosed camp to a two-month siege.

- ✓ The most authoritative primary Persian eyewitness account of the battle and its diplomatic preludes, *Ahwal-i-Jang-i-Bhau wa Ahmad Shah Abdali*, was authored by Kashiraj Pandit in Persian, a prominent Maratha scribe employed in the court of Shuja-ud-Daula.
- ✓ The catastrophic Maratha defeat, which obliterated a generation of military leadership, including Vishwasrao, was conveyed to the Peshwa through a cryptic banker's dispatch: "Two pearls have been dissolved, twenty-seven gold coins have been lost, and of the silver and copper, the total cannot be cast up."

Q 104. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** To reach the fabulously rich temple of Somnath in 1025, Mahmud marched via Multan and Jaisalmer with a regular cavalry of 30,000.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Upon his approach, the commander of the city fled, but the citizens put up a stout resistance before the temple was sacked.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** No attempt was made by Mahmud to annex any of these Indian states; his raids were aimed strictly at plundering rich temples and towns.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Somnath had a broader psychological objective, which was to create a sense of awe and shock among the Rajput rulers who had recently emerged. Furthermore, the wealth looted was primarily used to finance his ongoing military struggles against his enemies in **Central Asia**.
 - ✓ While his memory in India is that of a plunderer and destroyer of temples, medieval Persian chronicles consider him a hero of Islam for his stout defence of Islamic lands against Central Asian Turkish tribal invaders and his association with the **Iranian cultural renaissance**.
 - ✓ Before Somnath, his most daring plundering raids were directed against Kanauj in 1018, where he sacked both **Mathura** and **Kanauj**, and an invasion of **Kalinjar** in Bundelkhand the following year.

Q 105. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** According to Barani's *Tarikh-i-Firoz Shahi*, Alauddin Khilji introduced these strict military regulations to maintain a massive, highly efficient standing army paid directly in **cash** (*nagad*) from the state treasury, effectively bypassing corrupt feudal *Iqtadars*.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** To defraud the **Diwan-i-Arz** (military department), soldiers frequently presented borrowed or inferior horses during annual inspections. Alauddin instituted the *Dagh* (branding) system, where every approved warhorse received a permanent royal mark. Simultaneously, the **Chehra** (or *Huliya*) system maintained a detailed physical description of every soldier to prevent the hiring of proxies.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** These systems were highly successful and became foundational to later Indian military administration. **Sher Shah Suri** vigorously revived the *Dagh* and *Chehra* regulations to discipline his Afghan contingents. Later, Akbar formally incorporated these identical practices into his comprehensive **Mansabdari** system, as explicitly recorded in the *Ain-i-Akbari*.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Before Alauddin Khilji, the Delhi Sultanate relied heavily on the *Iqta* system, where provincial nobles provided military contingents when requested. Alauddin was the **first** Sultan of Delhi to maintain a permanent, centrally administered standing army (**Wajh-i-Hashm**).
 - ✓ The central troops were paid a strictly fixed salary to match the regulated market prices: a fully equipped cavalryman (**Murattab**) received 234 tankas annually. A soldier maintaining a second horse (**Do-Aspa**) received an additional allowance of 78 tankas.
 - ✓ The overarching administration of these reforms was entrusted to the **Ariz-i-Mumalik** (**Minister of War**), who personally oversaw the recruitment processes, updated the descriptive rolls, and commanded the regular muster parades.

Q 106. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** The *Mahzar* did not claim universal Islamic leadership, nor did it attempt to challenge or transfer the spiritual authority of the

Ottoman Caliphate; rather, it merely designated Akbar as the **Imam-i-Adil** (just ruler) and the final arbiter of Islamic law strictly within his own dominions, granting him the definitive power to choose between the conflicting legal interpretations of various Islamic scholars.

- **Statement 2 is correct:** Because the early Mughal court was heavily dominated by powerful, orthodox Islamic clerics like **Makh-dum-ul-Mulk** and **Sheikh Abdun Nabi**, who frequently persecuted liberal thinkers, **Sheikh Mubarak** (the father of Abul Fazl) drafted this decree specifically to empower the emperor and effectively strip the conservative Ulema of their ultimate veto power over state policies.

- **Additional facts:**

- ✓ Furthermore, the decree placed a crucial secular constraint on the emperor's religious authority by demanding that his legal interpretations could not contradict the general welfare of his subjects, ensuring that state policies remained practically beneficial to the diverse population.
- ✓ To ensure the document carried supreme legal weight, the leading orthodox Islamic scholars of the court were essentially forced to sign the decree, which severely humiliated the conservative faction and triggered immense outrage among orthodox Muslims who viewed it as a dangerous deviation from traditional governance.
- ✓ By decisively breaking the monopoly of the conservative clergy over religious and state affairs, the Mahzar laid the essential ideological and political groundwork for Akbar's later, highly syncretic religious experiments, most notably the articulation of **Sulh-i-Kul** (universal peace) and the formulation of the **Din-i-Ilahi**.

absorbed Marwar into the imperial Khalisa (state-managed lands) pending a succession decision, and subsequently elevated a rival Rathore claimant, Indra Singh of Nagaur, to the throne of Jodhpur in May 1679 in exchange for a substantial succession fee (peshkash) of thirty-six lakh rupees.

- **Additional facts:**

- ✓ Following Jaswant Singh's death, his pregnant queens gave birth to posthumous sons, including **Ajit Singh**, at **Lahore** in February 1679, prompting Aurangzeb to demand that the infant prince be raised at the imperial court in **Delhi** under state supervision until he reached maturity, a condition the **Rathore** nobility viewed as a profound threat to their dynastic autonomy.
- ✓ Rejecting this imperial mandate, the Rathore contingent led by **Durgadas Rathore** executed a tactical extraction of the infant prince and the queens from the Mughal capital in July 1679, directly initiating a protracted, decentralised insurgency against Mughal administrative outposts across the **Marwar** territory.
- ✓ The regional conflict significantly escalated when **Maharana Raj Singh** of **Mewar**, feeling structurally threatened by the Mughal military absorption of neighbouring Marwar and the simultaneous imperial re-imposition of the Jizya tax, formally entered into an armed coalition with the Rathore insurgents.
- ✓ During the ensuing military campaigns in Rajputana, the allied Rajput forces successfully persuaded Aurangzeb's son, **Prince Akbar**, to rebel against the imperial centre, leading the prince to formally declare himself the independent Mughal sovereign at **Nadol** in January 1681 with the backing of four Rajput clans.
- ✓ Aurangzeb neutralised this severe dynastic threat by engineering a sophisticated psychological warfare operation, deliberately planting forged correspondence that convinced the Rajput leadership that Prince Akbar was secretly coordinating a trap with the imperial army, a manoeuvre that successfully fractured the rebel coalition without a major pitched battle and forced Akbar to flee to the **Maratha court of Sambhaji**.

Q 107. Ans. D

Explanation:

- **Assertion (A) is false:** Aurangzeb's initial annexation of Marwar was not driven by a monolithic policy of mass religious conversion, but rather by pressing geopolitical and strategic imperatives, specifically the necessity of securing direct administrative control over the vital commercial routes that traversed Marwar, connecting the imperial capital of Delhi to the lucrative maritime ports of Gujarat.
- **Reason (R) is true:** Following the demise of Maharaja Jaswant Singh at the remote Afghan outpost of Jamrud in December 1678 without a recognized surviving male heir, Aurangzeb initially

Q 108. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Sadashivrao Bhau relied heavily on European-style

static heavy artillery commanded by **Ibrahim Khan Gardi**. While these cannons initially inflicted massive casualties, they could not be easily repositioned once the battle became fluid. Ahmad Shah Abdali tactically countered this by deploying highly mobile, camel-mounted swivel guns known as zamburaks. These light guns were rapidly redeployed and fired continuously over the heads of the advancing Afghan infantry, effectively shattering the Maratha squares.

● **Additional facts:**

- ✓ The Afghan right wing, commanded by Hafiz Rahmat Khan and Dundi Khan, suffered devastating early casualties from the disciplined musket volleys of Gardi's French-trained Telinga infantry.
- ✓ A critical Maratha tactical error occurred when cavalry units under Damaji Gaikwad prematurely broke formation to charge the Afghans, inadvertently blocking the firing line of their own artillery.
- ✓ Ahmad Shah Abdali maintained a strictly disciplined reserve force of 10,000 armoured Kizilbash cavalry, deploying them late in the afternoon to decisively break the exhausted Maratha centre.
- ✓ The Maratha right wing, led by Malhar Rao Holkar, remained largely inactive during the climax of the fighting and eventually retreated from the battlefield to save his contingent.
- ✓ Abdali successfully utilised a classic Central Asian enveloping tactic (tulughma), using his superior cavalry numbers to outflank the Maratha line and attack the non-combatants in the rear.

Q 109. Ans. C

Explanation:

- Zain-ul-Abidin (1420–1470) reversed the brutal, orthodox policies of his predecessor, **Sikandar Shah** (known as the 'Idol-breaker'). He established an era of profound religious tolerance by officially recalling exiled Kashmiri Pandits, abolishing the **Jizya** and cremation taxes, banning cow slaughter, and actively financing the **rebuilding** of demolished Hindu temples.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ He established a royal translation bureau that translated the **Mahabharata** and **Kalhana's Rajatarangini** into **Persian**, as well as Persian treatises into Sanskrit. He also patronised

Sanskrit scholars like **Jonaraja** and **Srivara**, who were commissioned to update the historical timeline of the **Rajatarangini**.

- ✓ He fundamentally transformed Kashmir's economy by importing skilled **Central Asian artisans** to introduce paper-making, bookbinding, papier-mâché, and the world-famous Kashmiri shawl-weaving industry.
- ✓ A prolific builder and engineer, he constructed a massive network of irrigation canals and built **Zaina-Lanka**, a spectacular artificial island palace situated in the middle of Wular Lake.
- ✓ He actively participated in Hindu festivals, strictly forbade the forgery of currency, and personally composed poetry under the Persian pseudonym **Qutb**.

Q 110. Ans. C

Explanation:

- Balaji Vishwanath (1713–1720) first consolidated Chhatrapati Shahu's authority and secured the 1719 Mughal farmans. His son Baji Rao I (1720–1740) shifted the geopolitical focus to northern expansion across the Narmada River. Balaji Baji Rao (1740–1761) then transitioned the Peshwaship into the supreme executive authority of the Maratha Confederacy, culminating in the 1761 Panipat disaster. Finally, Madhav Rao I (1761–1772) spearheaded the Maratha Resurrection (Punrutthan), restoring imperial finances and northern hegemony.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Balaji Vishwanath fundamentally altered the Maratha military structure by systematising the **Saranjami** system, delegating revenue collection rights in conquered territories to prominent commanders to finance their localised cavalry units.
 - ✓ Baji Rao I formalised the territorial partition of the Maratha state by signing the **Treaty of Warna in 1731**, legally recognising **Sambhaji II** of Kolhapur as a sovereign ruler over southern territories while securing Satara's supremacy in the north.
 - ✓ Under Balaji Baji Rao, the Maratha state underwent massive administrative centralisation, moving the de facto imperial capital from Satara to Pune and establishing the **Huzur Daftar**, a massive secretariat managing all imperial revenue and troop deployments.
 - ✓ Madhav Rao I decisively defeated the **Nizam of**

Hyderabad at the Battle of Rakshasbhuvan in 1763, securing crucial territorial concessions and preventing the disintegration of the Maratha state immediately following the Panipat disaster.

- ✓ The premature death of Madhav Rao I in 1772 due to tuberculosis directly triggered the **First Anglo-Maratha War**, as his ambitious uncle **Raghunathrao** sought British military assistance via the **Treaty of Surat (1775)** to usurp the Peshwaship.

Q 111. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Malhar Rao Holkar**, a prominent cavalry commander serving Peshwa Baji Rao I, was formally assigned the collection of Maratha revenues in the Malwa region in 1732. He successfully established his military and administrative headquarters at Indore. This territorial grant laid the foundation for the Holkar dynasty, which effectively controlled western Malwa as a semi-autonomous state within the expanding Maratha Confederacy.
- The Gaekwad dynasty, founded by Pilaji Gaekwad, was specifically deputed to extract Chauth from the Mughal province of Gujarat. They subsequently established their sovereign capital at Baroda (Vadodara), completely distinct from the central Indian Malwa plateau, where Indore is situated.
- Scindias (Shindes) were granted extensive northern territories by Peshwa Baji Rao I alongside the Holkars. Their founder, Ranoji Scindia, initially established his administrative base at Ujjain. The dynastic capital was only permanently shifted to the formidable fortress of Gwalior much later under the leadership of Mahadji Scindia.
- The Bhonsle dynasty, specifically under the leadership of Raghaji I Bhonsle, consolidated its political base at Nagpur in the Berar region. Their strategic focus was entirely oriented towards eastern India, spearheading the devastating Maratha cavalry invasions (Bargi incursions) into the Bengal Subah and Odisha, far removed from the Malwa region of Indore.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Under the reign of Ahilyabai Holkar (1767–1795), the dynastic administrative capital was temporarily shifted south to Maheshwar on the banks of the Narmada River.
 - ✓ Ahilyabai utilised the state treasury to fund a pan-India architectural revival, systematically

rebuilding major Hindu pilgrimage sites, including the Kashi Vishwanath temple in Varanasi and the Somnath temple in Gujarat.

- ✓ Yashwantrao Holkar inflicted a severe tactical defeat upon British East India Company forces commanded by Colonel William Monson at the Mukundwara Pass in 1804 during the Second Anglo-Maratha War.
- ✓ The Holkar polity was legally reduced to a subordinate British protectorate following the signing of the Treaty of Mandsaur in 1818, which concluded the Third Anglo-Maratha War.
- ✓ The dynasty strictly originated from the Dhanger (shepherd) pastoral community, demonstrating the significant caste and social mobility facilitated by the decentralised Maratha military recruitment system.

Q 112. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Option A is correct:** Maharana Raj Singh, the fiercely independent ruler of Mewar, vehemently opposed Aurangzeb's discriminatory taxation policies by authoring a protest letter directly to the emperor, which contrasted Aurangzeb's religious bigotry with the highly successful, inclusive, and tolerant administrative frameworks previously established by Akbar and Jahangir.
- **Option B is incorrect:** Maharaja Jaswant Singh of Marwar, despite his historically volatile relationship with Aurangzeb, served as a prominent Mughal general until his sudden death at the remote Afghan frontier outpost of Jamrud in December 1678, an event that occurred shortly before the official imperial re-imposition of the Jizya in 1679.
- **Option C is incorrect:** Mirza Raja Jai Singh of Amber served Aurangzeb with absolute loyalty and successfully commanded the **Deccan military campaign** that forced **Shivaji** to sign the **Treaty of Purandar** in 1665.
- **Option D is incorrect:** Durgadas Rathore was a brilliant military commander who fiercely defended the sovereign rights of the infant prince **Ajit Singh** by waging a relentless, decades-long guerrilla war against the Mughal occupation of **Marwar**, operating as a battlefield insurgent.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Aurangzeb officially re-imposed the Jizya (a discriminatory poll tax levied on non-Muslim subjects) in **April 1679** during his twenty-second regnal year, explicitly justifying the controversial

administrative measure on orthodox religious grounds to strictly align the Mughal state with traditional Islamic jurisprudence.

- ✓ The imperial tax code systematically divided the Hindu population into three distinct economic brackets, requiring them to pay 48, 24, or 12 silver dirhams annually, depending entirely on their total wealth, while legally granting exemptions to women, children, the physically disabled, the blind, the utterly destitute, and any Hindu actively serving as a government official.
- ✓ When tens of thousands of poor artisans, local merchants, and shopkeepers gathered outside the Red Fort in Delhi to stage a desperate, peaceful protest against the financial burden of the newly enforced tax, Aurangzeb ordered his imperial elephants to march directly through the dense crowd, trampling unarmed civilian protesters to death to clear his path to the Jama Masjid.
- ✓ The disastrous re-imposition of the Jizya, occurring simultaneously with the aggressive Mughal military occupation of Marwar following Jaswant Singh's death, permanently alienated the powerful Rajput nobility, shattering the century-long political and military alliance that had formed the bedrock of Mughal imperial expansion since the 1560s.

Yavana-rajya-sthapana-acharya (Restorer of the Yavana Kingdom) after intervening in Bahmani politics to briefly restore the puppet **Bahmani Sultan Mahmud Shah** to his throne in Bidar.

- ✓ Despite his continuous military campaigns, his reign marked a golden age of literature. He personally composed the masterful Telugu political and religious treatise **Amuktamalyada**.
- ✓ His royal court, known as the **Bhuvana Vijayam**, was adorned by eight eminent Telugu poets and scholars collectively celebrated as the **Ashtadiggajas** (the eight elephants).

Ashtadiggajas:

- ✓ **Allasani Peddana:** Revered as Andhra Kavita Pitamaha (The Grandfather of Telugu Poetry). His magnum opus, *Manucharitramu*, is considered a foundational text in Telugu literature.
- ✓ **Nandi Thimmana:** Also affectionately known as Mukku Timmana. He authored *Parijatapaharanamu*, a highly celebrated work dedicated to Krishnadevaraya.
- ✓ **Madayyagari Mallana:** Known for composing the *Rajasekhara Charitramu*, a romantic poetry work detailing the military and amorous exploits of a prince.
- ✓ **Dhurjati:** A devout Shaivite poet from Srikalahasti. He is famous for writing the *Kalahasti Mahatyamu*, praising the glory of the Shiva temple there.
- ✓ **Ayyalaraju Ramabhadru:** He translated and synthesised major epics, composing the *Ramabhyudayamu* and the *Sakalakatha Sara Sangrahamu*.
- ✓ **Pingali Surana:** Renowned for his complex dual-meaning poetry (*Dvyarthi Kavya*). He wrote the *Raghavapandaveeyamu* (which tells the stories of both the Ramayana and Mahabharata simultaneously) and *Kalapurnodayamu*.
- ✓ **Ramarajabhushanudu:** Also known as Bhattumurthi. He was a master of musical poetry and authored the highly ornate *Vasu Charitramu*.
- ✓ **Tenali Ramakrishna:** Globally famous for his sharp wit and folk tales. While often remembered as a jester, he was a formidable scholar who wrote the *Panduranga Mahatyamu*, considered one of the five great Telugu epics (*Pancha Kavyas*).

Q 113. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Krishnadevaraya launched a series of brilliant eastern campaigns (1513–1518) against the Gajapati kingdom of Odisha. After systematically capturing impregnable fortresses like Udayagiri and Kondavidu, he forced King Prataparudra Deva to sue for peace, offer his daughter in marriage, and formally cede all territories south of the Krishna River to the Vijayanagara Empire.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** On his western frontier, Krishnadevaraya inflicted a crushing defeat upon Ismail Adil Shah of Bijapur at the decisive Battle of Raichur (1520). This victory allowed Vijayanagara to annex and fully secure the incredibly wealthy and strategically vital Raichur Doab (the fertile land between the Krishna and Tungabhadra rivers).
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Following his victories, Krishnadevaraya famously assumed the unique title

Q 114. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** As part of his extensive infrastructural development program, Sher Shah

commissioned the construction of approximately seventeen hundred sarais (rest houses) strategically positioned at regular intervals along the major imperial highways to facilitate secure travel.

- **Statement 2 is correct:** To accommodate the diverse socio-religious practices of the travelling populace, the administration established separate residential quarters and kitchens for Hindus and Muslims within these facilities, notably employing state-funded Brahmins to prepare food specifically for Hindu merchants and travellers.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Rather than restricting access, the Sur administration actively encouraged international overland commerce by allowing foreign merchants to utilise these secure havens, where state officials provided explicit administrative protection for their valuable trading goods.
- **Statement 4 is correct:** Beyond their civilian utility, the sarais functioned as the fundamental infrastructural backbone of the royal postal service (Dak Chauki), permanently housing fresh relay horses and dedicated postal runners to ensure the rapid, uninterrupted transmission of military and administrative intelligence directly to the emperor.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ To ensure the financial sustainability of this vast network without perpetually burdening the central treasury, the state officially assigned the revenue generated from specific adjacent agricultural lands for the maintenance of each sarai.
 - ✓ The daily administrative operations, security, and logistical supply of each individual inn were supervised by a designated resident state official known as a **Shahna**.
 - ✓ By functioning as secure nodal points, the sarais organically stimulated localised economic activity, prompting nearby villagers to establish regular markets that frequently evolved into permanent commercial towns or qasbas.
 - ✓ The imperial administration provided overnight shelter and essential provisions at these facilities entirely free of cost to travellers.
 - ✓ To guarantee the physical safety of the highways, Sher Shah strictly enforced the administrative principle of local responsibility, holding adjacent village headmen (muqaddams) legally and financially accountable for any robberies or violent crimes committed within the immediate vicinity of a sarai.

Q 115. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** According to Ziauddin Barani's *Tarikh-i-Firoz Shahi*, Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq abandoned Alauddin Khilji's harsh **hukm-i-masahat** (revenue assessment based on land measurement) and reverted to **hukm-i-hasil** or **Batai** (actual crop-sharing). This system was far more sympathetic to the peasantry, as it meant the state automatically shared the burden of losses during droughts or crop failures.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Ghiyasuddin strictly opposed sudden and drastic tax hikes. Barani records that the Sultan instituted a policy of moderation (**rasm-i-miyan**), explicitly instructing his governors and revenue officials that the **Kharaj** (land tax) of any province or Iqta must never be increased by more than **one-tenth** (1/10) or **one-eleventh** (1/11) in any single year to prevent agrarian ruin and rebellion.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq holds the distinction of being the **first Sultan** of the Delhi Sultanate to officially initiate the digging of a network of **canals** to provide artificial irrigation for agriculture.
 - ✓ He restored the traditional privileges and perquisites to the rural Hindu intermediaries, the **khuts**, **muqaddams**, and **chaudhuris** (village headmen). He exempted their personal landholdings from the **ghari** (house tax) and **chari** (grazing tax), reversing the brutal centralisation policies of Alauddin Khilji.
 - ✓ His overarching economic philosophy was that the royal treasury should be enriched not by ruthlessly squeezing the existing peasantry with higher rates, but by actively encouraging the expansion of the total area under cultivation.

Q 116. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Option A is correct:** The Muhtasib served as the imperial censor of public morals, explicitly appointed by Aurangzeb in 1659 across all major provincial cities and market towns to actively patrol the streets, strictly enforce the state prohibition of alcohol and intoxicating drugs like bhang, and physically prevent illicit activities such as public gambling, prostitution, and the use of shortened weights and measures by merchants.

- **Option B is incorrect:** The **Qazi-ul-Quzat** was the **Chief Justice** of the empire who presided over the supreme imperial court in the capital to adjudicate complex civil and criminal litigation based on Islamic jurisprudence (Sharia).
- **Option C is incorrect:** The **Mir-i-Arz** functioned as the high-ranking administrative officer in charge of civilian petitions, responsible for safely receiving and officially presenting all public requests, grievances, and military dispatches directly to the emperor during regular court sessions, holding no religious, judicial, or moral policing authority.
- **Option D is incorrect:** The **Sadr-us-Sudur** was the supreme minister of ecclesiastical affairs who solely managed the vast distribution of tax-free charitable land grants (**Madad-i-Ma'ash**) to religious scholars and formally oversaw the administrative appointments of local judges (Qazis) across the empire, operating entirely at the high-administrative level rather than enforcing street-level morality.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ In his eleventh regnal year (1668), Aurangzeb abruptly discontinued the long-standing imperial practice of **Jharokha Darshan** (public appearance at the palace balcony), formally arguing that it un-Islamically elevated the emperor to the status of a semi-divine figure and actively fostered human worship (darshan) among the Hindu masses.
 - ✓ To further align the imperial court with orthodox Sunni traditions, Aurangzeb completely banned the celebration of the **Persian New Year festival, Nauroz**, and formally dismissed all state-sponsored musicians and singers from the imperial payroll, though he surprisingly allowed the **Naubat** (royal band) to remain and heavily patronised the compilation of the famous Persian musical treatise **Faqirullah**, as he himself remained an expert **Veena player**.
 - ✓ Dramatically reversing the tolerant architectural policies of his predecessors, Aurangzeb issued direct imperial decrees in 1669 explicitly ordering the destruction of newly constructed Hindu temples and specific prominent historical shrines, directly resulting in the systematic demolition of the **Kashi Vishwanath temple in Varanasi** and the **Keshavdev temple in Mathura**.
 - ✓ In a move that permanently fractured the foundational socio-political unity of the

Mughal state, Aurangzeb officially re-imposed the **Jizya** (a discriminatory religious poll tax levied exclusively on non-Muslim subjects) in **1679** after a gap of over a century, a massive administrative action that sparked widespread, violent public protests in the streets of Delhi and alienated the crucial Rajput nobility.

- ✓ To codify and standardise Islamic law across the sprawling empire, Aurangzeb commissioned a board of leading Islamic theologians to compile the **Fatawa-i-Alamgiri**, an exhaustive, multi-volume legal digest of Islamic jurisprudence that served as the definitive reference manual for all Qazis in the Mughal judicial system.

Q 117. Ans. B

Explanation:

- The Gaekwad dynasty, established by Pilaji Gaekwad, was specifically deputed to systematically collect revenue from the wealthy Mughal province of Gujarat.
- Damaji Gaekwad consolidated power in Gujarat following the decline of the Senapati Dabhade lineage.
- They subsequently consolidated absolute political and military control over the region, establishing their permanent sovereign capital at Baroda (Vadodara) to dominate western inland trade.

Q 118. Ans. D

Explanation:

- Rajatarangini translates to the River of Kings. It documents the continuous history of Kashmir. Kalhana composed this text in the twelfth century.
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ Kalhana wrote this monumental text in the Sanskrit language.
 - ✓ He utilised older historical texts to compile his work.
 - ✓ He utilised ancient inscriptions to verify historical facts.
 - ✓ He utilised early coins to establish chronological accuracy.
 - ✓ The text contains exactly eight distinct chapters called Tarangas.
 - ✓ It is considered India's first truly objective historical text.

Q 119. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Chand Bardai served as the court poet for Prithviraj

III. Prithviraj III belonged to the powerful Chauhan clan. The poem details his fierce battles against Muhammad Ghori.

● Additional facts:

- ✓ The poem was originally composed in the Brajbhasha dialect.
- ✓ It contains a heavily romanticised account of Prithviraj's life.
- ✓ It vividly describes the controversial abduction of Princess Sanyogita.
- ✓ Princess Sanyogita was the daughter of Jaichand of the Gahadavala dynasty (Kannauj).
- ✓ Many modern historians question the strict historical accuracy of this text.
- ✓ The poem claims Prithviraj killed Ghori using archery while blinded.
- ✓ It remains a foundational text for North Indian martial folklore.

Q 120. Ans. B

Explanation:

- During the reign of Shah Jahan (1628–1658), imperial Mughal architecture underwent a definitive structural and aesthetic shift toward the extensive use of pristine white marble (sang-i-marmar). This material transition marked the zenith of Mughal architectural refinement, relying heavily on premium, highly translucent white marble sourced specifically from the Makrana quarries in the Nagaur district of Rajasthan for monumental commissions like the Taj Mahal.
- Red sandstone (sang-i-surkh) was the dominant structural material of the earlier Mughal era, most prominently utilised by Emperor Akbar during the massive late 16th-century construction of the imperial capital at Fatehpur Sikri and the foundational walls of the Agra Fort.
- Granite, due to its extreme hardness and resistance to detailed carving, was not utilised as a primary structural or decorative material in mainstream Mughal imperial architecture, which required softer stones for intricate geometric and floral relief work.
- While stucco (lime plaster) was frequently employed for internal vaulted ceilings and decorative relief work throughout the Mughal and regional Sultanate periods, it did not replace red sandstone as the primary, load-bearing exterior building material of Shah Jahan's imperial monuments.
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ To achieve his vision of imperial perfection, Shah Jahan systematically ordered the

demolition of several earlier red sandstone structures built by Akbar and Jahangir within the Agra Fort and Lahore Fort, replacing them entirely with refined white marble pavilions.

- ✓ The widespread adoption of white marble was structurally paired with the introduction of Pietra Dura (indigenously known as parchin kari), a highly specialised technique involving the intricate inlay of semi-precious stones, such as lapis lazuli, jade, carnelian, and agate, directly into the carved marble surface.
- ✓ This material shift also accompanied a distinct evolution in architectural forms, most notably the widespread imperial adoption of the multi-foliated (cusped) arch, gracefully tapering pillars, and the prominent bulbous double-dome.
- ✓ Prominent examples of this pure marble phase include the Moti Masjid (Pearl Mosque) within the Agra Fort and the exquisite Diwan-i-Khas (Hall of Private Audiences) at the Red Fort in Shahjahanabad (Delhi), which famously housed the jewel-encrusted Peacock Throne.
- ✓ Contemporary court chronicles, such as the Padshahnama by Abdul Hamid Lahori, explicitly confirm that this obsession with white marble and precise symmetry was ideologically designed to replicate the Quranic descriptions of Paradise (Jannah) on Earth.

Q 121. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Bilhana served the Western Chalukya dynasty. He wrote this text to glorify his patron king. His patron was King Vikramaditya VI. The Chalukyas ruled from the capital city of Kalyani.
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ Bilhana composed this grand eulogy in the Sanskrit language.
 - ✓ Bilhana originally hailed from the distant region of Kashmir.
 - ✓ The text vividly describes the king's numerous military campaigns.
 - ✓ It details the intense succession struggle between Vikramaditya and his brother.
 - ✓ It offers valuable insights into the contemporary political geography of South India.

Q 122. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Statement B is incorrect: While authored by Emperor Krishnadevaraya, Amuktamalyada was composed

in classical **Telugu**, not Sanskrit. It is considered the supreme masterpiece of the **Prabandha style of Telugu literature**. Krishnadevaraya did, however, write other major works in **Sanskrit**, most notably the dramas **Jambavati Kalyanam** and **Usha Parinayam**.

● **Additional facts:**

- ✓ Amuktamalyada was written following the emperor's successful Kalinga campaign. Legend states that Lord Andhra Vishnu (the presiding deity of Srikakulam) appeared in Krishnadevaraya's dream and explicitly commanded him to compose the work in Telugu, famously declaring: "**Desa bhashalandu Telugu Lessa**" (Among the languages of the nation, Telugu is the best).
- ✓ The core story revolves around the female Alvar saint Andal (Goda Devi), the adopted daughter of **Vishnucitta** (Periyalvar). The title "Amuktamalyada" means "One who wears and gives away garlands." It describes Andal's intense devotion: she would secretly wear flower garlands to ensure they were beautiful enough before offering them to **Lord Ranganatha (Vishnu) at Srirangam**.
- ✓ Moving beyond religion, the text acts as a sophisticated political manual (similar to Kautilya's Arthashastra). Krishnadevaraya lays down highly pragmatic, almost **Machiavellian** rules for governance:
 - A king must proactively develop ports, protect foreign merchants, and heavily incentivise the import of warhorses and elephants from the Portuguese and Arabs to maintain military supremacy over the Bahmani Sultanates.
 - He advised that forest tribes (**Chenchus**, etc.) should not be destroyed but aggressively recruited and utilised as **spies** and **guerrilla** fighters against rival kingdoms.
 - He stated that a king should collect taxes gently, "like a gardener plucking flowers, not uprooting the plant," and that the state's wealth must be spent equally on the army, charity, and public works (like irrigation).
- ✓ Because of this work and his unparalleled patronage of the **Ashtadiggajas**, Krishnadevaraya earned the imperial titles **Andhra Bhoja**, **Abhinava Bhoja**, and **Sakalakala Bhoja**. His reign is universally recognised as the **Golden Age of Telugu Literature**.

Q 123. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correctly matched:** Hakim Khan Sur was a prominent Afghan noble harbouring intense anti-Mughal sentiments who brought a crucial **artillery** contingent to support **Maharana Pratap** and fought valiantly in the vanguard of the **Mewar** army during the initial Rajput charge.
- **Pair 2 is correctly matched:** Raja Man Singh of Amber, possessing extensive battlefield experience and royal trust, acted as the supreme commander of the imperial Mughal forces, a role that showcased the success of Akbar's Rajput integration policy but simultaneously triggered deep resentment among orthodox Muslim commanders like **Badauni**, who were ideologically uncomfortable serving under a Hindu general.
- **Pair 3 is incorrectly matched:** Asaf Khan was actually a prominent **Mughal** general fighting alongside Man Singh against the Rajputs, whereas the indigenous **Bhil archers**, who launched devastating arrow attacks from the surrounding hills to support the Mewar forces, were actually commanded by the loyal tribal leader **Rana Poonja**.
- **Pair 4 is correctly matched:** When Maharana Pratap was severely wounded during the fierce, close-quarters combat and found himself entirely surrounded by advancing Mughal forces, his loyal chieftain **Jhala Bida** heroically snatched the royal umbrella to impersonate the king, a deliberate deception that successfully facilitated the Maharana's safe retreat from the battlefield at the cost of Bida's own life.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ The Battle of Haldighati, fought in the narrow, rugged mountain pass of the **Aravalli** range in **June 1576**, was essentially a geopolitical clash between the expanding imperialistic ambitions of Akbar and the fierce regional independence of Mewar, rather than a simplistic religious war between Hindus and Muslims.
 - ✓ Following the tactical stalemate at Haldighati, where the Mughals won the field but ultimately failed to capture Pratap or definitively crush his army's spirit, Maharana Pratap shifted his operational base into the deep forests of the Aravallis and initiated a prolonged, highly effective **guerrilla** warfare campaign.
 - ✓ This relentless guerrilla strategy deeply frustrated the Mughal supply lines and

garrisons, eventually allowing Maharana Pratap to successfully recover the vast majority of his lost territories, including **Kumbhalgarh** and the areas around **Chittor**, before his death in **1597**.

- ✓ Historian **Abdul Qadir Badauni**, who was personally present at the battle as part of the Mughal vanguard, provides a detailed, albeit highly biased, first-hand account of the intense combat in his work **Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh**, highlighting the sheer confusion, blinding dust, and immense bloodshed that characterised the engagement.

Q 124. Ans. D

Explanation:

- Sadruddin Hasan Nizami's **Taj-ul-Maasir** (The Crown of Exploits) functions as the first official dynastic history of the Delhi Sultanate, explicitly commissioned by Qutbuddin Aibak.
- Written in a highly ornate mixture of Arabic and Persian, the text meticulously details Aibak's military campaigns across northern India following the Second Battle of Tarain (1192 CE).
- It specifically documents his strategic conquests of regional Rajput strongholds such as Meerut, Kol (Aligarh), and Kalinjar, thereby recording the critical geopolitical transition from a Ghurid military occupation to an independent Mamluk state.

Q 125. Ans. C

Explanation:

Ralph Fitch reached Patna in **1585** during the reign of **Emperor Akbar** (1556–1605). He was part of a small group of English merchants who travelled overland via the Persian Gulf to India to explore commercial opportunities. His detailed accounts, later published by Richard Hakluyt, provided the English-speaking world with its first eyewitness description of the wealth and trade of the Mughal heartland, specifically highlighting Patna's importance in the cotton and opium trades.

Q 126. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Niccolao Manucci, a Venetian adventurer, arrived in India in 1656 and almost immediately entered the service of Dara Shikoh, the eldest son and heir-apparent of Emperor Shah Jahan. Manucci served as a gunner (artilleryman) in Dara's army during the brutal Mughal War of Succession. His work, *Storia do Mogor* (Story of the Moguls), provides a vivid, often biased, first-hand account of the Battle of

Samugarh and the subsequent tragic downfall of his patron. Manucci remained fiercely loyal to Dara's memory, often portraying his rival Aurangzeb in a highly negative light.

Q 127. Ans. D

Explanation:

Jean-Baptiste Tavernier was a highly successful French gem merchant and jeweller. Over the course of his six voyages to Asia between 1630 and 1668, his primary objective was to acquire, appraise, and trade precious stones, particularly diamonds. He visited Patna and the surrounding regions of Bihar during his travels through the Gangetic plains to access its massive commercial markets. While in Patna, he engaged with merchants from Tibet and Nepal to trade in highly lucrative luxury goods, particularly musk, which he procured alongside his core jewellery enterprise.

Q 128. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Akbar integrated Rajputs into the Mughal nobility. He granted them high military and administrative ranks. They served as key commanders in imperial campaigns.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** Matrimonial alliances did not require religious conversion. Rajput princesses maintained their Hindu faith. They built temples inside the imperial harem. They celebrated Hindu festivals openly.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** Subjugated rulers recognised Mughal suzerainty. They paid regular tribute to the emperor. Akbar allowed them to rule their ancestral lands. These hereditary lands were known as watan jagirs.
- **Statement 4 is correct:** Raja Bharmal belonged to the Kachwaha clan. He met Akbar at Sanganer in 1562. He offered his daughter in marriage to the emperor. This marked the beginning of a deliberate political strategy.
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ The matrimonial alliances secured the loyalty of fierce warriors.
 - ✓ These alliances provided a counterweight to ambitious **Turani** nobles.
 - ✓ Akbar abolished the pilgrimage tax on Hindus in **1563**.
 - ✓ He abolished the **jizya tax** in **1564**.
 - ✓ Some Rajput states, like **Mewar**, fiercely resisted Mughal expansion.
 - ✓ Akbar besieged and captured the strategic **Chittor fort** in **1568**.

Q 129. Ans. A

Explanation:

Peter Mundy, an English trader and traveller for the East India Company, visited Patna in 1632. His journals identify Saltpetre (referred to locally as shora) as the most significant driver of the city's trade. During the 17th century, European powers were frequently engaged in warfare (such as the Thirty Years' War), creating an insatiable demand for saltpetre as it was the primary ingredient in gunpowder. Mundy noted that Patna was the most important centre in the world for its refinement, providing the highest quality material at the lowest cost.

Q 130. Ans. B

Explanation:

- Muhammad bin Tughlaq's empire had expanded to the extreme south of India. **Devagiri** (renamed Daulatabad) was chosen because of its **central geographical location**. This allowed the Sultan to maintain a tighter administrative and military grip over the rebellious southern provinces compared to the distant northern frontier of Delhi.
- In his *Tarikh-i-Firoz Shahi*, Ziauddin Barani mentions that to populate this new capital, the Sultan ordered the total and ruthless evacuation of Delhi, claiming the city was left so desolate that "not a cat or a dog was left."
- Irfan Habib argues that only the administrative elite and Sufi saints were forced to move.
- Ibn Battuta's **Rihla** also corroborates the forced migration and its hardships, as he was a contemporary eyewitness, unlike Barani.
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ To facilitate the massive 1500-kilometre journey, the Sultan ordered the **construction of a broad road from Delhi to Daulatabad**, planting shade trees on both sides and establishing halting stations (sarais) with free food and water at regular intervals.
 - ✓ Realising that Daulatabad could not be defended against northern Mongol incursions and that controlling the northern frontiers from the Deccan was equally impossible, the Sultan ultimately reversed his decision and permitted the citizens to return to Delhi.
 - ✓ The forced migration of the northern Muslim elite, scholars, and Sufi saints to Daulatabad had a profound long-term cultural impact. It planted the seeds for the spread of Islamic

culture, the development of the **Dakhni language**, and the eventual rise of the **Bahmani Sultanate** in the Deccan.

Q 131. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Option A is the correct:** During the intense climax of the battle, Dara Shikoh's prominent war elephant became a prime target for Aurangzeb's concentrated artillery fire, prompting the prince to quickly dismount and mount a horse to personally lead a cavalry charge; however, when his frontline troops saw the empty royal howdah, they instantly assumed their supreme commander was dead, triggering a massive, irreversible panic that caused the entire imperial army to abruptly break formation and flee the battlefield in complete chaos.
- **Option B is incorrect:** Maharaja Jaswant Singh of Marwar, who initially commanded the imperial forces, was heavily defeated earlier by Aurangzeb at the **Battle of Dharmat** and was not even present at the Battle of Samugarh, having retreated back to his desert kingdom in Rajasthan.
- **Option C is incorrect:** Emperor Shah Jahan was helplessly confined inside the **Agra Fort** due to his severe illness and growing political isolation, possessing no command authority over the battlefield operations or the imperial artillery during this war.
- **Option D is incorrect:** The Battle of Samugarh was a purely land-based engagement fought entirely on a dusty inland plain located east of Agra, meaning there was no naval combat involved; **Prince Murad Bakhsh** instead fought fiercely alongside Aurangzeb using traditional, heavy cavalry charges.
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ The devastating Mughal War of Succession formally erupted when Emperor Shah Jahan fell gravely ill with strangury in September 1657, prompting a brutal, multi-front military struggle for the Peacock Throne among his four adult, geographically dispersed sons: **Dara Shikoh, Shuja, Aurangzeb, and Murad Bakhsh**.
 - ✓ Prior to the decisive war at Samugarh, the combined rebel armies of Aurangzeb and Murad Bakhsh secured a massive strategic victory by completely routing the imperial forces commanded by **Jaswant Singh** and **Qasim Khan** at the **Battle of Dharmat** in April 1658.
 - ✓ The bitter conflict was concluded at the **Battle of Deorai** in April 1659, which served as the final military engagement of the succession war and

resulted in Dara Shikoh's permanent defeat.

- ✓ Following his defeat at Deorai, Dara Shikoh sought refuge in the northwestern frontier but was betrayed to the pursuing Mughal forces by an Afghan chieftain named **Malik Jiwan**, a man whose life Dara had previously saved from Shah Jahan.
- ✓ To publicly humiliate his defeated elder brother and destroy any remaining political sympathy among the populace, Aurangzeb ordered the captured Dara Shikoh to be paraded through the crowded streets of Delhi in rags atop a small, dirt-covered elephant before his brutal execution on charges of religious heresy in August 1659.

Q 132. Ans. A

Explanation:

Malik Muhammad Jayasi completed his magnum opus, the *Padmavat*, in 1540 CE, which coincided with the accession of Sher Shah Suri to the throne of Delhi. In the introductory section of the poem, known as the *Madah* (panegyric), Jayasi explicitly praises Sher Shah as the "Sultan of the World," acknowledging his contemporary political authority. The work is considered the finest specimen of the Sufi Premakhyan (heroic-romantic) tradition, utilising the local Awadhi dialect and Persian script to narrate the legendary siege of Chittor.

Q 133. Ans. C

Explanation:

Dara Shikoh, the eldest son of Shah Jahan, completed the Persian translation of fifty-two Upanishads in 1657 CE under the title *Sirr-i-Akbar* (The Great Secret). Assisted by Sanskrit scholars from Varanasi, he undertook this project believing that the Upanishads contained the "hidden book" (*Kitab al-maknun*) mentioned in the Quran. This work played a critical role in global history, as it was later translated into Latin by Anquetil-Duperron, introducing Indian philosophy to European scholars like Schopenhauer.

Q 134. Ans. B

Explanation:

In 1704, Prince Azim-ush-shan, who was serving as the Subahdar (Governor) of Bihar, obtained permission from his grandfather, Emperor Aurangzeb, to rename Patna to Azimabad. He aimed to transform the city into a magnificent capital rivalling Delhi and reportedly spent nearly 1 crore

rupees on its reconstruction and beautification, including the development of the fortification walls and administrative buildings.

Q 135. Ans. D

Explanation:

Vidyapati, widely celebrated by the title Maithil Kokil (the Cuckoo of Mithila), wrote the *Padavali* in Maithili. This collection of lyrics, focusing on the divine love of Radha and Krishna, played a foundational role in transitioning Indian devotional literature from Sanskrit to vernacular languages. His influence was so profound that his style led to the creation of the Brajabuli literary dialect, which dominated Vaishnava poetry in Bengal, Assam, and Odisha for centuries.

Q 136. Ans. C

Explanation:

The **Chhoti Dargah** at Maner Sharif, completed in 1616, is constructed entirely of high-quality **sandstone** (specifically Chunar sandstone). It is widely regarded as the most magnificent example of Mughal architecture in Eastern India. The use of sandstone provided a durable canvas for the exceptionally fine, lace-like carvings and intricate jali (lattice) work that adorn the mausoleum, distinguishing it from the simpler brick-and-plaster structures common in the region at the time.

Q 137. Ans. A

Explanation:

Mythology has historically been the central theme of Mithila painting, also known as Madhubani art. These works traditionally depict religious narratives from ancient epics, focusing on the lives of deities such as Krishna, Ram, Shiva, and Durga. The art form originated as a ritualistic practice where women decorated the walls of their homes during festivals and life-cycle events, specifically creating the Kohbar (nuptial chamber) paintings to invoke divine blessings for fertility and marital harmony through sacred symbols and mythological scenes.

Q 138. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Statement B is incorrect:** According to Ziauddin Barani's *Tarikh-i-Firoz Shahi*, the fundamental reason for the failure of the token currency was the exact opposite of a monopoly: the state completely

failed to secure the minting process. Because the design of the new bronze and copper coins was relatively simple and lacked complex royal seals, ordinary citizens turned their own homes into mints (**Dar-ul-Zarb**). A massive flood of counterfeit coins entered the market, causing rapid hyperinflation and economic chaos, not a shortage.

- **Statements A, C, and D are correct:** The Sultan introduced the token currency to counter a severe global shortage of silver and to fund his massive standing army. However, as foreign merchants refused to accept the base metals, trade came to a halt. Citizens hoarded precious metals and paid their state dues in forged copper. Barani famously records that when the Sultan finally admitted the failure and offered to exchange the token coins for real gold and silver, veritable “mountains” of rejected copper coins piled up outside the fort of Tughlaqabad.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ Muhammad bin Tughlaq’s economic experiment was heavily inspired by contemporary global events, specifically the successful introduction of paper currency (**Chao**) by the **Mongol emperor Kublai Khan** in China, and the less successful paper money (**Jao**) issued by the **Ilkhanid ruler of Persia, Gaykhatu**.
 - ✓ Prior to this disastrous experiment, the Sultan had actually implemented highly successful coinage reforms. The eminent British numismatist Edward Thomas even titled Muhammad bin Tughlaq the “**Prince of Moneyers**” for standardising the coinage and introducing a high-quality gold coin called the **Dinar** (weighing 200 grains) and a silver coin called the **Adali**.
 - ✓ The token currency was primarily meant to finance the Sultan’s extraordinarily ambitious, and ultimately aborted, military projects, such as the proposed conquest of **Khurasan** and **Iraq**, for which he had raised and paid an army of 3,70,000 soldiers for an entire year.

Q 139. Ans. A

Explanation:

- **Option A is correct:** The Sadak-i-Azam (Great Road) originated in **Sonargaon**, a major commercial and administrative centre in the province of Bengal, and stretched thousands of miles westward across the northern plains, ultimately terminating near the banks of the Indus River in the northwest.

- **Option B is incorrect:** The Sur Empire never incorporated Assam into its territorial holdings; the powerful Ahom kingdom successfully defended this eastern frontier, meaning the imperial highway network did not extend into this specific region.
- **Option C is incorrect:** The primary royal highway bypassed Orissa entirely, strategically following the highly fertile, populated, and economically vital Gangetic plain instead of the eastern coastal routes.
- **Option D is incorrect:** Arakan functioned as an independent kingdom situated in present-day Myanmar (Burma) and remained completely outside the political, military, and infrastructural orbit of the Afghan state.
- **Additional facts:**
 - ✓ This historic transcontinental route is widely recognised in contemporary geography as the **Grand Trunk Road**.
 - ✓ To facilitate travel and commerce, Sher Shah directed the systematic planting of shade-providing, fruit-bearing trees along both sides of the extensive highway.
 - ✓ The imperial administration constructed dedicated drinking wells and specialised rest houses (**serais**) at regular intervals to actively support merchants, royal postmen, and civilian travellers.
 - ✓ This extensive infrastructural network significantly accelerated the rapid mobilisation and deployment of the imperial army across the vast northern provinces.
 - ✓ By providing a secure and highly reliable transportation corridor, the highway systematically stimulated internal overland trade and economic integration within the empire.
 - ✓ In addition to this primary northern artery, Sher Shah also commissioned the construction of another major regional road connecting the imperial capital at **Agra** southward to **Burhanpur**.

Q 140. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Minhaj-i-Siraj Juzjani dedicated his monumental universal history, the *Tabaqat-i-Nasiri*, to Sultan Nasiruddin Mahmud (reigned 1246–1266 CE). Nasiruddin was the grandson of Iltutmish and a ruler known for his pious, reclusive nature. Minhaj served as the Chief Qazi (judge) of Delhi and the head of the Nasiriya Madrasa under this sovereign. The text provides the most authoritative contemporary account of the Sultanate’s early administrative

challenges, the rise of the “Group of Forty,” and the internal factionalism between the Turkish nobility and the crown during Nasiruddin’s tenure.

- Additional facts:

- ✓ While Iltutmish is a central figure in the *Tabaqat-i-Nasiri*, he is not the dedicatee. Minhaj provides extensive detail on Iltutmish’s reign (1211–1236 CE), specifically his formal recognition by the Abbasid Caliph in 1229 and his consolidation of the Iqta system.
- ✓ Ghiyasuddin Balban served as the Naib (Regent) and held the title Ulugh Khan during Nasiruddin Mahmud’s reign. While the *Tabaqat-i-Nasiri* highly praises Balban’s military campaigns against the Mongols and the Mewatis, the formal dedication remains to the titular Sultan, Nasiruddin. Balban’s own subsequent reign (1266–1287 CE) and his “blood and iron” policy are instead the primary focus of later historians like Ziauddin Barani.
- ✓ Alauddin Khalji reigned from 1296 to 1316 CE, more than thirty years after Minhaj-i-Siraj had completed his work and passed away. The Khalji Revolution and Alauddin’s radical market reforms and agrarian policies are documented in the *Tarikh-i-Firuz Shahi* by Ziauddin Barani and the poetic works of Amir Khusrau, such as the *Khaza’in-ul-Futuh*.

Q 141. Ans. A

Explanation:

- Aurangzeb formally halted the compilation of the official court history, the *Alamgirnama*, after the tenth year of his reign (1668 CE). He viewed the practice as a wasteful expense and a form of vanity inconsistent with his orthodox religious beliefs. Consequently, Muhammad Hashim, known by the title Khafi Khan, was forced to collect data and write his monumental work, *Muntakhab-ul-Lubab*, in private. The title “Khafi” (meaning concealed or secret) is often interpreted as a reference to the clandestine nature of his historical documentation during a period when imperial patronage for chronicles had ceased.

Q 142. Ans. C

Explanation:

Francois Bernier was a French doctor and a graduate of the Faculty of Montpellier who served first as the personal physician to Prince Dara Shikoh, and after Dara’s defeat, became attached to the household of the Mughal nobleman **Daneshmand Khan** at

Aurangzeb’s court, remaining in India for twelve years (1656–1668). His seminal work, *Travels in the Mughal Empire*, provides a sophisticated medical and sociopolitical critique of the Mughal state. He famously compared the Mughal lack of private land ownership to European property rights, a theory that later influenced Enlightenment thinkers.

Q 143. Ans. A

Explanation:

The *Futuh-us-Salat* (Gifts of the Sultans) was composed by Abdul Malik Isami and dedicated to Ala-ud-Din Bahman Shah, the founder of the Bahmani Sultanate in the Deccan (1347 CE). Isami migrated from Delhi to Daulatabad during the forced capital transfer under Muhammad bin Tughlaq. Disillusioned with the Tughlaq administration, he sought refuge in the newly independent Bahmani court. His work, often called the *Shah-nama-i-Hind*, is an epic history in Persian verse that justifies the Deccan’s independence from the Delhi Sultanate by framing the Bahmani rulers as the legitimate successors of Islamic authority in India.

Q 144. Ans. C

Explanation:

- The *Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi* was a separate department of agriculture created by Muhammad bin Tughlaq. Its primary objective was to increase state revenue by bringing barren, uncultivated land into cultivation through direct state intervention and financial support.
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ The state distributed massive agricultural loans known as *Sondhar* to peasants to help them buy seeds, cattle, and dig irrigation wells.
 - ✓ A key policy of this department was enforcing crop rotation and incentivising farmers to grow superior cash crops (such as wheat and sugarcane) instead of inferior crops (like barley).
 - ✓ According to Ziauddin Barani, the experiment ultimately failed and resulted in a massive treasury loss of over 70 lakh tankas. The project collapsed because the land chosen for cultivation was infertile, the appointed officials were corrupt and inexperienced, and the three-year project window was too short.

Q 145. Ans. B

Explanation:

Ibn Battuta, hailing from Tangier, Morocco, was a

native speaker of Arabic and a trained Islamic jurist. Upon his return to Morocco in 1354 CE, the Marinid Sultan Abu Inan Faris commissioned him to record his observations. Battuta dictated his experiences in Arabic to a professional **scholar and literary editor** named Ibn Juzayy, whom Ibn Battuta had previously met in Granada. The resulting work, formally titled *Tuhfat al-Anzar fi Ghara'ib al-Amsar wa 'Aja'ib al-Asfar* (A Gift to Those Who Contemplate the Wonders of Cities and the Marvels of Travelling), is globally recognised by its shorter title, the *Rihla*.

Q 146. Ans. A

Explanation:

Abdul Hamid Lahori was the official court historian commissioned by Emperor Shah Jahan to chronicle his reign. The *Padshahnama* (The Book of the Emperor) is a meticulously detailed Persian history focusing on the first twenty years of Shah Jahan's administration (1628–1648 CE). Lahori modelled his narrative after Abul Fazl's *Akbarnama*, providing exhaustive accounts of royal ceremonies, military campaigns in the Deccan and Central Asia, and the construction of imperial monuments, most notably the Taj Mahal and the Red Fort.

Q 147. Ans. B

Explanation:

- **Option A is incorrect:** The silver Tanka was an older currency unit originally introduced by Sultan Iltutmish during the Delhi Sultanate period, a monetary system that Sher Shah explicitly sought to reform and completely replace due to its severe debasement over time.
- **Option B is correct:** Sher Shah Suri introduced the Rupiya, a highly standardised silver coin weighing exactly 178 grains. This specific currency reform successfully eliminated older mixed-metal coins and established a durable numismatic standard that remained the foundation of the Indian monetary system for centuries.
- **Option C is incorrect:** The Jital was a traditional copper fractional coin that circulated widely during the earlier Sultanate era. In contrast, Sher Shah introduced the standardised copper Dam to serve as the primary currency for smaller, everyday commercial transactions.
- **Option D is incorrect:** The Mohur was a prominent gold coin predominantly utilised for high-value commercial transactions and state ceremonial purposes. While gold coins were minted during

the Sur period, The Mohur was itself introduced by Sher Shah Suri as the gold component of his tri-metallic currency system, weighing 169 grains. The Mughals subsequently continued and expanded its use.

Additional facts:

- ✓ Sher Shah systematically abolished the circulation of older, mixed-metal (billion) currency, issuing instead distinct, high-purity coins in gold, silver, and copper.
- ✓ To ensure the uniform production and broad geographic circulation of the new currency, Sher Shah established an extensive network of royal mints across the imperial provinces.
- ✓ Demonstrating a practical approach to administrative communication, the new coins prominently featured the emperor's name and title inscribed in both the Perso-Arabic and Devanagari scripts, facilitating easier commercial use among the diverse local populace.
- ✓ The structural integrity and exact weight of Sher Shah's silver Rupiya were so successful that the coin was subsequently adopted by the Mughal Empire and ultimately retained as the foundational currency model by the British East India Company.

Q 148. Ans. C

Explanation:

- **Option C is the correct:** The primary geopolitical objective behind Shah Jahan's massive military expedition into Balkh and Badakhshan was to permanently **secure** the highly vulnerable **northwestern frontier** around **Kabul** from the devastating, recurrent raids of the turbulent **Uzbeks** by actively installing a friendly, subservient ruler in **Balkh** to serve as a reliable strategic buffer for the Mughal Empire.
- **Option A is incorrect:** Although Shah Jahan, like his predecessors, heavily romanticised his ancestral **Timurid** origins and harboured deep emotional attachments to the Central Asian homeland, he possessed no practical administrative plans to permanently relocate the imperial capital to Samarkand, as India remained the undisputed, immensely wealthy centre of Mughal power.
- **Option B is incorrect:** The immense military undertaking was driven entirely by hard geopolitical realities rather than scientific or cultural ambitions; securing control over historical sites like **Ulugh**

Beg's observatories held absolutely no strategic military value and was never a formalised war aim.

- **Option D is incorrect:** Geographically, the rugged, landlocked mountainous terrains of Balkh and Badakhshan offer no maritime access to the Caspian Sea; furthermore, the specific military target of this campaign was the Uzbek confederacy in Central Asia, not the Safavid Empire of Iran (with whom the Mughals contested Kandahar).

- **Additional facts:**

- ✓ The initial Mughal expeditionary force, launched in **1646**, was commanded by Shah Jahan's youngest son, **Prince Murad Bakhsh**, who successfully captured Balkh but quickly despised the harsh, unforgiving mountainous terrain and the alien culture, notoriously abandoning his critical command post and returning to India without securing formal imperial permission.
- ✓ Following Murad's disastrous dereliction of duty, Shah Jahan first sent his Grand Vizier Saadullah Khan to stabilise the situation, and when this failed, dispatched Prince Aurangzeb with Rajput commanders **Jai Singh of Amber** and **Rao Madho Singh Hada of Kota** to restore order in 1647
- ✓ It was during the subsequent brutal combat against the massive **Uzbek cavalry forces** that Prince Aurangzeb famously demonstrated his legendary personal piety and immense physical courage by calmly dismounting his horse directly in the middle of the raging battlefield to perform his obligatory **Zuhr** (midday) prayers, an act that deeply awed the Uzbek commanders.
- ✓ Despite achieving significant tactical victories in the field, the Mughals were ultimately forced to completely **abandon** Balkh in **1647** due to the absolute impossibility of maintaining secure supply lines across the snow-blocked Hindu Kush mountains, the extreme hostility of the local Uzbek population, and the financial drain on the imperial treasury, which lost an estimated forty million rupees during the futile campaign.

- **Option B is correct:** The Suhrawardis maintained close, mutually beneficial relationships with the political state. Shaikh Bahauddin Zakariya openly supported **Iltutmish** during the political succession, and in return, the Sultan bestowed upon him the prestigious state title of **Shaikh-ul-Islam** (Leader of Islam).

- **Option C is incorrect:** The ideology of severe asceticism, voluntary poverty, and reliance strictly on **futuh** (unsolicited charity) was the hallmark of the Chishti silsila. The Suhrawardis completely rejected this view. They argued that living in poverty was not a prerequisite for spiritual elevation. Instead, they believed that as long as a saint's heart was entirely detached from materialism, there was no harm in accumulating wealth, eating well, and living comfortably.

- **Option D is correct:** The **Awarif-ul-Ma'arif**, written by the eponymous founder of the order (**Shihabuddin Suhrawardi**), served as the ultimate guidebook for Sufi initiates, outlining the rules for monastic life, meditation, and the master-disciple (pir-murid) relationship.

- **Additional facts:**

- ✓ Compared to the Chishtis, the Suhrawardis were generally more orthodox in their Islamic practices. They strictly adhered to the **Sharia** (Islamic law) and generally disapproved of **Sama** (ecstatic musical gatherings) as a method of spiritual realisation.
- ✓ Because they aligned closely with the state and orthodox theology, they did not mingle as freely with the Hindu masses or the lower classes as the Chishtis did, often interacting primarily with the Muslim aristocracy and political elites.
- ✓ Another highly influential figure of this order was **Shaikh Ruknuddin Abul Fath** (often known as **Rukn-i-Alam**), who wielded immense influence during the reign of the Tughlaq dynasty and was highly venerated by Sultan Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq.

Q 149. Ans. C

Explanation:

- Option A is correct: While the order was founded in Baghdad, it was Shaikh Bahauddin Zakariya who firmly established its roots in India during the 13th century, centralising its spiritual and political influence in the northwestern regions of Multan and Sindh.

Q 150. Ans. C

Explanation:

- Pair 1 is correctly matched: Firoz Shah Tughlaq established the Dar-ul-Shifa (or Bimaristan) in Delhi. It was a completely state-funded charitable hospital where skilled physicians (hakims) provided free medical diagnoses, medicines, and daily meals to patients at the government's expense.

- Pair 2 is correctly matched: The Diwan-i-Khairat was a dedicated charity department. Its primary function was to provide state financial assistance to poor Muslim parents to facilitate the marriage of their daughters, while also providing regular stipends to destitute widows and orphans.
- Pair 3 is correctly matched: Firoz Shah established the Diwan-i-Bandagan to manage his unprecedented corpus of roughly 1,80,000 royal slaves. These slaves were systematically trained in various handicrafts, absorbed into the royal workshops (karkhanas), or placed as personal bodyguards.
- Pair 4 is incorrectly matched: The Daftar-i-Rozgar was an employment bureau established by the Sultan to register and provide state jobs to unemployed urban youth in Delhi, not a pension office. The actual department responsible for distributing pensions to aged soldiers, religious scholars, and the destitute was the Diwan-i-Istihqaq.
- Additional facts:
 - ✓ Firoz Shah Tughlaq was a prolific builder who established a highly organised Public Works Department (Diwan-i-Imarat). This department was responsible for founding several major cities, including Firozabad, Fatehabad, Hisar, and Jaunpur.
 - ✓ To boost regional agriculture, he commissioned a massive network of irrigation canals (the most famous being the Rajabwah and Ulughkhani). In return, with the approval of the Ulema, he levied a special 10% water tax known as Haqq-i-Sharb on peasants who utilised state canals.
 - ✓ Unlike his predecessors, he took a deep interest in conservation. He extensively repaired the top two storeys of the Qutub Minar after it was struck by lightning and successfully transported two massive Ashokan pillars (from Topra and Meerut) to adorn his newly built capital complex at Firozabad.

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